

Psych 100 How to Plan Your Life

1. Between Order and Chaos

- 1.1 So you really don't have an option about whether or not you're going to develop a vision for your life. You can either develop a good vision or bad vision. That's your option. Or you can live out your vision or someone else's. There's no no-vision option. If you have poor vision, immature and hedonistic, that might be a good way of thinking about it, then the vision that you impose on the world is merely a consequence of your short-term whims. You're going to be governed by something, and you need to know that.
- 1.2 And there isn't much difference between being governed by something and being possessed by something. And that's a useful thing to know, too, because if you have any sense at all, you'd want to be possessed by the right thing, because if you're possessed by the wrong thing, you're going to be in so much trouble, you can hardly imagine it. And not only are you going to be in trouble, you're going to be trouble to everyone that you encounter. And that seems like a very bad plan. And it's not necessary. So it would be better to do the better thing.
- 1.3 And so I entitled this relatively brief course, Vision and Plan: Theory and Practice. That's a repetitive title. A vision is a broad theory, and a plan is a narrow and focused vision. And so a broad vision focuses to a point that can be implemented. And so what I'm going to do with you over the next hours is describe to you how you might conceptualize a vision in the broadest possible sense, so that you understand deeply why doing so is necessary, so that you understand the consequences of doing it properly and you understand the consequences of doing it improperly.
- 1.4 Then we're going to take that general conceptual scheme, and we're going to focus it down to the point where it becomes practically implementable. Because one of the things you might most want to do if you become psychologically or philosophically informed is to understand how you take that broader conceptualization and make it relevant and implementable within the confines of your own life. Then you have the advantages of the broader philosophical view, but also something to do that's extraordinarily practical.

- 1.5 And I would say that abstract ideas become meaningful when they're implementable. That's a good thing to know if you're ever talking to people and you want to motivate them, if you have a broad-scale vision. Maybe you're trying to organize people to engage in some endeavor. That could be your family or your business compatriots, your friends, any sort of occasion. You want to give them the general picture, but then you also want to be able to specify for them exactly what they need to do.
- 1.6 And what they need to do is how they need to transform the way they look at the situation and how they need to reconstruct their actions. And so we're going to go from the general to the specific over the course of this discussion. So we'll start very general. I want to present you with a way of conceptualizing the world of experience in the broadest possible sense, because that'll give you the initial introduction into why developing a vision is inevitable and necessary.
- 1.7 So this is a Daoist image of the world, and it isn't the image that people in the West are generally familiar with, because we tend to think of the world as material, but the world is not merely material, not least because the world is at least material and information, and information is not, it's not material in a reductive sense. The classic view of the world, even in the West, was more like the Daoist view. And the Daoist view is that the world of your experience, and maybe even the world as such, is made up of two components.
- 1.8 One, you could conceptualize as chaos, and the other, you could conceptualize as order. And in the yin and yang symbol, which is two serpents, by the way, head to tail, the black serpent is chaos, and the white serpent is order. And the black serpent is generally identified with the feminine, which is not the same as the female or the woman. And the white serpent is characterized as masculine. I'll describe why that is as we progress.
- 1.9 So what does this mean, that the world is chaos and order, in its, what would you say, initial differentiated conception? You could think of the world of experience as a transcendent unity, and that would be the unity of all things. And then you could think of that unity as falling into pieces. Each of us is a piece of an overarching unity. You might ask, well, what is the most fundamental initial breakdown of the unity? And the answer to that is, well, it's chaos and order. And it's always that, no matter where you are.

- 1.10 And so here's a way of understanding that. No matter where you are, there are things that are happening that you understand, and there are things that are happening that you don't understand. And the things that you understand, that's order. That's the domain of order. And the things that you don't understand, that transcend your understanding, that's the domain of chaos. And chaos is also the domain of potential, because in the things you don't understand is the possibility of new knowledge, new ways of conceptualizing the world, and new discoveries about your own nature.
- 1.11 And so you can be terrified of the things that you don't understand and you don't know, and you can see why that might be, because they can undermine you. But by the same token, in the domain of things you don't understand is all the potential of the world. So one of the things that you might think about deeply is, what would be a good rule-of-thumb attitude to have towards the things you don't know? And one answer to that is to be terrified into paralysis because of the necessity for change that an encounter with the unknown might produce.
- 1.12 And the other is to welcome it with open arms because the you that might emerge as a consequence of confrontation with what you don't know might be much better than the you you're stuck with now. And that's very much worth considering. How you conceptualize the stance you take in relationship to the domains of chaos and order, that's about the most important decision you ever make. If you're a tyrant, for example, you're going to be allied 100% with what you already know.
- 1.13 Now, the price you pay for that is that you forego transformation. Another price you pay for that is, if you're tyrannical in your alliance with what you already understand, you're going to attempt to force that on other people. And part of the reason you do that is because you don't have enough faith in your own ability to confront what you don't understand and change. It's not wise unless, well, I suppose you could envision a situation where you should only abide by what you know. And I would say, if your life is absolutely perfect in all of its manifestations and you couldn't dream of having anything better, then you can stick with what you've got.
- 1.14 But if it isn't, then there's always the possibility that a little more transformation on your part might be a good thing. Now, there's a deep level of conceptualization that goes along with that, too, which is, how should you construe the domain of possibility or

potential? And I suppose you might say that this is a question of faith because the future is unknown and indeterminate, it's very difficult to make any final decisions about its nature.

1.15 But you can make a meta-decision, you might say, that the domain of potential, if confronted properly, is positive, and that you could establish a relationship with it that would bring benefit to you. That's really the attitude that children have towards the world, is that they're open to exploration and discovery within certain bounds. That's often shattered, that naivety. That naive openness of children is often shattered by trauma. And that tends to turn us into cynics. But that doesn't mean that the attitude was fundamentally inappropriate.

1.16 There's a Gospel statement that makes the claim that you can't enter the Kingdom of Heaven unless you become like little children, which is not the same as staying like a little child, by the way, and the idea there is that you should strive to regain the attitude of open acceptance of what's confronting you as an adult, even if you've been hurt. Because if you've been hurt, well, then you could imagine that you're more afraid of what you don't know because you've discovered that it can undermine and destroy you, devour you. And it's very easy to become cynical and bitter and rigid as a consequence of that.

1.17 But as I said before, the price you pay for that is that you forego any further transformation, and you tend to become a tyrant. Well, unless you want to become a tyrant, tyrants tend to live in hell. So I wouldn't recommend it unless that's what you want. And you can be a tyrant to yourself just like you're a tyrant to other people. And in fact, that's usually a precondition for being a tyrant to other people, which is also a good reason not to be a tyrant to other people, because you will bring that attitude towards yourself.

1.18 OK, so what have we established? Well, we've established that you can think about your world of experience as bifurcated into two fundamental realms. There's the realm of things you don't understand. You think about that as unexplored territory. If you want to make it more biological, animals have to deal with a territory that they have mastered and understand— that's their home territory—and they have to deal with territories where the predators lurk, let's say. And animals tend to stick to their home territory

because that's explored, and they tend to be afraid of their unexplored territory because that's where they can be destroyed.

1.19 And so this notion, this metaphysical notion that experience is characterized by chaos and order, is also a notion that can align with a materialistic view of the world and the psyche as a biological phenomenon. Your nervous system is set up, really, to respond with security when you're in the territory that you understand and to respond with, first, fear and then curiosity when you encounter the territory you don't understand.

1.20 Now, for animals, that territory tends to be more specifically geographical, because, like, a wolf pack will have its territory or any given animal will have its physical territory. Now, we inhabit a physical territory, which is why, hopefully, you're comfortable at home and less comfortable when you make a foray out into the world to places that you don't know. But our environment is also conceptual, and so our conceptual environments are also divided up into the things we understand and the things that we don't understand.

1.21 And even though we can be at home in our physical territory and quite secure in our metaphysical territories, there are still domains that we don't understand, edges and frontiers. And so if maybe you have some primitive understanding of physics, but you could certainly appreciate very rapidly that there are physical theories, theories developed by sophisticated physicists, that transcend your understanding. And you could imagine that there's also a place between your understanding and those more sophisticated theories where you can almost understand.

1.22 And you could imagine standing on that edge of almost understanding and being curious and intrigued and enticed by the possibility that you might expand your knowledge. Well, you're surrounded by a metaphysical territory, a multidimensional metaphysical territory, made of all these different domains of knowledge, and you have some mastery over each of them. There are elements of them that transcend you, and there are frontiers and borders that you could stand on where you would learn.

1.23 Here's the thing to know. You get interested in something when you're put on the edge of what you know. That grip of interest is actually a manifestation of the instinct that drives you to learn. And you can see now and then that you'll encounter a book or a talk or a discussion that maximizes your engagement, and the maximization of that

engagement is generally a signal that you're in the place where optimized learning is taking place.

1.24 Now, people make the claim, especially in the modern world, that life is intrinsically meaningless, and that's usually a rationalist claim. I can talk about that later. But I'm making a phenomenological claim, which is that there's an instinct of meaning that signals that you're in a place that's the border between what you know and what you don't know, that grips you, and that that phenomenological meaning is a signal of transformation and of expansion of adaptation.

1.25 And in consequence, it's not something that should be eradicable by a kind of brainless nihilism. It's actually the deepest signal you have that you're in the place that you should be, if you're transforming into the next best version of yourself. So you don't want to forego a relationship with that, because if you do that, because you're nihilistic, let's say, and maybe because you've been hurt, then you're going to destroy your relationship with the process that could transform you and allow you to adapt to the world. That seems like a bad idea. And so it's useful.

1.26 People say that they can't live without meaning. And that's a very strange thing to say if you think about meaning as something that's only abstracted or metaphysical. But if you understand that meaning is actually a manifestation of the instinct that signals optimal learning or optimal transformation, then you can understand why you might die without meaning, because in some sense, if you're static, you're not living.

1.27 And if you also understand that meaning is the signal of optimized transformation, if you really understand that, then you're immune in some ways to the corrosive nihilism that says, "at its core, life has no meaning." It's like, I probably figured this out years ago when I was thinking about music, because music has the aspect of intrinsic meaning. If you're listening to a piece of music that compels you or that you love, and someone taps you on the shoulder and tells you that in the final analysis that nothing you do has any significance, if you have any sense, you're going to just push them away and say, yeah, but I'm listening to the music.

1.28 And music is a balance between chaos and order. It has an element of predictability. Otherwise, you can't follow the piece of music, but it has an element of unpredictability because if it just repeats over and over, you get bored with it very quickly. So what a

musician does is present you with a structure of order and then vary that in an interesting way within a certain set of parameters and captures your interest as a consequence. And the reason that you feel that as meaningful is because what music is doing is modeling the way the world actually works. And so that's also extremely useful to know.

1.29 You hear that music is a non-representational art, but that's actually not true. It's the most representational art because it specifies most precisely that the world is made out of order and chaos, and that meaning is the appropriate balance between the two. And so I would say, if you're conducting your life properly, so to speak, it'll have a musical element. It'll have that same kind of meaning and the things will fall into place in a relatively musical manner. You'll see in your life that there are times when you're in the right place at the right time, doing the right thing, and things fall into alignment all around you.

1.30 Temporally, they're timed well, and things seem to exist in a harmonious relationship to one another. And those are the times of your life that you would like to have more of, if you could only figure out how to do it. And well, partly what we're going to do in the next hours or so is see if we can step through understanding how you might manage that. All right. So you could say, to begin with, the world is made out of order. And what does it mean for things to be ordered? There's a very specific meaning that's useful to know about that.

1.31 You're in the domain of order when your actions produce the outcomes you intended. OK, so that's really what it means to understand something. If what you're doing produces the results that you desire, then you're somewhere you understand. If you're out with your friends, hypothetically, you're there to have a good time. If you're in a conversation with them and the conversation is flowing smoothly, everyone's happy and laughing, then your emotions signal to you that the territory defined by you and your friends and your interaction is familiar and comfortable and promising.

1.32 It's the same thing if you have a meal with your family and it's going well. Now, maybe you have a meal with your family at a vacation and someone throws something untoward on the table, which often happens in family gatherings. Some unresolved issue comes up, for one reason or another, like it might habitually. That's the emergence

of unexplored territory into the domain of what's predictable and positive. And that produces all sorts of emotional reactions, often negative, especially if it happens involuntarily. So that's another way of starting to understand what it means to see the world in this way.

1.33 So you have what you understand, which is the domain that you inhabit when your patterns of attention and action are producing the desired outcome, and you have the domain of the unexpected, and then you have the border between them as well. So that's a good way of conceptualizing the world as such. And my proposition was that you experience the positive meaning that lightens up your life when you're standing on the border between order and chaos. That's the border of optimized transformation.

1.34 Because you might say you're best situated when you're firmly in the domain of what you understand. That's what people think when they pursue security. But the problem with security is that it has no element of transformation. And so you don't only want to be where things are going the way you want them to go. You want to be where things are going the way you want them to go, but where you're changing and things are changing so that they can get better. So it's an edge. You're not in the domain of the predictable.

1.35 You have one foot in the domain of the predictable and another foot in the domain of the unknown, so that you can make more of yourself while you're sufficiently safe. And that's why, that's what you do when you play, by the way. When you play, you manifest a set of skills that you've already mastered. Otherwise, you don't know how to play the game, but you want to play the game on the edge. That's why you pick a partner in a play about, that's a challenge to you.

1.36 Because you might think, well, if you're playing with someone, why not just pick someone that you can beat hands down 100% of the time? And your answer would be, well, that's no fun. And the question about that is, well, why is it no fun if the aim of the game is to win? Why not pick a partner that you can beat 100% of the time? Because then you win. And the answer is, in the pursuit of that narrow, certain victory, you forego the possibility of becoming a better player. OK.

1.37 So there's a meaning in security, which is that you can predict everything that's going to happen. And there's a meaning in the unknown, which is that you're put off your, what

would you say, you're thrown off your feet and you're surprised and threatened and anxious. And then there's a meaning on the border between those where you're secure enough so that you're stable, but you're transforming enough so that you're moving towards an optimized version of yourself and the world.

1.38 OK, so what we're going to do is to detail out the processes by which you develop the vision that enables you to stand on that edge. That's the plan. All right. Now, we live in time. We live in space, obviously. We inhabit our different territories, but we also live in time. And the entire expanse of time is also characterized by this relationship between the known and the unknown. Here's an example.

1.39 You may have memories that come to visit you of past troubles, and those will come on you involuntarily. And when they do, they make you anxious. They take the foundation out from underneath your feet. And the degree to which they do that is proportionate to how serious the chasm that you encountered. It's proportionate to the depth of the chasm that you encountered in the past. If you have experiences that hurt you, that you don't understand and didn't master and could still disturb you in the future, then those visions, those visions of the past will come to haunt you.

1.40 They'll haunt your nightmares. They'll haunt your daydreams. They'll destabilize you. You'll be tempted to push them away. And what that is, the reason that that happens is because your psyche is set up so that if you fell into a hole once and you don't know why, the more instinctual parts of you are going to presume that that danger still lurks in the future and will re-present those experiences to you in the hope of motivating you to develop the adaptive competence necessary so you won't fall into that hole again.

1.41 One of the things you do in therapy, one of the things you do with your friends and your family members or even with yourself, if you have some wisdom, is if someone has a problem, you try to walk through with them why the problem emerged, which might have something to do with the vagaries of the world, because things happen to us that are accidental and random, that are difficult and dangerous, but also that our misadventures may have something to do with the improper calibration of the way that we're looking at and interacting with the world.

1.42 And so when you're thinking about things that befell you in the past, let's say, you may have to develop a relatively sophisticated theory of the randomness of the world and

come to terms with that, but you may also have to determine as precisely as you can what insufficiencies you might have brought to the situation that made you more vulnerable than you needed to be. So, for example, if you were bullied as a child, maybe you still are concerned when you go to your workplace, for example, especially if it's new, that the same pattern might recur, and you might remember with some apprehension the misadventures you had when you were young.

1.43 And what that indicates is that, possibly, that you haven't redressed the insufficiencies in your personality that led you to be the victim of repeated bullying. I used bullying as an example because one thing we do know is that there is some stability in the probability that a given child will be a bully or be a victim of bullies. And so I'm not trying to blame the victim of a bully for the fact that that happens. I'm just saying that if negative things have befallen you in the past, it's wisdom to determine what it is that you might be doing wrong that's opening yourself up to the possibility that those sorts of things will happen to you.

1.44 And I would say, if you're characterized by patterns of negative events, then it's reasonably probable that you're bringing something to the situation. If it happens to you once, well, it's random. And maybe if it happens to you twice, it's random. But if it happens, if you have this same sort of relationship with an intimate partner three times, it's you. Right, and that's an uncomfortable thing to realize, and you can understand why a stance like that might be criticized in relationship to blaming the victim.

1.45 But look at it this way. Even if it's 5% you, maybe you should do something about it. That's a useful thing to know, by the way, if you're having difficult discussions with an intimate partner that you have now or a family member or a friend. If you're in a situation where your interactions aren't proceeding in the manner that you would find optimal, one thing that's very much worth doing is trying to figure out what it is that you're doing wrong. It's often very difficult, right?

1.46 Because if you're in a disagreement with someone, the part of you that's seeking security is going to want to insist that, look, we're having a fight here, but it's at least 95% you. And that's an easy—well, and anger will make you think that. Anger will also make you want to win. And the thing is, it might be 90% the other person, although on average, it's probably not. But even if it's 10% you, that's something that is under your

control and you could rectify, and if you did, might stop the 90% from making itself manifest in the other person, because you never know to what degree your imperfections are bringing about the conflicts in your life.

1.47 Now, you have to be careful to meditate on that because you don't want to take yourself apart, but you can learn techniques, and we'll talk about them, too, so that you don't force upon yourself the necessity of a transformation that's so rapid that it undermines you. If it starts to become too threatening, if the magnitude of change that you're apprehending that's necessary for yourself is too daunting, then you're biting off more than you can chew and you should try to change slightly slower. Maybe you should try to change at the rate that you find optimal.

1.48 And that's a good thing to learn about yourself. If you know that there's something that you have to do and you're not doing it, one tactic that you can employ that's extremely useful is to shrink the task. So maybe, I don't know, maybe your garage is a mess and it's been that way for 10 years and you can't get yourself in there to clean. It's like, well, maybe you should clean up one corner in a week, something like that. You can shrink the task until you'll find a step forward that you will take. And maybe if you're sophisticated, you could find a step forward that you would take, that you would take happily.

1.49 And this is a good thing to know, too, when you're negotiating, say, with your wife or your husband. It's like, you want them or you or the two of you to make a change. You can negotiate the change until you find a change that's small enough and interesting enough so you might both be willing to experiment with it happily. And there's a certain humility in that, right? Because one of the things I noticed as a clinician often was that, if my clients were starting to make a positive change in a new direction, especially in a domain where they had had some habitual weakness, they often had to start that change at a level that was so trivial that it was embarrassing or shameful.

1.50 And so that's where the humility comes in. There's going to be parts of your personality that are pretty immature, and the probability that you have to do something shamefully small to start improving that is extremely high. But one thing to know about that is, change accelerates. And so even if you have to start slow, that doesn't mean that that isn't going to start a process that will accelerate. And so even if your first steps have to

be embarrassingly tiny, that doesn't mean that you're destined to only take embarrassingly tiny steps during the entire process of necessary transformation.

1.51 Carl Jung said, "The fool is the precursor to the savior." That's why comedians are so necessary, by the way. But what he meant by that was that, if you want to make a change in a positive direction, you have to allow yourself to be a fool to begin with. You're going to do things stupidly and badly when you first do them, although maybe slightly better than you had done them before. And maybe even stupidly and badly is better than pure avoidance.

1.52 And this is a good thing to know, too, when you're negotiating again with your husband or your wife. If there's something that you would want from them that you think would help you strengthen your commitment to the relationship, you can negotiate with them until you find a small change that they're willing to do voluntarily, and you can allow them to do that badly. This is a very good thing to know, especially if you're with someone you're going to be with for a long time.

1.53 One of the things I used to do in my clinical practice was some relationship counseling, and one of the things I would recommend to my clients who were in a long-term relationship or married was to go on dates with their partner. And people were often very resistant to that for all, probably because they tried it a number of times and been burned in some way, or they'd say things like, "Well, I don't have to date because now I'm married." It's like, OK, you don't want any romance in your life? And then they'd go out and have a date, and they'd come back and tell me about how wretched and miserable it went.

1.54 And then we do a little arithmetic, which is always a useful thing to do in a situation like this, let's say. Maybe you want to have three intimate interactions with your marital partner a week for 50 years. Let's say that, or two. Let's go with three. That's 12 a month or about 150 a year. And over 50 years, that's 7,500 interactions, 7,500. OK, maybe you have to do the first 200 of them badly. And 200 is a lot, but it's nothing compared to 7,500.

1.55 And so if you're willing to let yourself stumble forward when you're improving things that repeat, you allow yourself that space for play and for error, then you can learn to incrementally master in a manner that enables you to become a master over the long

run. Another thing to think about that, too, that it isn't so obvious when you first apprehend it, is that your life in the main is made up of things you repeat. And we tend to downplay the significance of things that we repeat because they're everyday, right? They're normal, they're drab.

1.56 Coming home from work is a good example. You're going to come home from work five days a week. There's going to be a transition period from work that's 20 minutes. And that transition period is going to happen every day, and it's going to set the tone for the rest of the day. And so it's often the case that those transition periods are awkward for people, and they don't do anything about it. And that's a huge mistake. Because 20 minutes a day—we can do the arithmetic—that's 20 minutes a day times three. So that's 2 hours a week, let's say. It's 8 hours a month. So it's 12 work days a year, essentially. And so that's 5% of your life. That's 5% of your life.

1.57 If you get 20 things like that right, you have your whole life right. And so you look at the things that repeat, right? You master them. You make incremental progress to making them as perfect as they can possibly be. You negotiate with your partner so that that occurs, and you allow that negotiation to make itself manifest imperfectly and in a manner that's ridden with errors so that you can continually correct it. And hopefully, after you repeat it 100 times, you get it right. And you do that 20 times, and everything in your life is set, not only in order, but in the order that's on the edge of play.

1.58 Right. And you can do that. You have to think about it, though. You have to think about—I see this with parents and their children. You'll have someone with a two-year-old, and every bedtime's a fight. Well, you got to think that through, because parents actually only spend about 20 minutes a day in one-on-one interaction with their kids. It's a much smaller fraction of your time than you think. And if that interaction is bedtime and every night it's a misery, then what you've done is, you've made that whole relationship into misery.

1.59 And you think, well, it's only when I put my kid to bed. It's like, no, it's not only that because it happens every day. And if that sets the pattern of your relationship, that it's nothing but strife and foolish conflict, then, well, how are you going to establish a good relationship with your child and vice versa? All they are is a problem to you. And that's

not a good thing. And so, pay attention to the things that repeat. They're very, very important. That's your life.

1.60 People get obsessed about the exceptions, vacations, the special occasions in their life. And those are often a disappointment, by the way. And that's fair enough because, well, it's because people overvalue them, and then they go have the experience and it doesn't meet their expectations. And so then they're miserable while they have it and they have nothing but regret. And part of the problem with that, part of what's causing that, is that they're paying way too much attention to what's hypothetically exceptional and not nearly enough attention to what is normal and repeats.

1.61 And that's a form of pride, too, because you might want to identify with only the things in your life that are exceptional and not the boring and drab day-to-day things that you do all the time. But you could elevate those to the point of some optimized perfection. You could tell you're doing that, by the way, because you can do it in a state of play. And that's also a very good thing to know. It took me a long time to figure this out. I spent decades trying to understand what the opposite of tyrannical power was. It's not an easy thing to conceptualize, but I believe that it's play. And I think that you know if you have a situation mastered if you can do it playfully.

1.62 Imagine the situation where you're trying to put your little kid to bed, and that turns into a bout of play. Well, then you've got it, and then you do nothing but look forward to that. And that would be a good deal. If you were in a situation where you could do nothing but look forward to the things you repeat every day, that'd be a good bargain to strike with yourself. And it's also something to consider, too. If you have things you're doing every day that you dread, well, one question you might ask is, is there something wrong with your attitude? Because maybe there is, and you should dig into that and find out.

1.63 But another conclusion you might draw is maybe you're not doing the right thing. And then you have to strategize carefully, and that has to do with the development of a vision, about maybe you hate your job. And you think, well, I have to have this job because I have to take care of my family. That's a tyrannical attitude all the way through.

And you're blaming your family, so that's a real good deal for them. They're now the shackles that keep you in slavery to a tyrannical job that you hate. That's a lovely gift to lay at the feet of your family. There's a fair bit of pleasure of martyrdom in that, too.

1.64 And you might say instead, and this is what you can do, too, if you're trying to understand the obstacles that are getting in your way as you progress is well, why are you stuck with this damn job? And you got to think about that in detail. I had clients, for example, who were stuck in miserable jobs, and I'd say to them, "Well, let's take a look at your resume, your CV. Bring it in next week." And then they wouldn't. Then I'd have to

find out why. It's like, well, why do you not want to show your CV to someone?

1.65 Well, here's some reasons. You haven't updated it for 10 years. OK, so then, that's kind of daunting, right? Because it's actually, like, just because it's difficult, you have to sit down and go through your life and you have to structure that in a way that's comprehensible. But then, too, the problem with the CV is, you have to reveal everything about you that's embarrassing. Maybe you have to paper over various aspects of your stupidity with lies, and that undermines your confidence about the CV and about the job, say, the job interview process, because you have holes in your past that you don't know what to do with.

1.66 Well, you face that. You think, OK, well—you know, I had clients, for example, they had 95% of their undergraduate degree, and then they stopped. And there's a reason for that. I don't know. Maybe they didn't want the responsibility that would be attendant upon completing the degree. Maybe it was a good way of getting back at their father who forced them to go into engineering when they wanted to be an artist. There's some reason you stop with it 95% done.

1.67 And then you have to fix that because otherwise you're embarrassed about it. And if you're embarrassed about it, then you're not going to be confident when you go to your job interview. And if you're afraid of not being confident, you won't look for a job. And then if you won't look for a job, you'll blame your wife because you have to be tyrannized at work. That's a stupid game. And so instead of that, you might figure out, well, why the hell did you quit when you were within grasping distance of the goal? And god only knows why that is, but maybe it's something that isn't even true of you anymore. Maybe you outgrew whatever stupidity had made you do that 10 years ago.

1.68 To put your CV together, you have to put your past together. And maybe that takes two years. If you want to find a job you actually like, two years isn't too much of an investment to make. And maybe you're terrified because you're going to throw your CV

out in the wind and 49 out of 50 times it's going to be rejected. But then you could look at it actuarially and presume, well, of course that's the case, because lots of companies advertise positions that don't even exist because they want to keep a continual flow of CVs going through the system, or they advertise because they're required to legally and they already have a candidate, or it could be that, at this particular moment, you're not the best candidate for that particular—

1.69 There are a lot of reasons why you're not going to get the job, but they're true for virtually everyone. And when you know that the base rate for CV submission failure is 95%, then you don't have to take it personally. And you can think, "Well, I need a new job. OK, I have to send out." Well, you ask yourself, how many bloody resumes can you stand to send out a week? And that's a serious question, right? How much disappointment can you take? I don't know. Maybe you can handle 20 and maybe you can handle five.

1.70 There's going to be some individual difference in that, but you could consult yourself and find out. And maybe you're so afraid to begin with that you can only send out one. It's like, one is a lot more than zero. And once you've done one, well, maybe you could do three. And once you did three, maybe you could do 10. And you could settle on, I'll send out—you make a routine out of it. I'll send out 10 resumes a week for, like, a year.

1.71 And if you do that, if you've updated your CV and you're aiming at jobs that are hypothetically within your purview, and you have a good story to tell about why you would be the right candidate, and you can figure that out, too. If you have a good story to tell, you're not going to be nervous about telling it. So you got to ask yourself, well, why should someone hire you? And then you've got to discuss that with someone, your wife or friends, and have them hammer away at you until you know what you have to offer.

1.72 And then you can go in there with a bit of confidence and you can say, "Well, I don't know much. I don't have any experience in this realm, but here's a bunch of things that I've done. And here's the investigations that I've made about your company. And this is why I think I'd be a good fit, and this is what I can offer to you. And I won't be a catastrophe," which is the one thing everyone hiring really wants to know. It's like, what do you think? Can we do this together? And if you have an attitude like that, and you do

get an interview, which you will eventually, then the probability that you'll get the job has gone up substantively.

1.73 And so you don't have to stay in your damn rut, but you do have to figure out what elements of what you don't understand, that chaos and potential, are terrifying you into paralysis. And then you think, "Well, I'm terrified into paralysis by the magnitude of the job search." It's like, fair enough. You may have lots of things that you have to put right. Make a list of all the things that frighten you, right? Maybe it's 15 things. Then you can rank-order the list. This frightens me the least. Maybe I could try it. And if all of the things frighten you too much so you're paralyzed, break them down.

1.74 When I was counseling my clients to go on the job search, one of their first assignments was often "just open up your CV and look at it." And this was an actual contract, because when you're playing this game with yourself, let's say, you can't cheat. If you're terrified to go on the job search and you've motivated yourself enough so that you're willing to open your damn computer and look through your CV, don't sit down right then and start rewriting it. It's a violation of the contract. You're pushing yourself too hard.

1.75 What you should do instead is give yourself a little pat in the back and say, "You know, sad as it is, I was terrified to do this, but I did it." Right. So it's time to, like—if you have a child and the child does something new, you're not going to say to them, if you have any sense, "Why didn't you do twice as much?" That's a great way to demoralize someone. You also shouldn't do that to yourself. If you've taken a step forward, like, have a little recognition, and maybe you've got someone around you, if you're lucky, that you could tell what you did to, and they would be happy about it.

1.76 And that's how you distinguish, by the way, between the people you should have around you and the people you shouldn't. Because if you have people around you, and you tell them that you made a small step forward, and they make light of it or are cynical about it or punish you for it, you might think very hard about just who it is that you're hanging around. Because you want to be with people who note your progress forward and at least don't get in the way. And that includes yourself, that's for sure.

1.77 All right. So there may be some cleaning up of the chaos in your past you have to do. And you can note that. Imagine you have a goal, getting a new job, and you see that there are obstacles in your path that are preventing you from moving forward. And then

you see that some of those obstacles have to do with the past. Well, so then you have to clean up the past to the point where those obstacles disappear, and then you may find some obstacles in the present.

1.78 Maybe you don't think you're good at interviews. Lots of people feel that way. Well, then you have to practice that. That's a present problem, let's say. And although it may have its roots in the past, maybe you're not sophisticated enough to conduct yourself well in a job interview, but that's something you can learn. Write down 40 questions that you think

you might be asked. Come up with an answer, not a lie, but an answer.

1.79 Here's the problem with lying. Let's say you lie your way into a job. Well, then you didn't get the job. The lie got the job. And if you had to lie to get the job, probably it's not the job for you. So then your reward is that you get a job that isn't for you and that you don't deserve. Well, that's a hell of a way to start a job. Why don't you start a job that is for you, that you do deserve, that you could do. That'd be a lot better plan.

1.80 And you might say, well, I have to get a pretty dismal job given my qualifications. It's like, you start where you are or you start on a falsehood. And one of the things, there's this phenomenon in economics called the Matthew principle, by the way. And the Matthew principle is, "To those who have everything, more will be given. And from those who have nothing, everything will be taken." And this is a reflection of a phenomenon called the Pareto distribution.

1.81 And the Pareto distribution works like this: progress is not linear. It's geometric or exponential. Once you start accruing money, the probability that you'll accrue more starts to increase. This is why a very small percentage of the people have all the money.

If you have a million, it's hard to make—if you have no money, it's hard to make a dollar. If you have a million, it's a lot easier to make the next million than it is to make the first million. And that continues. If you have 400 million, it's a lot easier to make a billion, et cetera.

1.82 This is true, by the way, for every domain of accomplishment. Once you've recorded one album, it's much easier to record the next than it was to record the first. And the third is even easier than the second. Success builds upon itself. And so what that means, and this is a good thing to know, as I said before, even if you have to start slow, that doesn't mean you're doomed to slow. And even if you have to take a job that's

beneath you—which is not a good way of conceptualizing it, by the way; if it's actually matched to your talents, you should be grateful for it— if you do a stellar job at that job, the probability that someone will notice and push you along is extremely high.

1.83 This is something also that people who are bitter and hold back don't understand. I used to get undergraduates come to work with me in my lab, and I had a lot fewer positions than there were inquiring undergraduates, right? So they were high-demand positions. And generally, what I would do was give the undergraduate who's asking a task, a real one, because I'd have some—maybe I needed them to go investigate some psychological phenomenon, make me a little report about it, a research review, and I'd give them that obligation or opportunity.

1.84 Well, if you are talking with someone who has resources that you might want access to, if they ask you to do something, that's not an obligation. That's an opportunity. And if you have the two things confused, you're doomed. If you regard the things that will move you forward as an obligation, how in the world are you going to move forward? So what would happen inevitably is that some of the undergraduates would go and do just a stellar job, and it would be done in two days. And then others would come back to me a week later and say, "Well, all these things came up and I couldn't do it."

1.85 And often the story was very plausible, because they had family trouble. I don't know what the hell the problem was. It was some real problem, or maybe not, but at least it sounded like a real problem. But then I'd go ask the people who did it, who actually did the job, and they had just as many problems. They just didn't let the problem stop them from doing the job. And so then I would hire the undergraduates who actually did the job and not hire the undergraduates who didn't do the job.

1.86 And you might say, "Well, that's pretty mean because those poor people had problems." It's like, well, maybe they had problems, and maybe they were a problem. And one of the things I noticed was that if I pulled people into my lab who were a problem, that was a problem. And it wasn't just a problem that I had to deal with. It was a problem that often infected the entire lab and especially demoralized the people who were doing a good job. Right.

1.87 And so, well, if you have to start where you are and you're grateful for the opportunity and you make the proper sacrifices and you work, then anyone with any sense will

notice that. And anyone you want to work for has enough sense to notice when you're doing a good job. Now, if you're in a job where you're doing a good job and no one is noticing, you should ask yourself two questions. Do the people that you're working for know that you're doing a good job? Because it's possible that you're doing things so efficiently that you're invisible and you're not very good at self-promotion, which is actually just communication.

1.88 If you're doing a good job for people, they need to know it. And one of the times that you can inform them about that is when you go ask for a raise or a promotion. You need a little list. "Here's a bunch of things I did that made your life a hell of a lot easier than it might have otherwise been, and perhaps more profitable," that you may not have even known about. "And if you produce an increment of salary of this magnitude or give me a bit more flexibility or a promotion or some other opportunity, here's a bunch of things I could do for you that would make your life even better."

1.89 It's like, if you have that story and it's real, and you present that to your employer, and they don't go, "That sounds like a pretty damn good deal. Are you sure that that raise is enough?", then maybe you should decide whether or not that's not the right place for you to be working. And before you do that, too, you might have already wanted to get your CV in order and to have started sending it out to see what sort of market demand there is for your skills, so you can tell your employer as well that you have other offers that are pending. And then you put yourself in a pretty damn good bargaining position.

1.90 Part of the reason, by the way, that women do not make as much money as men—it's one of many reasons—is that they're not as good as men at promoting their own accomplishments. It's part of being agreeable and higher in negative emotion. I saw this when I worked in civil service in Alberta, years ago, when I was a kid, 20 years old. I saw that the bureaucracy was basically run by 50-year-old women who did all the work, and all of that credit was taken by narcissists who pretended that it was them and took all the credit from the conscientious older women who were working. Right, an ugly situation.

1.91 And you could lay that at the feet of the narcissists for being manipulative and psychopathic. But those women should have learned that doing a great job invisibly is not a very good strategy. People need to know. And that means you shouldn't be tooting

your own horn constantly because that's just annoying. But it does mean that the people for whom you're doing a good job should know you're doing it. And you should also note how much reward you need for doing a good job. Because if you're doing a great job and no one ever notices, maybe you're conscientious enough so that that'll be sufficiently motivating for you. But most of us would like to be rewarded for a job well done on some schedule.

1.92 That's something else you can negotiate with your wife, your husband, your kids. It's like, one of you in a marriage is going to cook. Well, a little appreciation for that now and then tends to improve the quality of the meals, and the atmosphere around the table. One of the things you have to discover about yourself, and this is also part of developing a vision is, well, what's the reward schedule that's necessary for you? And none, that's not a good reward schedule.

1.93 And it's something to discover, right? Maybe someone only has to say something positive to you once every month. Who knows? Or maybe it's twice a day. There's going to be some temperamental variability that characterizes you in that regard. You're probably going to need to be rewarded more for things that you're just trying as well. But this is a good thing to meditate on. How much notice do you need when you're doing something good? And this is something to negotiate with your partner. When you do something for them, you can teach them to notice it, and you can also let them know what they need to say.

1.94 This is something else that's useful to know. Say you're having a dispute with your wife, and she wanted you to say something other than what you said. Now, that's what she's going to let you know, first of all. "I would like you to say something other than what you just said." "What do you want me to say?" Well, then she's going to say, "Well, if you loved me, you'd know." Everyone laughs when I make that joke. Yeah, well, it's too vague. It's like, "No, I want to know exactly what you would want me to say. If I could say to you what would make you happiest, what would that be?"

1.95 Now you're in trouble because you have to figure that out. Then you have to reveal that. Then you're going to be annoyed because you're going to say, "Well, that's not genuine." It's like, yeah, maybe it won't be the first 20 times. But maybe the person can get good at it, and by the 50th compliment, not only will have the words right, but they'll

also have the sentiment right. You have to let people be stupid about how they're treating you well to begin with.

1.96 The other thing you can notice, too, is that if your partner does do something that you really appreciated, something small and subtle, let's say, they sneak something good in just to see what might happen, if you're smart enough to jump on that, and you have to not be too resentful about their existence to do this, if you're smart enough to jump on that and say, "Ha, I saw what you did. This is how you greeted me when I came home. I got a hug, for example, instead of an immediate litany of never-ending complaints. That was a very lovely way to reenter the house."

1.97 If you're very, very—this is something that's very useful with employees, too, and coworkers. If you see someone doing a good job and you say, "Hey, here's what you did," and you say it in detail, "I saw that and it was good," man, you do that a hundred times if you're running a restaurant, you do that to your employees, any of the employees worth keeping, they'll be working themselves to the bone to get another reward like that. People really like that.

1.98 The Skinner, the Skinner behavioral psychologist, could train animals to do anything. He trained pigeons to guide guided missiles over enemy territory by pecking on photographs. That's hard. Skinner noticed that reward was the most effective form of behavioral transformation, but it was subtle, because to reward an animal for doing something you want it to do, you have to wait around until it does the thing, and then you have to reward them.

1.99 And so this is the same in your household. If you're watching your kids, maybe your kid by accident cleaned something up one day. You can notice that. You say, look, maybe they're five. "That was the sort of thing an eight-year-old would do. Good work, kid. Here's what you did." They'll smile like mad. And the probability that they'll do something like that again radically magnifies. And kids are very good at generalizing, too. So not only will they do that thing again, but they'll do things in that category again.

1.100 And that's a fun way of interacting with people in your family, because targeted reward is a pleasure to give and also to receive. And so it's a great way of establishing harmony in your household without the scraps, the fights that might otherwise be necessary. Sometimes you have to settle something, and that requires dredging up all sorts of

things that everyone perhaps would rather leave buried, and attempting to sort through them. That's quite demanding. But targeted reward requires attention, but it's extremely effective and it's a very pleasant thing to engage in.

1.101 All right, so there may be things in your present that you have to sort out. Maybe you have to find your damn CV on your computer. Even that can be a nightmare. One of the things I saw with my particularly disorganized clients was that I'd ask them to get their CV off their computer, and then maybe they'd bring their laptop in, and the whole bloody thing was just a catastrophic mess. There were files everywhere. The computer hard drive was a reflection of their psyche. Everything was everywhere, and all that was valuable was lost.

1.102 And so maybe one of the things that, the first thing you have to encounter when you try to open your CV is the fact that your computer is such a bloody mess that you can't find anything. Imagine that, just imagine that. So someone's in a job they hate. And in order to fix that, they have to sort out their CV. And to do that, they have to find it. And to do that, they have to confront their computer, which isn't that big a dragon. It's not nothing, but it's not cancer. It's trouble.

1.103 But then that's annoying and embarrassing. And so instead of doing that, they don't do it. And then they have the job they hate for 30 years. Right. Yeah. Not smart. And you could also see that there's a certain humility involved in noticing that your failure to confront the mess on your computer might end your life. Right.

2. The Walled Garden

2.1 It doesn't matter where you encounter chaos. It just matters that you do encounter it. And that's also a good thing to know. And what that means is that wherever you decide to take a step into the unknown, that's as good a step as any other place. So I'll tell you a story about that. So when King Arthur is sitting around the round table with his knights, they all go off to look for the Holy Grail. And the Holy Grail, it's like the promised land, right? It's like the kingdom of heaven. It's some item of infinite worth that exists out there, hypothetically. No one knows where.

- 2.2 Technically, the Holy Grail was either the cup that Christ used at the Last Supper or the cup that caught his blood when he was speared during the crucifixion. So it's the container of the holy liquid or the water that revivifies. That's a good way of thinking about it. The knights have no idea where to go to look for the Holy Grail because, well, first of all, they don't even know if it still exists. And even if it does exist, they don't know where it is. Now, they're sitting at a round table which implies that they're equals.
- 2.3 Each knight goes into the forest at the point that looks darkest to him. That's a very interesting thing to know. There's a domain of chaos and potential that's part of your life. And there's going to be entry points that frighten you. It doesn't matter which entry point you take. It's all leading to the same destination. And that's another thing to understand when you're trying to overcome the shame you might feel when you note how small the step forward is that you have to take. But if you understand that it doesn't matter because you're confronting—no matter where you confront the dragon of chaos, it's the same dragon.
- 2.4 Now, you might say, well, that's metaphysical and speculative. I'll say, no, actually, we know this, and here's how we know it. One of the things that therapists learned over the last 100 years, they learned that one of the things you do in therapy is you get people to tell the truth. That's a form of confrontation with the unknown. Because people will recite their story, and if they trust you, they'll recite it in a manner that they may have never managed before. They'll tell the truth about events, so they have to trust you. That's a form of confrontation.
- 2.5 Helping people get their story straight is part of what—that's their vision, by the way, of past, present, and future. That's one of the things you do in the therapeutic context, and that works very well. It's a form of exposure to what's unknown. If I walk you through something terrible that happened to you in the past, you might cry. It might distress you a lot. When you first tell the story, you're going to be all over the place. It's going to pull in all sorts of terrible things that happened to you. Once you tell the story and then you retell, it's how it's going to be much shorter and much more focused. If you continue doing that, you'll eventually get to the point where it's summed up by your conclusion. Then that whole bloody mess is going to be replaced by a marker that you can now use to step forward.

- 2.6 This is a good thing to know, too. If you're listening to your partner, and this is particularly true of men who are listening to women, women are more threat-sensitive than men. That means they'll bring up more issues. The threat-sensitivity that women bring to bear on a situation is instinctual rather than cognitive. And so what that means is, they know something's up, but they don't know what it is. And so that means that you have to listen to them wander around. And now, as a man, your proclivity is going to be, "Tell me the bloody problem so I can fix it," which is really what you're being asked to do. But the problem with that response is, there's no sense fixing the wrong problem.
- 2.7 Something you have to learn as a diagnostician, if you're a physician or a psychologist, too. You have to let people talk long enough so you actually know what's wrong with them. That can take a long time. If you're listening to someone who's upset, they're going to wander around because they don't necessarily know why they're upset, and they're going to stumble upon a bunch of things they think they might be upset about, and some of those might be you. And so that's annoying. But you have to let the wandering occur until the person gets to the point.
- 2.8 And when they get to the point, usually what happens is, the point is actually smaller than the whole domain of problems, and then it's something that you can address. And it's the same thing if you're bothered. You can leap to the problem-solving stage rapidly, or you can do some investigation and try to figure out just exactly what the hell is it that's stopping you. That's a question you can ask yourself.
- 2.9 One of the purposes of meditation and prayer, the purpose of thought for that matter, thought is a secular form of prayer—if something's bothering you, you can ask yourself, this is a meditative exercise, what is it that's bothering me? It's a question, but you have to want to know the answer. And that's frightening because maybe the thing that's bothering you is trivial, but probably not. It's probably connected in some way with something that really bothers you. It's the same idea that every window into chaos is a window into the same thing.
- 2.10 Something that bothers you will be emblematic of all things that bother you. So they're frightening to investigate. But if you're willing to open yourself up, you'll see that fantasies will enter the theater of your imagination about what it is that might be bothering you. Maybe you're irritated at your boss. The first—why am I irritated at my

boss? What would I like to do? First fantasies that come up might be quite aggressive and violent, especially if you're very annoyed.

2.11 But your imagination will start to toy with the possibility of providing an answer to the question that you posited. If you are careful and you want the answer, you will circle around the thing that's bothering until you get to the core. You can usually tell you've got to the core because you don't like the answer. It's a good hallmark of truth. It's like, oh my god, really? That? Then you know you probably got it. Yeah, and that's part of the humility. That admission is part of the humility that's necessary to move forward.

2.12 In therapy, you often find that people are avoiding something. If someone has a panic disorder, anxiety disorder, and they're agoraphobic, maybe they're afraid of elevators. Then you can expose them in imagination or in reality to the elevator. Now, they're not afraid of the elevator, because who's afraid of an elevator? It's like, no one's afraid of an elevator. Then you find out about the fantasy, and the fantasy is almost always something like this.

2.13 Person with panic disorder has had heart palpitations, and a lot of them, and they're afraid they're going to die of cardiac arrest, and they have reason to be afraid of that because a panic attack produces a radical acceleration of heart rate, especially if you have a family history of heart disease, let's say, and your dad dropped dead when he was 40, and so you're terrified of anything that has to do with your heart.

2.14 OK, so what you're afraid of is that you're going to go in the elevator, and your heart's going to act up, and there's going to be other people in the elevator. And so then as you die, because you have this heart problem, you're going to make a fool of yourself. And that's the combination of the two things that are most frightening to people, like biological mortality and social exclusion. And so the elevator becomes a place where that confrontation is likely.

2.15 I had a client once, I got her right up to the doors of the elevator. We started quite a ways away. And when the doors opened, she said, "That's a tomb." That's right. Great Freudian symbolism in that because the elevator for her was a place of death. I think, "Well, an elevator isn't a place of death." It can be. For her to go into the elevator was no different than her confronting the fear of death. I would say, too, when you discover an obstacle that's in your path, that's a severe obstacle, and you look into it, that's

analogous in some profound manner to confronting the reality of your vulnerability per se.

2.16 Now, the disadvantage of that is that even small things can stop you. But the advantage is that, if you are willing to voluntarily confront the small things that stand in your way, you're simultaneously confronting the entire domain of things that you might be afraid of. And so what you see in psychotherapy, this was a revolutionary discovery because it wasn't what was predicted. When you encourage people to confront the small things that they're afraid of, they don't become less afraid of those things.

2.17 You could think they become less afraid of the specific thing they're exposed to, but equally afraid of everything else. That isn't what happens. They don't become less afraid. They become braver. That's not the same thing. Less afraid means the thing isn't as threatening you thought. Braver means there's more to you than you realized. If you become braver and you realize that there's more to you than you realized, that you hadn't noticed because you were avoiding, then you can bring that to every situation.

2.18 One of the things clinical psychologists noted was often women who were suffering from anxiety disorders who went through exposure therapy, they often ended up fighting with their husbands in the aftermath of the exposure therapy. It was because they got more assertive, because they were braver now in relationship to the things that were threatening them. They weren't so dependent on their husband, which was usually the alternative.

2.19 Sometimes people will develop panic disorder if they are dependent and a divorce is looming, because then they have to be alone. If you're dependent on someone else for your emotional stability, you're not going to bring up difficult issues with them because you're going to be afraid of breaking the security that the relationship, that the relationship constitutes. Well, if you get braver, you think, "Now I got a few things to say to you."

2.20 It's also the case, this is rather perverse, is that the husbands in that situation may well have been working at counter purposes to their wives' development, knowing at some level that, if their wives got braver, they'd bring up all the dismal things about the relationship and them that need to be brought up, so that they were covertly punishing

their partner for being brave whenever, "No, dear, you don't have to do that. I know you're not feeling that well today."

2.21 It's like, that sounds like care. It's not care, or it isn't necessarily care. It can be the worst thing that happened to you. It's the same with kids, is that maybe the right answer to a kid who is wondering whether or not he has the wherewithal to do something is, "Get the hell out there and try it." Not, "Yeah, I understand you're not having a good day." There's a devouring element to that excess of care that, well, has all sorts of devious branches, let's put it that way.

2.22 It's a good rule that people who care for the elderly use, by the way. Don't ever do anything for anyone they can do themselves. You're stealing from them. You're not helping them. It's one of the things you learn as a therapist. You come see me. Those are your problems. They're not mine. Now, that enables me to listen to you because I won't take all the burden of your troubles on myself, and you won't have to feel guilty about that. But more to the point, I don't want to solve your problems. I want to help you solve your problems because then you get to have the gift of having solved your problems. That is not something you want to steal from people.

2.23 If you're wondering as a mother why you have to let your kids suffer, it's like, it's so you don't steal their destinies from them. All right, so you have to map out your life, past, present, and future. Now, we generally assume that when you develop a vision, that the vision you're developing is oriented to the future. But if you develop a new conceptualization of who you could be in the future, it's highly probable that that's going to change the way that you conceptualize your past experiences and your present experiences.

2.24 If you do something that radical, if you are learning, for example, how not to be bullied at work, your story about your past may have been "innocent victim constantly pursued by psychopathic narcissists," and perhaps that's 50% true. But if you learn that there are patterns of behavior that you're manifesting that are making that bullying more likely, the story is going to change about your past, which is weird because you'd think that the past is fixed. It's less fixed than you think, is that, well, I was bringing to bear certain inadequacies on my part that were drawing out the implicit bullies in people, even when that wasn't necessary.

- 2.25 It means you're going to be taking some more responsibility for the past onto your shoulders, and that can be a real drag, especially if you had a lot of negative experiences. But if the consequences of that are that you've now paved the way forward to more future success, that seems like a small price to pay. There's an insistence in classic religious rituals. This is something deeply built into the Judeo-Christian substrate, for example, that you should confess and repent, that you should be, what would you say? You should bring your sins to mind.
- 2.26 You can understand how that's burdensome. When I went to church, when I was a kid, 13, and the minister was always railing on about the intrinsic sinfulness of man, I would sit there and think, "God, I just don't think I'm doing things that are that bad," which, by the way, wasn't true. But I didn't get the point. The point was, you should try to figure out what you're doing wrong. Why? So you can stop. And this is also something to know about your partner in marriage, too. If they're alerting you to insufficiencies, well, maybe that's because they're tyrannical narcissists and you should sort that out.
- 2.27 But maybe they've got a point. And it's worthwhile delving in to see. It's like, OK, what exactly are you telling me? Because it's going to come out as a vague accusation to begin with. I want to know exactly what your problem is. Then I want to know, is this your problem or is this my problem? If it's your problem, we're going to deal with that. If it's my problem, I'll deal with it, too. But I need to be convinced that it's my problem, and I need to know exactly how it's my problem.
- 2.28 Now, why would I want to know that? Well, if I have a problem, maybe I should fix it. One of the things that's happening in our culture is we continue to have arguments now about whether or not you're allowed to utter offensive truths. I would say any corrective truth is offensive. There's going to be stupid things about you that you're clinging to. Now, if you act them out, they're going to hurt you. Now, if I bring them to your attention and I'm oriented positively towards you, it's going to hurt you that they're brought to your attention. You're going to have to let a little part of you die, and maybe it's not even such a little part, and that in itself is going to be painful.
- 2.29 But the hypothesis is that we discuss things and try to sort them out because it's easier to sort yourself out voluntarily in the abstract than to live out your stupidity and die. Why is it necessary for people to be allowed to utter offensive truths? The answer is, well,

there's no progress without a bit of death and resurrection, you might say. It's in your best interest that your social situation is structured so that people can give you accurate, corrective feedback.

2.30 With a child, what constitutes valid discipline? Because you might ask yourself, kids, they're always zipping about trying to have fun. One of the things you find as a parent, and this is rather painful, is that half the time you're actually shutting your kids down when they're having too much fun. That's a drag because one of the things that's great about kids is they're running around having fun all the time. But there's times—they can't do that at a funeral. They can't do that at a restaurant. There's levels of fun that are permissible.

2.31 OK, so why should you have the right to interfere with that manifestation of your child's spirit? Parents ask themselves this all the time, especially if they're narcissistic and they don't want to interfere with the wonderful flowering of their child's independent spirit. And the reason is, if your children are doing something annoying, they'll annoy people. And if they annoy people, then those people aren't going to respond positively to them. And if they annoy everyone, then everywhere they go, all they're going to get is disapproval, inattention, and rejection.

2.32 Well, that's not a good deal for your kid. They're not going to have friends that way. Adults aren't going to pay attention. They're not going to teach them things. They're going to be displeased that they're around. If they do smile at them, the smiles are going to be, like, "Get this kid away from me." You can see kids like that, out on the street, in any stroll. If your eyes are open, it's very painful. You want to discipline your children when they're manifesting patterns of behavior that are going to interfere with their success in the broader social world. That's your job.

2.33 You and your wife, you might make one half-sane person, and if the conjunction of you two is annoyed by the misbehavior of your child, then it's possible that you're reflecting what would be annoyance on the broader social plane, and you need to help the child—I wouldn't say stop that, although sometimes that's the right response, but figure out how to make what they want manifest in a manner that's socially desirable.

2.34 If you have an aggressive little kid, for example, more likely if you have a boy, by the way, and some boys are really quite aggressive—the boys that are aggressive at two

years old who aren't socialized tend to be unpopular and head for a career of something like unrequited criminality. It's about 5% of boys. Most of those boys can be socialized by the time they're four. Socialized doesn't mean that they stop being aggressive. It means that they learn how to integrate their aggression into cooperative competition.

2.35 Then they become the sort of person you want as an athlete on your team. They can abide by the rules. They're going to help other people develop, but they're going to fight like mad to win. You can see that that's not an inhibition model of socialization. It's an integration model. That's the other thing that you're trying to do as a parent is help your child play a more mature game. You're not squashing their innate creativity with your tyrannical rules. You're teaching them a way of getting what they need and want in accordance with your temperament that's more sophisticated, so that it works in a broader and more mature and responsible social context.

2.36 It's a very different idea of what constitutes rules. They're not something you impose on someone. They're enabling principles for more sophisticated games. It's a good thing to know for yourself, too, because you imagine that there's some optimal level of discipline that you want to impose on yourself. Well, you may react in your life to discipline as if it's tyranny. It's just limitations on what you're allowed to do. Probably means you haven't got the rules formulated very well.

2.37 We're going to talk about this tomorrow when we talk about scheduling. If you're making a schedule that feels like a burden, you planned it inappropriately. To schedule yourself, to discipline yourself, doesn't mean that you have to carry around an arbitrary tyranny. The optimal schedule would be for you to plan days and weeks and months that you'd be thrilled to have. That's a good thing to know. People are often daunted by a Google calendar. I don't like scheduling. It's like, well, that's because you don't know how to do it.

2.38 Maybe I could sit you down and say, look, why don't you plan the best week that you could conceivably have? I mean, you're going to have financial limitations and all that, so we'd have to do it realistically. Or even a day. We could start with that. It's like, plan the tomorrow that you'd really enjoy. Then you can ask yourself, well, what time would I like to get up? How would I like to get up? What would I like to do after I got up? What

would I have for breakfast? These are questions you can ask yourself. That's part of the development of a detailed vision.

2.39 One of the things you want to do when you begin to develop a vision is to dismiss the idea that you know who you are. Imagine that your goal was to really please your wife. So you sat down with your wife and you said, "Look, let's make a schedule tomorrow where you can just have what you want and need. The best day we could plan." OK, so now you'd have to listen to her. You'd have to ask her, "What do you think you might want to do?" You'd have to listen and you'd have to admit that you didn't know. You can maybe make some suggestions and see how those go, but carefully, because you don't want to impose your view on her. You want to find out.

2.40 You want to do exactly the same thing to yourself. Don't be thinking you know who you are. That's especially true if you're profoundly unhappy with yourself. Because maybe you're profoundly unhappy with yourself because you have a very negative and pathological judgmental attitude towards something you don't understand. God only knows where you picked that up. Maybe you're depressed, maybe you've internalized an exceptionally harsh superego. God only knows where it came from.

2.41 But if you're damning yourself, well, there's probably things that you've done that are inadequate or even malevolent, and you should sort them out. But casting yourself into permanent hell seems to be something that you only do as a last resort, let's put it that way. And so when you decide to sit down and make a vision, and a schedule, because that's where the rubber hits the road, you might think, well, what do you want? Now, that's scary. Often people won't admit it. If you admit what you want, you can deny it to yourself.

2.42 If you have a pattern of self-betrayal, then you're going to be very unlikely to let yourself know what it is that you want. It's the same with your partner. It's often the case that people are locked in a relationship where neither person can please the other. And part of the reason for that is neither person will let the other person know what would please them. And the reason they do that is because they don't trust. If I let you know what I want, you have it within your hands to punish me in the most vicious and deep possible way, because now you can deny to me what I most truly need.

- 2.43 If you're in a marriage and you open yourself up, you're opening yourself up to possibility because if you do let the other person know what you need and want, there is some possibility that they'll negotiate with you so you can both get it, but there's also some possibility that they can use it against you. If you've been betrayed a lot in your past, it's going to be very difficult for you to make that trust manifest. But this is why you need some faith and some courage. And those two things are very, very similar.
- 2.44 You have to, arguably, put yourself in a position where you're willing to reveal your vulnerability to progress and to get what you most particularly need and want. There's not much difference between that and that exposure we were talking to before. Where are you insufficient? How is that blocking your path forward? How can you break that down into small steps that you're willing to undertake? That's a progressive revelation of vulnerability, of nakedness. That's a good way of thinking about it, too. So that's self-consciousness, to become aware of that nakedness.
- 2.45 OK, so we discussed the fact that your experience is made up of order and chaos, and we discussed the fact that you can stand on the line between them, and that that's an optimal place to stand, and that's the place of transformation. We talked about the fact that that balance between chaos and order characterizes the past and the present and the future. One of the things you want to do if you want to reduce your chronic stress load is to sort out your past.
- 2.46 Because one of the things your brain does at a very low level is it computes how much of your past experience didn't go the way you wanted it to go compared to how much did. And the more of it didn't go the way you wanted it to go, the more dangerous your emotional nervous system assumes your environment to be, and the more reactive you are to anything that's stressful in the moment. So one of the advantages to cleaning up your past is that you decrease your stress reactivity in the present.
- 2.47 Because your nervous system starts to calm down, assuming as it does, because you've sorted things out, that you've mastered all the dragons that bit you in the past. And then it presumes, well, if you've managed them in the past, there's a reasonable probability that you'll do the same in the future. At least you won't fall prey to the same problems. And so you don't have to be on alert to such a degree when something unexpected happens.

2.48 If you have memories of the past, traumatic memories, for example, that haunt you, one of the things you can do is note that, first of all. That'll be difficult because these things will come up and they'll destabilize you. "I don't want to think about that." Figure out what it is that you don't want to think about, and then think about it voluntarily. So one of the things you could do if you have a memory that's bothering you is decide you're going to think about that memory, visualize it for 10 minutes, say, before you go to sleep. Do that voluntarily.

2.49 If you do that enough, you'll signal to yourself that you're now large enough to confront that. So that's a good primary signal. But the other thing that will happen is, the fantasies that were surrounding that will lay themselves out, and hopefully you'll have matured enough, especially if the memories are older, so that you're in a better position now to determine what it is that you could have done in that situation so it would go better than it had gone. That's a—you can do that.

2.50 Anything that makes you bitter, anything that makes you resentful, anything that makes you anxious that you're carrying with you, that's a process, that's a place where you could enter that domain of chaos and sort out. And part of the forgiveness that might go along with that is that it's not exactly forgiveness. That usually requires a willingness to change on the part of the person who needs to be forgiven. But that ability for you to shed a load you might be carrying that's weighty is to reconstitute yourself in relationship to those events so that you can now see yourself as the master of similar circumstances in the future.

2.51 Now, that's not an easy thing to figure out. I mean, if you have a history of being bullied, it's going to take some real time to think through what it is that you brought to bear on that and what it is that you might have to change. You can usually get a handle on that by thinking about, what would make you afraid of confronting someone, say, who's rude to you? Imagine you're in a supermarket or something like that, and someone's rude. Often people won't say anything. It's like, they won't say something because they're afraid. Afraid of what?

2.52 Well, think it through. Exactly. What exactly is it that you're afraid of? Some of that might be reasonable. Here's something to consider, too, when you're dealing with things you're afraid of. Maybe you have a tyrannical boss and you're afraid to confront him.

Well, you need a strategy. Otherwise, he's going to push you and push you. You'll just explode one day. That'll be completely counterproductive and you'll get fired. That's not a good strategy. You want to think through what the problem is. Then you want to practice that till you have the routine down.

2.53 Now, how would you fortify yourself to do that? "I'm afraid of my boss. He reminds me of my father. He reminds me of a teacher I had in grade five who bullied the hell out of me. I have a problem with authority." It's like, well, what happens if you don't confront your boss? You're going to labor under that tyranny at work for the next 30 years? How afraid of that are you? Whenever you're afraid of something and you're inclined to avoid, one of the things you can do is ask yourself, what are the consequences of not doing it? And you really have to think it through.

2.54 The consequences of not confronting a tyrannical boss could easily be that he will get more tyrannical, you'll get smaller, your life will go downhill, and that will last for 30 years. You should really be terrified of that. Then you think, well, "I'm afraid of confronting my boss." It's like, fair enough. How afraid are you of not confronting him? Same thing with troubles in your marriage. It's like, "Well, I don't want to cause any trouble." It's like, you want to live with this problem every week for the next five decades? Because that's your alternative.

2.55 I don't like conflict, personally. It really bothers me. I don't like upsetting people. I don't like hurting people's feelings, even when they need it. But what I really don't like is having the same stupid fight forever. And so it's often the case that, even though it's daunting to deal with the issue, it's much less intimidating if you really think it through than sorting it out so you don't have to have the problem forever. And who knows? If you're sophisticated—

2.56 Maybe you can't approach your boss. Maybe the situation has gone too far out of hand and you just have to get a new job. But god only knows what you might learn if you actually had an honest conversation. You don't have to go in there hostile. You can go in there and just tell the truth. It's like, "I need to talk to you. I come to work every day. I'm afraid to come to work. Here's what happens when I come to work. It's making me demotivated and resentful. That's just not a good attitude to bring to work. Maybe it's

me, and if it is, could you tell me what the hell I'm doing wrong? If it isn't me, well, is it something between us?"

2.57 People will often try to avoid a conversation like that, which is why you probably have to schedule it, and you have to have an alternative at hand. You probably can't have a difficult conversation with your boss unless you're prepared to lose your job. That doesn't mean that's your plan, but it means it's something that you should have prepared for. Because if you want to have a difficult conversation, you have to prepare for the worst, because otherwise you won't have the courage to do it. Maybe you don't want the worst, but if you're prepared for it, you won't be terrified of it.

2.58 Then maybe you can sort the damn problem out. Maybe—it's often, not always, but it's at least sometimes the case that a pattern like that can be based on a misunderstanding. Maybe your boss has no idea what the hell you do, or you did something stupid once, and that's the only time they ever noticed you, and now you're stuck with that reputation forever. Maybe he's a son of a bitch and you have to go somewhere else.

2.59 Or maybe you have to learn how to turn someone like that into an ally because there are times when people who are harsh and judgmental, as long as they're honest and can be worked with, they can be very good people to work with because they'll tell you what the hell is going on. So, and maybe you have to grow up a bit so that you can deal with people who are a bit more harsh and abrasive. Who the hell knows? That's why, when you go into a situation like that, what you really want to do is just tell the truth. Because then you'll see what the situation is and, hopefully, you'll see the pathway forward.

2.60 You don't want to go in there assuming that it's him or assuming that it's you. You want to go there thinking, "I don't know what the hell is going on here, but it's not working out very well for either of us because I'm not motivated to come to work. So I'm certainly not doing my best for you. So do you think we can fix this?" If you're stuck working with someone who you can't talk to, really, and you try repeatedly, it's like, probably you should go somewhere else. It's like, you're not being rewarded for the things you do right. You're being punished for things that you don't do wrong. There's no real

possibility for communication or advancement. It's like, well, what the hell are you doing there?

2.61 "Well, I don't think I can get another job." It's like, you don't think you can get another job you hate? You probably can. Yeah, right. All right. Now, imagine that there's this domain of things you understand. Then you imagine there's a domain of things you don't understand. Then imagine that the domain of things you don't understand is a lot bigger. Because your ignorance is disproportionately large compared to your knowledge.

2.62 There's a lot of things about the world that you don't know. You go on an airplane; you have no idea how the airplane works. You drive your car; you have no idea how your car works. Use your computer. If it doesn't work, maybe there's some things you can do, you can randomly hit buttons. If it fundamentally doesn't work, you're not going to be able to fix it. You're surrounded by things you don't understand all the time. The domain of chaotic potential is much larger than you are.

2.63 There's an interesting question there, which is, well, if most of the world is made out of things that you don't understand, how the hell is it that you manage to maneuver in the world at all? If your knowledge is outmatched by your ignorance, how is it that you can proceed at all? That's the problem of adequate action in the face of infinite ignorance. The answer to that is, you frame the world. You frame them. And I mean this literally and metaphysically. You put boundaries around things.

2.64 One of the reasons that children will push you is because they want to find out where the wall is. And they want to find out where the wall is because they don't want to be dropped into the ocean and told to swim in any direction. They don't want to be dropped in the desert and told that they can walk anywhere for any length of time. They want to know that there's somewhere that's got defined walls. And the reason they want to do that is because the walls keep out the predators and the unknown, and the walls might enclose a space that's small enough so they can master.

2.65 This is a city called Carcassonne. It's in France, and it's a medieval walled city. Still exists, by the way. That's a relatively recent picture. And you see, why do people live in that town? The answer is, well, look at all the walls. And why are the walls there? Well, how about to keep away the marauding psychopaths and the wild animals? Well, that's

a good way of simplifying the world. How do you deal with marauding psychopaths and predatory animals? You just don't have them around. Right.

2.66 So there's walls within walls, and you see that very clearly. There's an outer wall, and then there's an inner wall. But then inside the wall, there are walls. Everybody has their own house, and the houses have walls. And because we wall off a small territory, so we don't have to deal with all of the insanity of all of our neighbors. We just have to deal with the bounded insanity of our family within those walls. We're continually walling off portions of the world till we find a portion that's small enough that we can hypothetically manage.

2.67 That's a walled garden. That's what paradise means. Paradise in Eden, well-watered walled garden. That's what we're trying to establish for ourselves, a walled-off space that has some natural dynamism in it. That's the well-watered element or the garden. We want the optimum balance of chaos and order within a constrained environment. Children push you to find out where the walls are, and they want to know they're there.

2.68 Another reason you discipline your children carefully is because it makes them secure. Because you might think, well, imposing all those rules on your child does nothing but limit them. It's like, well, first of all, you don't want limits? Here's a way to make your child miserable. You have a closet for them. There's 100 pieces of clothing. You get them up in the morning and they're three, and you open the closet that you filled with your largesse and you say, "What would you like to wear?" There's 100 choices. They're not happy about that. Who the hell wants to make 100 choices when they're three the first thing in the morning?

2.69 You take three pieces of clothing out of the closet and you put them on the bed and you say, "Which of these would you like to wear?" Or maybe two. Constrained choice. We also know this from the consumer literature. If you go to a drug store, imagine you go to a drug store, and there's four shampoos on the shelf and you pick one. What's the probability you pick the best shampoo? One in four. Let's say there's 200 on the shelf and you pick one. What's the probability that you pick the best one? One in 200.

2.70 It's very frequently the case that a surplus of choice makes people miserable. And that's part of the necessity for boundaries. Same with kids, too. If they have a toy box that's just jammed full of toys, they often can't even get play going. But maybe you put out one

or two toys or three, they can choose between them—and you can tell with the kids. Some kids can handle a wider range of choices and some a narrower range of choices. And it depends on their cognitive fluency and their openness and their neuroticism and their level of experience with the toys.

2.71 It's like, OK, so part of the way that we deal with the chaos of the world is that we erect physical boundaries. And we erect, see, and with these medieval castles, what would happen, too, or towns, is that if the outer wall was breached and the inner wall was breached, everybody would run from their houses into the castle where there are more walls. And so there were sequential walls that kept out the chaos. Here's a way of thinking about it.

2.72 So university professors, they like to think that they're intellectually daring. OK, so let's think about that for a minute. So first of all, to be a university professor, there has to be a society that is free enough and interested enough in the pursuit of ideas so that there are universities. That's one kind of wall. That's one precondition for that hypothetical intellectual daring that's already provided because very few university professors create their own university, let's say.

2.73 Then you have to have an economic system that provides financing for the activity. That's another wall. First might be a cultural wall, and then there's an economic wall. Then you actually have to have the university, like the physical buildings. Then you have to have the administration that brings in the students and that handles all the administrative details. Then you have to have an office. There's just sequential walls around someone who's well-situated in their profession so that they have the wherewithal to deal with the bit of chaos that's now theirs to manage.

2.74 Most of us in a complex society, the reason that we accept the limitations that are imposed on us by the necessity of the social contract is that we benefit to a huge degree by this sequential structure of walls that surround us that are often invisible, especially when they're functioning well, so that we're protected enough so that we can deal with the bit of chaos that we can bite off and chew. So one of the consequences of realizing that is that it's useful to understand what it is that protects you. It's useful to understand that you are protected, and it's useful to be grateful for that.

- 2.75 There's a philosopher, Thomas Hobbes. What was his presupposition? "Life is nasty, brutish, and short." The natural state of mankind is chaos and malevolence, disorder. It's opposite of the view of Jean-Jacques Rousseau, who thought that people were intrinsically good and that strictures and restraints corrupted us. Well, from the Hobbesian perspective, life is a bloody nightmare of chaos, and we need structures of order to protect us from the onslaught of what we don't understand. And a well-structured society does that for you.
- 2.76 Now, the Rousseauians would say, "Well, there is something intrinsically good about you, and you can be warped by required conformity with the social norms." And there's something to be said about that, too, right? Because corrupt power structures can harm you. But that doesn't mean that structures of authority per se are without their utility. And that's very much worth understanding. Well, if you understand something like this town. Your psyche is a reflection of this town. You have all sorts of walls surrounding the conceptual domains that you inhabit that are the presuppositions that you hold to be true about the way the world is constituted, and they keep the chaos at bay.
- 2.77 I'll give you an example of this. You're married. Here's a wall, your partner's faithfulness. It's assumed. Now, the assumption, so how does the assumption keep away chaos? Well, if you can assume your partner's faithfulness, you don't have to worry about the dissolution of your entire life as a consequence of their romantic entanglements. That's actually why you get married. I mean, it's not the only reason, obviously, but part of the reason you get married is so that you don't have that complication anymore.
- 2.78 You have someone in your life who's bound to you, so that you don't have to deal with the complexity of the infinite number of romantic relationships that you could conceivably have and that they could conceivably have. You might say, "Well, you're foregoing a lot of opportunity." It's like, yeah, possibly, although your opportunities for trading up or negotiating a better relationship are probably a lot more limited than you might like to think. But then there's no shortage of heartache on the dating market. Our general presumption as a species has been, you find someone foolish enough to take you and offer them the same favor.
- 2.79 And all things considered, that's not a bad solution to the otherwise chaotic entanglements of life. But the wall is, you hold to your vow and I hold to mine. And then

you can see that if that is violated, that everything comes flooding in, like literally everything. And that's traumatic. So if you're betrayed by your partner, for example, one of the things that you're going to ask is, "Did we ever have anything?" So you just think about that. Betrayal doesn't just wipe out the present and the future. It wipes out the past. It takes all of that past that you think you had a handle on and turns it back into chaos. Rough.

2.80 When Dante sketched out hell, so he showed hell as layers. You could think of hell as what's approaching as each of those walls are breached. Because when it's the outermost wall, well, that's a drag, but there's still an inner wall. And then when that one goes, well, the hell increases. Dante put betrayers at the bottom of hell. And people, modern people who are not very bright, think, "There's no such thing as hell." It's like, wait till you're betrayed, or worse, possibly, wait till you betray someone. You'll find out just how real hell is.

2.81 If you betray someone, you violate your trust in your ability to form a relationship. And then maybe you do that because you experience the freedom that comes along with the betrayal. But the price you pay for that is you reveal yourself to yourself as someone too unreliable to make the long-term commitment necessary for a stable life. That's a hell of a price to pay. Maybe you never recover from that.

2.82 I think if a couple dissolves because of a betrayal, some of the time it's a consequence of the fact that the person who's betrayed can't bear the betrayal and doesn't know what to do with it. But sometimes it's a consequence of the fact that the person who betrayed cannot see their way forward to forgiving themselves.

2.83 All right, so we were talking about walls. Well, you see the same thing in a house. Your house has walls, but inside the house, there's walls there too, because you're walling off smaller and smaller spaces. Something you do when you want to progress is wall off a small enough space so that the amount of chaos in that space beckons as opportunity instead of threat. So maybe you want to write a book. That's a lot, writing a book. You think you could write a sentence or a paragraph?

2.84 Here's something you could do if you wanted to write a book. It's like, make a schedule and find 15 minutes a day that you could use. Maybe you get up 15 minutes earlier. I don't know. Maybe you go to bed 15 minutes later. I don't care. Find 15 minutes, but it

has to be 15 minutes that you get to have. That's not that easy because other people generally want your time. You might have to steal 15 minutes, then you have to wall it off. It's like, well, how much could you write in 15 minutes? Well, let's say it's two sentences, and you do that every day. You have a paragraph.

2.85 Let's say you manage a paragraph in a day, even if it's a short paragraph. That's a page a week, and in a year, that's 400 pages. So even if it's half a paragraph a day, it's 200 pages in a year, even if it's a sentence. And so writing a book is a daunting proposition, but setting aside 15 minutes a day to write something— and then if you find that you're not doing that, you might say, "Well, I can't write in relationship to this book I've been thinking about." All right. Well, maybe you could negotiate with yourself and see. Can you write about something? Maybe the rule is, you have to get down 200 words. It doesn't matter what it's about.

2.86 OK, because that takes a lot of constraints off. Here, you can remove some more constraints. It doesn't have to be that good and it doesn't have to be grammatically correct. There's some more restraints that are gone. OK, now you start doing that. You find you keep taking off the constraints till you start to write. You think, "Well, that's not very good, what I'm writing." It's like, well, no one's writing is very good when they start writing. But after the 200th day, you might find out what it is that you're writing about. Then you can start to organize and you can start to edit.

2.87 Maybe you're discovering what it is that you actually need to write about, because how the hell did you know to begin with? You thought maybe you had something to say, but you didn't know what it was, which is why you're writing to begin with. You write to discover what it is that you have to say. So this is a good thing to know, that you can wall off smaller and smaller. It's a great way to get to know yourself. If you want to make progress in a direction, how small a step do you have to plan so that you'll take it? There's no difference between that and learning to love yourself. Those are the same thing.

2.88 It's the same with another person, too. If you have a child and you want to encourage their development, you keep making the task you set in front of them small enough till they find something they can do. Then you pat them on the head and you say, "Good work, kid." Then the next step they take will be firmer, but it might also be longer. I had

people in my clinical practice who were paralyzed into inactivity by terror, and so they were virtually doing nothing. I never saw a situation where it was impossible to break down a fear small enough so the person couldn't make progress, because a fear is infinitely fractionable.

2.89 If you don't want to have a fight with your boss, maybe you'd watch 10 minutes of a movie about someone having a fight with their boss. You can find something small enough so that you'll do it, and that's the start. There's a mythological trope. When the hero first encounters the dragon, the villain, the giant, the threat, he often turns tail and runs. You see this in the movie Pinocchio, when Pinocchio goes down to the depths to confront Monstro, this fire-breathing whale dragon. He sees them and he swims in the opposite direction.

2.90 And it is often the case that when you first encounter something that you're frightened by, you'll turn tail and run. But if you make that first thing small enough, you'll be able to find something where you will stand your ground. Really what you want to do is, you're actually trying find the place where you can play. Because I took my son to the Natural History Museum in Boston when he was three. He's this tall. And there was a Tyrannosaurus rex skeleton there. He'd barely be a mouthful for a Tyrannosaurus rex. And he wouldn't get closer than about 200 feet from that thing. And no wonder, it's like all eyes and teeth.

2.91 But you could see, he'd walk up to that perimeter, and that's where he'd stand. But he wasn't so far away he couldn't see it. He wasn't exposing himself to this. He didn't want to get any closer, but he found the edge. This is what you do if you're on the edge is you just stand there and pay attention to the thing that you're intimidated by. Just pay attention to it. And eventually, your nervous system will signal to you that nothing terrible is happening. And that means you'll calm down. And then you can take a step forward. And that's where you're playing. And when kids are playing, they're always on that edge.

2.92 The word Eve, so in Genesis, God makes Eve after he makes Adam. The word Eve means beneficial adversary, which is a very cool thing to know. A beneficial adversary is a partner in play. If you're playing one-on-one basketball, you want to find someone who's maybe slightly better than you. Maybe not. Maybe your self-esteem needs a

boost, so you find someone slightly worse. Or maybe you want someone who's equally matched with you. But maybe if you're feeling daring, you find someone who's a little better than you.

2.93 Why? Because they'll push you to the edge of your development. That's what you want in a marriage. There's that beneficial adversarial relationship that can be established. If it's established properly, it's established in a spirit of play. The play is mutual, it's like a dance, which is why it's not such a bad idea to dance with your wife, by the way. It's a state of play, and the play is designed to facilitate the mutual development of the people who are inhabiting the relationship.

2.94 This is another reason we get married. I mean, we already talked about the fact that it keeps the chaotic catastrophe of continual romantic entanglement at bay. You could think about that as a security-seeking strategy, but then there's more to it than that, too. You know, if you love someone—generally, if you fall in love with someone, it's someone you respect and admire, and it's someone that you have, in that respect and admiration is, at least in principle, some regard for their ability to push back. Most people don't want to marry a doormat.

2.95 If you do, well, then you end up with a doormat and you can continue in your narcissistic ways, but then you can whine to everyone magnanimously about the fact that you've been burdened with this doormat. And I suppose that's some route to satisfaction. But it's a lot more fun to find someone who can push you a bit in a provocative way and to have that engagement continue to keep you both on the edge. That's part of the spirit of romantic attraction, to find someone like that that you can play with.

2.96 That's what little kids are practicing when they make cross-sex friends. They're practicing finding that partner in play with whom they can construct a shared vision, which is usually a game for a kid. You're doing exactly the same thing as when you're an adult, playing house, trying to construct with your wife or husband a shared vision. Here's a good way of thinking about that, too. People think you have to compromise in a marriage. I would say, you only compromise when you're not creative enough to come up with an optimized solution.

2.97 Because our deal should be, "I want to know what you want and need, and I need to know it honestly, and you need to know the same from me, and then we need to decide

that we're going to treat each other's necessities with at least as much seriousness as we treat our own." Then you might think, well, that dooms us to compromise. It's like, no. There's a game you could play by yourself, and there's a game I could play by myself. But if we get together and we put our heads together and we communicate honestly, we might be able to come up with a game that we could play together that would be better than any game we could play apart.

2.98 Well, that's what you're hoping for when you get married. And so that's what you want to do when you're negotiating with your wife. It's like, "OK, I'm going to come home every day. What, if you could imagine that when I come home, that goes perfectly, what would that look like?" That's a literal question. Now you have to go away and you have to imagine that. OK, so you get to have your wildest dream. Your husband comes home and you're happy about it. OK, what has to happen in detail?

2.99 I mean, sometimes when people come home, they're hungry. It's like, well, maybe you need to make him something to eat or vice versa, or maybe there has to be something in the fridge so that he could eat or you could eat. Maybe you have to decide that the first thing he does or you do when you come home is have something to eat. Then maybe you need 10 minutes to unwind, who knows? Or maybe you need a hug when you come to the door. I don't know exactly what it is. You could play around and find out.

But what would be the goal?

2.100 Well, let's say you want to make the transition. You want your person to be happy that they're coming home. You don't want to greet them at the door with a whole bunch of problems after they've had a whole day of work and they're probably tired. That's a stupid strategy. They're tired and hungry, possibly. Well, figure out how to fix that. Then maybe you need to talk about the things that happened during the day, for how long? Three hours? Hopefully not. Zero? That seems like a little too short. 15 minutes, 20 minutes?

2.101 Well, if you do that after the person has a shower and has had something to eat, they're going to be a lot easier to get along with. Here's a funny stat. If you go in front of a judge for parole, you're something like 60% more likely to be granted parole after lunch than before lunch. So this is just a good thing to know, too. If you want something from your husband, feed him something first. It's a sneaky trick, but you get my point. So you

could negotiate a solution to the problem of coming home. But the solution should be not a compromise.

2.102 He needs a rest and you need to talk, and so he has to listen to you while he's resting. It's like, a compromised solution, sometimes that's the best you can get because you just don't have the creativity to come up with a shared vision that's optimized. And so you have to settle for a compromise. But sometimes, especially if you set yourself at that task, it's like, well, no. What would I actually want if I could have it, realistically? And can I present that to the other person in a way that they might be thrilled? Thrilled is good. Thrilled to voluntarily agree with and to participate.

2.103 Then you can even put a boundary around that, like a flexible boundary, and say, "Look, why don't we try this out? We're going to do it stupidly for a while, and maybe we've got some of the parameters wrong, but we could try it for a week." In behavioral psychology, if you're a clinician, that's called collaborative empiricism. Imagine you have a problem, and we've talked about it a lot, and you think you've got your finger on the problem, and now we've also negotiated a potential solution, but it's an open question. You're going to go try out this solution.

2.104 Is it going to work? And so your assignment, which is voluntary, would be, why don't you go out and try this? Maybe you're very isolated in your neighborhood and you never learned to shake hands properly or introduce yourself. So you don't have any friends and you never have. One of the things we've done in behavioral therapy is to teach you how to shake hands and say your name. I tell you, you have no idea how many people are 100% isolated till they're old because they don't know that basic social maneuver.

2.105 No one ever paid enough attention to them when they were a kid. "It doesn't matter how my child introduces himself." It's like, you know what? Yeah, it matters. If you're expert at it, the probability that you'll get a positive initial response to people skyrockets. It's a nice thing to have at hand, a mechanism that enables you to go into a party of strangers and radically increase the probability that people will be positive to you. Imagine what your life is like if you don't know how to do that at all. You look at the person's feet, you offer a dead fish, you forget their name, you mumble yours. It's like, it's no wonder you don't have any friends. You can't get the ball rolling.

2.106 So maybe your assignment would be, go to the grocery store or the corner store that you regularly go to and introduce yourself to the cashier. And that's a great thing to do if you're in a new neighborhood, by the way, is to go to the local places and introduce yourself and ask the people about their store and find out their names, and then go there a couple of times and you start to establish a bit of familiar territory. And so you play with the imperfect solutions.

2.107 And the collaborative empiricism is, well, you're going to come back and report to me. It's like, OK, you went and introduced yourself. What happened? And one answer is, "Well, I couldn't do it." It's like, OK, well, then we have to practice more. And maybe I need to bring someone who isn't me into the office so that you can practice with them while I'm watching. You just narrow the task. Or maybe you come back and say, "Well, that went way better than I expected. We had a conversation, and now when I go in there, someone smiles at me."

2.108 For someone who's really isolated, man, that's a big deal. That can be life-saving. They've got at least one person who smiles at them. That's a lot more than zero. You can do the same thing with you and your partners. Try out the new solution and see, did it work? How was it for you? One of the things I noticed in my clinical practice, again, was that, in a marriage, you need to spend about 90 minutes discussing the details of your mutual lives with your partner, practically. What are you up to? What have you done this week? What's on your mind? What are the problems that might be emerging in the household? Are there things that we need to talk about? 90 minutes, something like that.

2.109 It doesn't have to be in one session, but you need about that much time just to keep things on track. If you don't do that, you might think, "I don't have the time." It's like, make the time or the time will come knocking and louder and louder. You'll end up taking the time in divorce court at \$500 an hour. That's not a good solution, especially if you have to negotiate custody of your children. So, 90 minutes a week to not have hell break loose, that's probably a good deal. And if you do that, then you might be able to spend 90 minutes a week playing.

2.110 Because the other thing you'll find, too, is on the romantic side. If there are issues between you that are unaddressed, you're not going to have any fun. So, that 90-minute

sacrifice, and then it's not a sacrifice either. If you understand that what you're doing is you're trying to see the small dragons in your house before they turn into man-eating monsters and you want to deal with these things that might actually take some work and be a bit of a pain before they get to the point where you can't control them.

2.111 But if you understand that while doing that, once you get good at it, the solutions that you both generate to the problems won't be compromises, they'll be shared visions of opportunity, then that can start to become something that's positive instead of something that's daunting or negative. Now, that takes a high level of mastery. But, hey, you've got 50 years to perfect it, so you might as well get at it.

2.112 And there's rules to this, too. I'll tell you a story. It's a biblical story, from the story of Exodus. So in the story of Exodus, Moses is the figure who frees his people from slavery and tyranny. OK, so one of the ways of thinking about that is, Moses is a representation of the pattern of existence that allows you to not be dominated a tyrant and to not be a slave. OK, now the Israelites are freed from tyranny, and then they end up stupidly wandering around the desert for, like, 40 years because they don't know what they're doing. And Moses is the person who they follow.

2.113 So that's another thing to think about what Moses is. He's the person that people who are lost follow. OK, so he stands up against the tyrant and he frees people from slavery. That'd be the person in you that could free you from your own tyranny and your own slavery. OK, near the end of the story, Moses has led these Israelites through the desert for 40 years, three generations, and they're just bitching and whining and complaining and squawking, and they're faithless, and they worship false idols. And like, they're quite the fractious and miserable bunch.

2.114 And he has to keep them all together as they move through the desert. And he's done a pretty good job, and he's done it for 40 years. Now they're near the end. They're on the border of the Promised Land. So you could imagine now. You've wandered through your

life, trying to orient yourself, and you can see the accomplishment that you really wanted at hand. You're right on the boundary. Now, the Israelites are on the boundary, and so is Moses, of the Promised Land.

2.115 But they're still in the desert and they don't have any water. And so they're bitching and squawking about the fact that they don't have any water and that they should have

never left Egypt. And who the hell is Moses? And what's God up to? And the whole thing. And they go to Moses and he goes to God and God says, "Ask the rocks to bring forth water, and they will." And so Moses listens to God. But then when he goes to the rocks, he takes his staff. Now, his staff is a symbol of tradition and authority. And his staff, imagine that you're the leader of a nomadic group and you have a staff, and someone's getting out of line. You just tap them on the head with the top of your staff.

2.116 Or it's maybe a shepherd's crook where your sheep are getting lost and you hook them around the neck and bring them back into order. It's a symbol of authority. It's like a scepter or a rod. And so that's Moses' staff. And it's a symbol of tradition and solidity. It's

a symbol of the center point of the world. It's like a flag. That's another way of thinking about it. Moses hits the rocks with his staff. And he does that twice, not once, twice. And God says, "Because you hit the rocks with your staff, instead of using your words, you do not get to enter the Promised Land."

2.117 And that's a hell of a punishment for someone who spent 40 years leading a fractious group of slaves out of this dismal tyranny. The fact that he uses force at all when he could use invitation means that he doesn't get to his destination. Now, that's worth thinking about. In your own household, now and then, maybe your children are misbehaving so badly that you have to use compulsion to rein them in. It's probably a sign that your disciplinary strategies are not optimized because you've let things go so far that force becomes necessary.

2.118 With your wife or your husband, if you have to use compulsion or deception or manipulation, instead of getting voluntary assent, you're never going to get to your goal. What you want to do, and this is a good thing to know, too, if you're running a business, for example, or you're trying to please your customers, is like, when I'm negotiating for a business deal, I'm never trying to figure out, "How can I get get the best deal?" Which would mean, I get a great deal and you don't get such a good deal. That's a stupid deal because, if you're too dumb to figure that out, then you're not going to be a very good business partner.

2.119 If I did pull one over you, well, once you figure that out, you're not going to be very happy with me. If we're yoked together now because we're partners, and I took advantage of you as my first move and put you in a lower position, now you have to

labor forward with that for decades, how is that going to work? How is that possibly going to work? It's the same thing. If you have to use manipulation or force to get assent from your wife for anything or from your husband, it's like, there may be times when you can't conceptualize any alternative, but it's a suboptimal solution and you will not get to where you're going if you use it.

2.120 What you want to do is, you want to make an invitation offer. It's like, OK, you have a problem. You told me your problem. How about this as a solution? Would that be OK? Well, maybe the answer is no. It's like, well, can you come up with a better solution? No. Well, then that's the best one I can come up with. So maybe we're stuck with that. And maybe that's the best you can do. But what you'd really want, if you got it right, is to offer a solution that the other person was thrilled with. It's like, "Yeah, I'd really like that." Great. Why don't we aim at that? Why don't we aim at that? What we'd both really like to have happen.

2.121 Sometimes, sometimes you can only do the best that you can do with what you've got. You come up with a solution that neither of you can improve on. It's like, well, if it's a solution that neither of you can improve on, well, that's not so bad. And plus, you can't fix it anyway, so you might as well go with that. But most of the time, if you use some imagination and you do it in a manner that's somewhat playful, that you can find a solution that you're both thrilled with.

2.122 And if you can't, make the problem smaller. And you can do this with almost anything. You can do this with how the dishes will be put away. If you're trying to organize your household, especially for the things that repeat, how the dishes are going to be put away is actually important because you're going to do that three times a day. So why not get it right? It would take 10 minutes of discussion. Maybe your wife is more finicky than you are about certain things, which is usually the case because women are a little bit more orderly on average than men. But what difference does it make, if you have to go that extra 2 seconds of step, and it produces an optimized solution?

2.123 Your whole household is full of little micro problems like that, and the micro problems that repeat should be amenable to an optimized solution. And part of what you want to do when you're playing house is to get all those little solutions right. And then the other thing, too, is if you get all those trivial things in order, then that actually frees you up so

that when you do have an exceptional opportunity, you can take it and maybe actually enjoy it. Maybe you can invite your extended family over to your house, and there aren't a lot of dragons under the carpets and skeletons in the closet.

2.124

So when people come into your house, they don't have to cringe and hide because of all the things that haven't been spoken about in the household or lurking around like dread ghosts. And you can actually entertain people and you're happy they're there, because your wife isn't acting like she's a domestic drudge and you're not acting like someone who's just being taken advantage of, so her miserable family can visit, you know. And so, yeah.

3. Desire and Discipline

3.1

All right. Well, how else do we put up walls? We organize ourselves politically, right? And so we have hierarchies of social organization that surround us. And we've figured out how to formalize that so we can have conflicts and compete and cooperate without degenerating into absolute chaos. And then we also frame the world with our bodies. So part of the way that we solve the problem of the fact that we're surrounded by an infinite amount of that which we do not understand is that we can't see that much. You hear what you hear, but not everything. And you see what you see, but by no means everything.

3.2

What you focus on visually is a very, very tiny percentage of what you could conceivably see. You don't see what's behind you. You don't see what's to the side of you. If I'm looking at you, I'm not looking at you, right? So even that focal perception restricts. Our bodies are—what did Huxley say? Who's the philosopher? I can't remember his name at the moment. Huxley wrote about this in *The Doors of Perception*, is that there's a world of infinite wonder around us all the time, but that infinite wonder is also overwhelming.

3.3

And one of the things that being embodied does is restrict our view to the point where it's narrow enough so that we can master it. You don't see more than you can understand, perhaps. It restricts it. And so embodiment is another invisible frame. It

excludes as much as it includes; it actually excludes more. And then there are sub-bodies, so to speak, within us. And you could think about those as instincts.

3.4 Your senses frame the world. So you see the world visually, you hear the world, you touch the world, you taste the world, you smell the world. Those are avenues of encountering what you don't understand, so you can sample them. Your motivations and your emotions provide you with the basic structures of understanding that help you categorize the world. And they're there to begin with.

3.5 So for example, if you say to your wife, "I'm hungry," she doesn't say, "What do you mean, hungry?" And the reason she doesn't say that is because she gets hungry, too. And so you can take that for granted. And the reason she gets hungry is because you have a biological system that operates within you. It's a subset of your body that regulates food intake and lets you know by craving when it is that you need to eat. And that's a universal experience. And it's one way that we parse the world apart instinctively.

3.6 And so if you're hungry, your goal is to find something to eat. And so what happens when you're hungry, it isn't a drive that propels you deterministically through the world. What happens when you're hungry is that your hunger takes a grip of your vision, your internal vision. It says, "Your goal is now to find something to eat." And so now you're set up in a perceptual frame that orients the world in its entirety around the task that you're undertaking, which is to find food.

3.7 And so the best way to think about hunger is as a personality or as a story. Hunger is the personality or the story that drives you into the realm of conceptualization that has food at its end. In the Exodus story, the Promised Land is the land of milk and honey. And that's partly because archaic people were hungry a lot, and milk is fat and honey is sugar. And when you don't have enough to eat, ice cream, that's sugar and fat, that's paradise. Right. And so when you're hungry, food is paradise.

3.8 And so, and it sets up—it's not a drive. It's not a deterministic drive, because if you're hungry, you might have to solve extremely complex problems, like how to share food with other people, for example, in order to eat. So the hunger is a sophisticated subpersonality. And we have a variety of intrinsic, instinctual subpersonalities that we

define as motivations that we all share. That's part of what makes us mutually comprehensible and fundamentally human.

3.9 And so various physiologists have broken these motivational states down in various ways. But one reasonable rubric based on biological analysis is that you have two broad classes of motivation. One is designed to make sure that you continue to exist. Those are self-preservation motivations or self-maintenance, and the others are reproductive. And so, there's you, and you have to keep yourself going, but there's you in the social world, right? So you need a mate, and you to get along with other people.

3.10 And there are different classes of motivation that serve those different needs. So in terms of self-maintenance, you get hot or you get cold. If you're taking care of an infant, you see this very clearly, because if your infant is distressed, it's usually because there's

some basic motivational need that's not addressed. They're hot, they're cold, they're wet, they're thirsty, they're hungry, they're tired, right? Or they need to use the washroom. It's something like that.

3.11 And so if you're taking care of an infant, you run through these different—is the baby too hot? Is the baby too cold? Does the baby need something to eat? Is the baby tired? And those are your basic initial solutions, and they suffice 95% of the time. And that's a good thing to know, if you have an infant. It's like, you go through the checklist. Even with little kids, it's the same thing. If they start to misbehave, they're often hungry—adults for that matter, too.

3.12 I noticed when we had little kids that we'd take them out to a social event, and after like an hour, they'd start to misbehave, and then we'd leave, and my wife and I would think, "It was time to go." And the kids figured that out before we did. It's like, the adults will get crabby 15 minutes after the kids get crabby. So anyways, you have these basic in-built motivations, and they're there at the beginning. And a two-year-old, for example, is really nothing but a bundle of those motivations. And one of the things that makes kids delightful is they just bounce through those motivational states, and they sort of appear.

3.13 If a kid's angry, some kids in particular, they'll have a tantrum. It's like, they're just 100% rage. I've seen 30-year-olds have tantrums. I tell you, man, you want to call the police when that happens. It's really terrifying because a two-year-old who's having a tantrum

is completely out of control. But they're, like, two. So what are they going to do? They're only this tall and you can just push them over if they cause too much trouble. But if you're 30 and you have a tantrum, oh my god, it's quite the terrifying display.

3.14 And so, a two-year-old will cry and be enraged and be hungry and then be so happy that you can hardly even stand it. Neither can they. And they just cycle through these motivational states. And there's a real purity in that and a real intensity that makes being around them fun. But they can't take care of themselves, and they're nothing but a handful of problems. And if you have someone who's adult who's like that, like, god help you. So it's just fine when you're two, but when you're 30, it's getting a little old.

3.15 One of the things that happens as a child matures, they have these in-built instinctive systems, and you might say, well, maybe that's good enough. And it's not, because the systems really present problems, but they're not that good at offering solutions. So when you're hungry, that's not the same as eating. It's the problem. The eating is the solution. The hunger is the problem. When you're thirsty, it's the same thing. These in-built motivational systems don't tell you how to solve the problem.

3.16 And sometimes the problem is that the motivations conflict. You see this sometimes. Like, are you too hungry to sleep or too tired to eat? And you can see that you can have motivational problems of your own. Maybe you hate someone, but you're terribly sexually attracted to them. So that's another place where motivational systems will conflict. And so what happens as you mature is that those motivational systems have to be integrated so that they can be satisfied over a long period of time, so they can be satisfied in relationship to each other, and so they can be satisfied in the presence of other people.

3.17 So maybe, you can see that with kids. So what are the elementary forms of socialization? Toilet training, because now there are lots of kids who are in grade 1 who aren't toilet-trained. That's become a real problem in places like the UK, is that we've allowed our families to get so fragmented that there are six-year-old kids who haven't been toilet-trained. Stunning. And you can see that if you haven't got that figured out by the time you're four, and that's really pushing it, that's going to cause a lot of social problems, to say the least. You're just not getting anywhere in life if you haven't got that under control.

- 3.18 And so you see that that's a place where a basic biological motivation has to be integrated into a pattern of behavior that's socially acceptable, so that other things that are socially acceptable, other solutions that are socially acceptable, can be implemented. And that's what you're trying to do with your children. This is a good thing to know because the Freudian model, which is interesting but wrong, is the human being—well, it is, but interestingly wrong is useful, right? And it is interestingly wrong.
- 3.19 So Freud conceptualized us in part as an id, which was a, what would you call, gathering place of instincts, mostly sexual for Freud, but instinct, instinctual compulsion and drive. And that would meet the superego, which was basically the social, patriarchal social community, potentially internalized, that says no. It's inhibition. It's like a Rousseauian model, in some sense, with a bit more negativity added. You're a mass of impulses. The impulses have to be met with control.
- 3.20 OK, but that brings us to the force problem. It's like, is it control that you're trying to institute on your children? The problem with that is, if you use force and control, they're going to rebel, or you're going to intimidate them, or you're going to, or you're going to, what would you call? You're going to make them into resentful followers of stupid rules they don't understand, which is also not a good outcome. You can do that to yourself, too, by forcing yourself to do things that you're actually not inclined to do. It's complicated because you want to discipline yourself.
- 3.21 So what are you doing? Well, you're offering the child a better game. As I said before, my son, when he was little, he was a pretty aggressive little kid. He had a good temper, and I liked playing with him. But now and then he'd get out of hand and get stubborn, and I'd go have him sit on the steps. And it was so interesting watching him, because, maybe, it probably happened from the time he was about 12 months till he was about two, something like that.
- 3.22 He'd sit on the steps because he, I don't know, he was enraged about something that didn't go his way. And the rule was, sit on the steps until you can play again, until you can act like a civilized human being that other people would like to have around. And so as soon as he would do that, he could get off the steps. It was so interesting watching him do that, because he'd sit on the steps with his fists clenched, his teeth clenched, and I'd go tap and say, "Are you ready to get off the steps?" "Not yet."

3.23 But you could see, so what was happening is, he was trying to integrate those powerful forces of rage into a personality that would enable him to maintain his social relations. Now, look. If you can imagine this as an adult, is maybe you're having a difficult conversation with your wife, and she's afraid to do that because you have a temper, which means that you're not well socialized. She'll say something provocative, maybe that's just related to an actual problem, or maybe she's given you a poke just to find out what kind of son of a bitch you are, and you can't control your anger.

3.24 And so what does that mean? It means that you haven't mastered the capacity to integrate the full range of your aggression into a sophisticated personality. That makes you dangerous. Part of the reason you see that in a developing relationship, for example, between a man and a woman, both partners will test each other out. And women will say provocative things to men. And men think, "Why the hell is that going on?" And the answer is something like, well, the women want to find out, if you're annoyed, if you turn into a murderous tyrant, because if you do, you're probably not the best person to have around children.

3.25 And that's a really crucial thing to discover. And so you don't discover that just by asking someone. You have to poke them a bunch and see. It's like, can I elicit something in you that's untoward? And that's a deadly game. And it's not even necessary that the people who are playing it even know they are, but people will definitely play games like that, and they need to because you need to know. And it isn't that you control your temper. There are times when you have to, but that's not right.

3.26 My son, who learned to integrate the part of him that was aggressive, became a very good athlete, and he's very competitive. He really likes to win, and his mother is like that as well. But he learned how to—that meant the aggression is still there, but it's replicated at a higher level of development that integrates it with all sorts of other things. If you want to be aggressive while you're playing a sport, you have to play it in a way that other people want to play with. Then you get to have your aggression, but in these walled boundaries.

3.27 And partly what you're trying to do with your children is to teach them the sophisticated games that enable all of their needs and wants to be met over the longest possible span of time in the broadest possible set of situations. And that's not inhibition. It's not

superego against id. It's the integration of those lower-order personalities into a higher-order personality that does meet all the demands.

3.28 And so maybe by the time you're 13 or 14, 15, you're sophisticated enough as a male so that you can do a good job playing competitively on a sports team, and you're a good team player, and you give credit where credit is due, and you don't take all the glory when you win, and people like you, and you're a winner, and that makes you attractive. And so now your self-maintenance goals and the integration of your personality has also made you sexually and socially attractive, right?

3.29 And so then you're playing a very complex and sophisticated game that meets all of the requirements of those subordinate systems simultaneously, and even more importantly, does that in a way that enables other people to do it at the same time, and maybe even better than they could if you weren't around. Right, and so, when you think your personality, you might think your personality has a goal. That's an interesting way of thinking about it.

3.30 You can see what your goal is, the intrinsic goal of your personality, by asking yourself to imagine what it is that you might want. This is a very good exercise. We'll talk about this tomorrow, practically speaking. But you could imagine, daydream, you know. If your life could be set up the way that you wanted it to, we're assuming you bring a bit of wisdom to bear on this. Well, what would that look like? Probably you'd want to have a partner, and maybe you'd want her to like you, and maybe you'd like to have a family, and the same thing would apply there.

3.31 You could get along with your parents. You could get along with your siblings. You love your children, and they would respect you. You'd have some friends. Well, if you could have the friends you wanted, what would that look like? And what would your friendships be like? You could do that with your career, and you can do that with your education. We'll step through this tomorrow when we talk about these things more concretely. But those are all those visions of what you want and need, if you're asking yourself honestly, are the collective voice of your integrated instincts that are attempting to lay out a description of who you could be if you could satisfy everything that needs to be satisfied at the same time.

3.32 Now, you imagine it's three in the morning and you've done something stupid and your conscience comes to visit; and it's bothering you because you are a fool and you know it. You might say, well, what the hell is that voice of conscience? Is it you? And if it's you,

why can't you just shut it off? And if it's you, why is it calling you to task? Why can't you just tell your conscience, "Reorient yourself there, buddy. I can do whatever the hell I want. I don't want to feel guilty about it afterwards. I don't want to feel disgusted or ashamed or that I'm lesser. Why would I bother with that?"

3.33 And if your conscience is you, in some simple sense, why doesn't it just listen, which it doesn't? And the answer is something like, the person you could be, if you were all the things you could be, is calling you to task for your shortcomings in relationship to that domain of possibility. And you could think about that as—one way of thinking about that is that that's your higher self.

3.34 Carl Jung made a distinction between the persona and the ego and the self. So the persona is what you show of yourself to other people. Now, that can be a falsehood, in which case you're manipulative, or it can be the sort of thing that you do when you go to visit the teller at a bank, because the teller says, "How are you?" And they don't really care. And you say, "I'm fine," even though you're not. And the reason you do that isn't because you're both lying. It's because the teller wants to see, "Are you sane enough to play the simplest of social games so that I can be reasonably certain that when I do my small task with you, all hell won't break loose?"

3.35 And so they say, "How are you?" And if you say, "I'm fine," they think, "Well, you got the basics down. It's probably safe to proceed." Well, that's what small talk is for. And you need to have a persona because lots of time when you're interacting with other people, they don't want to know who you are. You don't want to know everything about the person who's selling clothes. When you're on a bus and someone sits down beside you and starts telling you their life story, you know that's not good. You know that's not good,

put it that way. So that's the persona. And you want to have a well-manicured persona just so you're not a pain in the neck. You don't want to confuse yourself with that. You're not your social role.

3.36 Then you have the ego behind that. And the ego is more like who you think you are. And that's a partial thing, too, because what the hell do you know about yourself? You

probably don't know much about yourself, more about yourself than you know about anybody else. You're very, very, very complicated.

3.37 You just think about the internal machinery. All the subsystems that make up you, and then that going all the way down to the subatomic level. Man, your brain is more complicated than anything else that exists, except other brains. You're one complicated thing. There are more connections, patterns of connections in your brain than there are subatomic particles in the visible universe. So that's how complicated you are. And that's why your wife or your husband can hardly stand living with you.

3.38 And so the thing that holds you responsible, your conscience, let's say, that's what you could become. That's the unity that you could become attempting to make itself manifest in the moment. It does that all sorts of interesting ways. This is such a cool thing to know. It does that by calling you on your misbehavior. Now, your conscience can malfunction, because you can be socialized in a way that makes you too harsh on yourself, or maybe you've lied to yourself a bunch, and so you've warped your relationship with your internal guidance system.

3.39 It's another reason you shouldn't lie, because you program yourself erroneously, and then you will report falsely to yourself. And then one day you'll be in real trouble, and you'll need to know what's true, and you won't be able to tell, and then you'll be in real trouble. So one of the reasons you don't lie is because you want to keep your vision clear, because you're going to need it at some point.

3.40 OK, so imagine that your conscience will call you out on deviations from the proper course. OK, and I already defined the proper course. The proper course solves the problems you need to solve over the medium to long run and in relationship to all the other problems, for you, in a way that's maximally socially acceptable. It's a very complicated dynamic. It's something like being an athlete on multiple teams. Maybe it's something like being an athlete on multiple teams and performing well in school.

3.41 You could see that there's a pattern there. You'd be a good athlete and good student, and the pattern would be good. Good. Good athlete, good student, and then that would decompose into the various sports team memberships and the various academic disciplines that you're excelling in. It's a hierarchy. Well, that hierarchy of attainment is

your identity. And insofar as you've been true to yourself, then that's going to be successful and differentiated.

3.42 OK, so your conscience will call you on deviations from that path. So that's a good thing to know. That's like the voice of the higher self within. That's a religious phenomenon, one of the things you see happening in the Old Testament, for example, with the Prophet Elijah. Elijah is the first person in the Judeo-Christian pantheon who identifies the voice of God with conscience. So he's a prophet that stands up against the nature god.

3.43 So before that, one of the presuppositions of the archaic pagans was that the divine was embedded in the natural world, the force of nature. And you can imagine that. You go look at the Grand Canyon; it inspires you with awe. And you look at the stars and the ocean; you experience a hurricane. You could see that you could place divinity in the natural world. Elijah was the first person, at least in this pantheon of stories, who made a psychological interpretation, said the thing that should orient you most properly is the still, small voice within, the voice of conscience.

3.44 And so that's a very interesting thing to know, right? And you think, well, what's that a reflection of? Well, it's not you, as we said, because if it was you, you could control it. It's got an autonomy, your conscience. It speaks to you. It'll hold you accountable. Well, you have to ask yourself, well, what is it that's holding you accountable? And you could say, well, it's the voice of society within. It's like, well, that's not really much of an answer, actually, because then you have to ask, well, where did the voice of society come from? What's the derivation of that spirit?

3.45 Because then that would be tradition extending over thousands and thousands or tens of thousands of years. It doesn't really dissolve the mystery. If it's the voice of society within, it's the voice of the proper social orientation within. So then it's the spirit of proper social orientation. You still end up with the same problem. It's an autonomous spirit of some sort. And so it's the thing that will call on your misbehavior.

3.46 There's another element to it, too, that's worth knowing about. So I'll tell you another story. So this is from Exodus, again. So Moses is going about his business in Exodus as a shepherd. And that was actually a pretty admirable occupation in archaic times because sheep are hard to take care of and there's lambs, they're hard to take care of

and they're delicious. And so there's lions and wolves around the Middle East at that time and plenty of them. And so if you were a shepherd, you had to take care of yourself and you had to protect the lambs from lions. And that was hard.

3.47 So you were like a major league character if you could manage that. It was a relatively low-status job, but that didn't mean it wasn't difficult. You could see that it would be an analogy for protecting the vulnerable from the worst of all possible predators. That's why the shepherd, for example, is an analog to the savior, for example, in the Judeo-Christian pantheon. Anyways, Moses has left Egypt temporarily. He killed some Egyptian who was torturing a Hebrew slave, and he had to make tracks. And so he went to this foreign country, and he got himself a couple of wives. And he had a father-in-law he got along with, and he established a life there.

3.48 And so he's wondering around being a shepherd, feeling pretty good about himself. And something beckons to him. Something captures his attention off to the side. It's a burning bush. Now, it's not like an oak tree on fire right in the middle of his path. It's something that you could pass by. Now, a burning bush, what does that mean? Well, a bush is a little tree, and a tree is commonly a symbol of life, partly because life branches, partly because a tree is alive, partly because we lived in trees for 20 million years.

3.49 We have a very integral relationship with trees. That's why we think of old growth forests as sacred. We have a very tight relationship with trees. A tree is a symbol of life, a symbol of being, let's say, of living being. And fire is a symbol of transformation. And so, a burning bush is something living so intensely that it's in flame. It's a compelling—you know how compelling fire is. You can't take your eyes off fire. And so this is something compelling that calls to Moses, and he deviates from his path, and he goes to investigate.

3.50 OK, so when does that happen in your life? It happens when you get interested in something. And you see, that has an autonomy, too. Maybe you're 15 and you're in class and a new girl comes in and it's like, man, you're instantly interested in her. It's like, well, where the hell did that come from? It's not you. Not exactly. Maybe you're not even happy about it. I mean, that happens in all sorts of doomed relationships. You get

interested in someone, and it's hopeless and pointless or miserable and painful, but you can't shake it.

3.51 And your interest is a strange thing because it comes upon you. It makes itself manifest. It's not something that you create. You can squelch it. You can fail to follow it. But it's very difficult to elicit it if it's not there. I had a client, for example, who, he was with a woman that he really—she was a good friend of his, but there was no sexual chemistry as far as he was concerned. And he really liked her, and he had gone out with a number of women who he had plenty of sexual chemistry with and just horrible relationships with. So he was happy that he was with someone that he liked, but he couldn't get that spark going. And no matter how hard he tried, that didn't happen.

3.52 And the reason I'm telling you that is because you see that interest has a certain autonomy. It's something that calls to you. It's an old idea that people have a calling or a destiny. And one of the things I've done in my podcast, I get to talk to people who've had various levels of accomplishment. I'm always interested in how they got interested in what they got interested in, because something gripped them with enough force that they followed and became disciplined, and then that turned into success, right?

3.53 OK, so you find something that's interesting to you, it calls to you, and then you can establish, what, a relationship with it? Is that the right way of thinking about it? Likely. So what happens to Moses is that he starts investigating this. He gets closer and closer to it. Imagine you're interested in something; now you start to investigate it. So now you're getting closer to it. And as you get closer to it, it deepens. You know that if you have an intellectual, artistic interest. The more you study it, the deeper it gets. It starts to spread out, so it covers more and more territory, and it gets deeper, whatever that means.

3.54 What does deeper mean? It means you get closer to the basics, you get closer to the foundation. You get closer to the assumptions. If you start to get to know someone deeply, you understand their deepest motivations, the pattern of their motivation all the way down to the root. You go down the levels to go deeper. Well, that's what happens when Moses starts to approach this burning bush. He realizes he's starting to tread on sacred ground. So he takes off his shoes, and then he continues his investigation. That's a gesture of humility, to take off your shoes in that context.

- 3.55 OK, so now you're pursuing something that's interesting to you, and you allow that to change you as you pursue it. And you do that in humility, assuming that if you pursue this interest honestly, that it will lead you, it'll lead you to a better place. That's a good way of thinking about it. It'll change you. Maybe it'll burn things away from you that shouldn't be there. That's another thing.
- 3.56 That happens, for example, if you are attracted to someone, you may do backflips to sort yourself out so that you're more attractive to them. Because if you're compelled by something and you want to be worthy of it, you'll let go of the things that aren't worthy in you. Let them burn away. So that's part of the symbolism of the burning bush. Anyways, he keeps investigating, and then the voice of God itself speaks to him and reveals itself as the ground of being. So what happens is, Moses establishes a relationship with this thing that compels him, that's so deep that he now understands right what's at the bottom of things.
- 3.57 And that's when he becomes a leader. God tells him, "Now you can go and face the Pharaoh," which is not a trivial thing, because he's an absolute monarch of the biggest empire that ever existed up to that time. "And you can tell him that he's misbehaving and that he has to let his workers be free." Well, that's a major daunting mission. But the implication of the story is that if you pursue those things that compel your interest with sufficient depth, you'll get to the depths, and that will transform you into a leader, right now.
- 3.58 So then you think there's a dynamic there. Very interesting dynamic. On the one hand, you can pursue what you're interested in, what calls to you. You have to decide what that is, and you have to seek it out. And on the other hand, you can attend to the dictates of your conscience. Both of those are autonomous to some degree. They're outside of you, or deep inside of you, or both. And if you let that dynamism play out, that'll transform you across time.
- 3.59 And you might say, well, transformation has no direction. That's what you say if you're nihilistic, let's say. But we already defined a direction, which is that if you develop, if you're primitive, you're hungry and you cry, that's your whole strategy. And someone offers you food, and that works if you're two because someone takes care of you. But it's not much of a long-term strategy. As you mature, you have to determine how you

can take care of yourself. And you get better and better at doing that in more and more situations. And you get better at doing that in a way that makes you socially desirable. And there's no upper limit to that.

3.60 And so if you were everything you could be, you'd be welcome and useful wherever you went. And if you're not that, you will call yourself out on that. You'll go to a party and you'll be embarrassed. You'll be embarrassed that you're not as socially fluent as the ideal that beckons within you. And that can be a devastating realization. There's no ideal without judgment. But by the same token, that's the possibilities that reside within you making themselves manifest to you. They do that by capturing your interest.

3.61 So that's such a cool thing to understand is that this assumes, again, that you've established the proper relationship with yourself. This is why you shouldn't lie. If you don't lie, the things that will make you develop optimally will call to you. If you lie, you'll pervert that vision, and then you'll follow false idols. And that's not a good idea, because these are very fundamental orienting mechanisms. And if you interfere with their function by falsifying them, they'll lead you astray in ways that you won't even be conscious of.

3.62 And you can tell if that's happening. As I said, for example, if you have the same stupid experience over and over, that's a good sign that something's occluding or skewing your vision, probably something false. So that's worth considering. OK, so what happens here? This is the simplest story or frame of reference. That's another way of thinking about it. This is how you frame the world. Wherever you are, you're aiming at something. As you sit here, for example, maybe you're aiming at the information that you're acquiring, but maybe as you get tired, you're thinking, well, your vision will shift a bit; it's time for a break.

3.63 So the underlying motivational systems will shift your goal, but they shift your whole frame of perceptual reference. So for example, if you're hungry and you go into the kitchen, the kitchen makes itself manifest as a place to make something to eat. You ignore everything. You're not going to be concerned with the decor if you're hungry. Because you can imagine walking into your kitchen and looking at it like a design problem. But normally, when you walk into your kitchen, you walk in there under the influence of hunger. And so the kitchen is a place to provide food.

3.64 And so what you see are all the things relevant to that or all the things that will get in the way. And I mean this literally. That's how motivation transforms perception. You don't see valueless facts and apply a system of value to them. Your motivational systems set up your perceptions for you so that what you see in the world essentially are tools that will move you forward, pathways that you can walk on, and obstacles that are in your way, and everything else is invisible.

3.65 So one of the things you'll see, for example, if you want to set up a given room in a manner that makes you feel welcome, one of the things you can do is figure out what you do there, like what actions do you undertake in the room? And then you want to put everything in the room in a place that makes those actions the least amount of trouble. If there's a place you walk down continually, you don't want it cluttered so that there's even any visual clutter there, because if it's a place you walk down habitually and there's visual clutter, when you see the clutter, you'll see the clutter as an obstacle, and it will annoy you.

3.66 And you can actually do this in a room. It's quite fun if you're trying to fix up your room. You sit in your bed and you can think, "What in this room annoys me?" Right, right. And then you can see. You'll see, as soon as you orient yourself in that direction, you'll think, "Well, that's not put in the right place, and I'm always bumping into that, and I never seem to clean up that corner." And you can fix all that. And what you're doing is, you're organizing your environment so that the pathways are clear, so the obstacles are cleared away, and so the things that facilitate your progress forward are at hand.

3.67 So, for example, if you—that's why, in my first book, I talked about people about—what was the rule? Clean up your room before you criticize the world. Well, so maybe you want to organize your closet. That's a pain. It's like, take all your clothes out, figure out which ones fit you. That's probably annoying because you're not the man you once were, right? So you have to throw away all those clothes that only fit the hypothetical you from yesterday. And you have to make complex decisions about what's appropriate, what isn't. You have to figure out what the hell your clothes are for and what image—they're tools to maneuver in the world.

3.68 And you have to figure out what they're for and what you're trying to attain by wearing them, and if they're of reasonable quality, and every single piece of clothing has to have

that decision tree associated with it, or the piece of clothing will be foreign to you and you won't like it. You won't even take it off the hanger, and then you have to organize your closet so it's not annoying when you open it. It's actually a very complicated thing to do, because if you do it right, you put all your clothing in order, in relationship to your aspirations. So there's actually no way of organizing your closet properly without arranging your aspirations properly.

3.69 And so that's why you can start in a low place. It's like, well, my closet's a mess, and I don't get a big pat on the back for setting it straight. It's harder than you think to do it perfectly. And you should do it so that when you open your closet, you think, "Well, that looks like a civilized person lives here," and so that all the things that are there are things that you would hypothetically wear, or maybe would aspire to wear, and that nothing is in there that shouldn't be in there, which requires a very differentiating judgment.

3.70 Lots of people, you see this when they get older, their whole house is so damn cluttered, they just can't do anything with it. And it's a nightmare being in a house like that because there's 150,000 decisions that haven't been made. To go there and clean up, I've done that with my clients. It's like, you try to move one thing and they have, "No, that was my great aunt's from 1860." It's like, "Yeah, but you haven't looked at it for 30 years, and it's in a box in your kitchen, and it's been there for a decade." It's like, "Well, we can't do any—mom will be very upset if we do anything with that." It's like, yeah, that and the other 50,000 things in the house.

3.71 Every single one of those cluttered items is a fight that no one had. The whole house is just full of that. It's horrible. It's horrible. And your closet is probably a little nightmare like that, 300 decisions you don't want to make. And maybe you can't face the whole closet. It's like, fine, fix up one foot of it. But it's so interesting to do it as a meditative exercise, especially if you take the time to do it. Put six pieces of clothing on the bed. Maybe that's enough and think, OK, who bought these? And what were they aiming at? And is this what I want? And what for? And that forces you to start the process of envisioning.

3.72 So all of these little micro stories that your instincts pop up for you, and what you're trying to do as you mature is to integrate them into something approximating a maximally desirable character. And so that's not just an internal process. It's not merely

a matter of getting your act together because people say that, "Get your act together."

It's like, no, you're not getting your act together exactly, because there's you, there's your husband, and there's your family, and there's your community, and there's your state. And there's a lot more to you than the you that has to get its act together.

3.73 You have to establish harmonious relationships up all of those levels of hierarchy. There's no mental health that's just inside your head. That's not a reasonable way of looking at the world. You're not going to be mentally healthy unless you can get along with other people. You think, "How deep is this?" The worst people are psychopathic criminals. Let's say that. Maybe they're not the worst. They're up there, though. And you can take the worst psychopathic criminals, so the people who treat other people and themselves with the utmost contempt, and how do you punish them? By putting them in solitary confinement.

3.74 That's how social people are. You can take the worst antisocial person and punish them by isolating them. And you're not the worst antisocial person. So you imagine how important being properly embedded in the social environment is to you. There's no getting your act together without working that at multiple levels of social existence. There's no being sane in a toxic relationship. That's not going to happen. You've got to drop the idea.

3.75 Part of the reason that you want to treat other people the way you would want to be treated is because there's no difference between the two. So, for example, if you establish—let's say you go out of your way to be of service to other people, and you might contrast that with being selfish. OK, but what's the consequence of that? Let's think it through for a minute. There's only one of you. There's a lot of other people. OK, so now imagine you're running around, trying to make yourself the most useful possible to other people. OK, and you do that for, like, 1,000 people. Well, 900 of those people are going to be heavily inclined to reciprocate.

3.76 So now you've put yourself in a position where there's only one of you, and there's 900 people trying to do for you what you've done for them. That's a good deal. When your kids, when they're teenagers, they're striving to be popular. That's not exactly what they're striving for. And popularity isn't some sort of shallow virtue. It's like, if your kids can be of proper service to their peers, they're going to be surrounded by people who

are thrilled to have them around. Yeah, well, if you were surrounded all the time by people who are thrilled to have you around, you wouldn't have to be worried about your mental health. That'd pretty much take care of itself.

3.77 There is a corollary to that. When psychologists started to investigate the structure of self-definitional descriptors, self-definitional adjectives—sad, happy, dutiful, creative—they noticed that they clumped in bin. So if you're happy, you're more likely to be talkative. If you're angry, you're more likely to be sad. If you're creative, you're more likely to be interested in ideas. If you're dutiful, you're more likely to be patriotic. Things clump.

3.78 Self-consciousness clumps with misery, right, so tightly in the NEO-PI-R, which is a five-dimensional personality inventory, one of the canonical inventories, one of the facets of neuroticism, which is the proclivity for negative emotion, they all clump, the negative emotions, is self-consciousness. So here's the situation. The more you think about your narrow self, the more miserable you are. And it's not causal, exactly. They're not distinguishable from one another. There's no difference between being hyper-concerned with your immediate self and being miserable.

3.79 Now, you might ask, "What's the way out of that?" And you might say, "Well, stop thinking about yourself." And if I tell you to stop thinking about yourself and you try that, you're just going to think about yourself not thinking about yourself. And so you're going to be thinking about yourself nonstop. It doesn't work. One of the things you can do with socially anxious people, this is a good thing to know, a practical tip. If you're anxious at parties, you're worried about how other people are reacting to you, start trying to make them comfortable. Forget about you. But don't forget about you the way, like, consciously.

3.80 Focus on the other people and think, "OK, how could I make this person feel as welcome as possible right now?" Listening to people, by the way, that really works. You can ask people questions. There's so many people out there that never get listened to. If you can listen 10 % better than the typical person, you'll be so popular, you won't be able to stand it. So you could just start with—"I don't have anything to say." It's like, that's OK. Ask stupid questions and listen. People will be so happy, they'll just talk you to death.

3.81 OK, so your instincts, your basic motivations grip this whole perceptual frame. They establish the aim, but they determine what you see and how you feel about it. I'll show you how that works here. OK, so you're in one of these frames. What do you see in the world? You're hungry. Well, you're happy to see a butter knife. You're happy to see a loaf of bread. Those are tools that will enable you to fulfill the demand of the frame. When you go into the kitchen, your perception will narrow so that all you see are the facilitators of your desire and the obstacles. The facilitators will fill you with positive emotion, and the obstacles will fill you with negative emotion.

3.82 That's how you evaluate the world. You have a frame that sets up the perceptual objects. The frame has a goal and a starting point. The starting point is where you are. The goal is where you want to be, in hand with a peanut butter sandwich. That's your goal. And then maybe your kid comes in and wants to show you a picture and you're annoyed. And why? It's because you're trying to make a damn peanut butter sandwich. And so under normal circumstances, maybe you'd be happy about that. But because you're hungry and irritable, the child's offering appears as an obstacle and elicits negative emotion.

3.83 So it's very useful to know that. You don't see the world as objects and lay a structure value on it. The world presents itself to you as pathways, tools, and obstacles, and then everything else that's invisible, which is like 99.9% of everything. And then you understand emotions as soon as you understand that, which is also quite fun. OK, so you go from point A to point B. You're always doing that as long as you're awake and conscious. You're always on a journey somewhere, micro journey maybe. And you're always looking for things that will get you to where you're going and things that will get in your way.

3.84 The things that will get you to where you're going, they fill you with positive emotion. Two kinds of positive emotion. There's the kind of emotion that emerges when you get what you're after. That's satiation. So you eat a peanut butter sandwich, you're satisfied. The price you pay for that is the little frame you were operating in that gives your life purpose disappears. So on graduation day at high school, you're king of the castle, and the next day, you're, like, cap in hand, beggar, looking for a job at Starbucks.

3.85 But you see what I mean? So you attain something, and that is satisfying, but the price you pay for that, it blows out the frame of reference. It brings it to an end. That's what satiation does, and that's a particular kind of positive emotion. The positive emotion that you run on is more like hope. The thing that makes us exhilarated or enthusiastic or interested or curious or motivated is the vision that we're moving towards a valued goal.

3.86 OK, so now you've got to think about that because there's corollaries. The positive emotion that fills your life with enthusiasm and hope is experienced in relationship to a goal, not as a consequence of its accomplishment. OK, so the corollary is you should have a goal. Another corollary is you should have a goal that you can take steps towards. Because if the goal is so damn impossible that you can't take steps towards it, then the world just lays itself out as a series of obstacles. So if your goal is so stellar that you can't move towards it, you should lower your goal. You've bitten off more than you can chew.

3.87 And this is what you do with little kids. If you want to encourage them to do something, you set them a goal that's within their domain of achievement, but slightly difficult, so that they can move towards it, but it demands a bit, and they transform themselves as they're pursuing it. So a goal that you'll find optimally meaningful will do two things. It'll beckon to you. You want to achieve it. It'll produce positive emotion because you can see yourself making movement. But it'll be movement that pushes you to transform, so that the next goal that you chase will be better.

3.88 So that's another thing, why you don't have to worry too much about what you're aiming at. You do the best job you can. What do you want? OK, this is what I want. Are you right? You don't know, because what do you know? But you decide to pursue it. Then you break it down, so you have a name that you could hypothetically move towards. OK, now you move towards it and you start to change a little bit because of what you're learning. OK, at some point, you're going to change the goal. So you can hold the goal with something like a light touch, knowing that it's not final, but also knowing that even though it's not final, you should pursue it.

3.89 So, just like there's lots of pathways into chaos—all you have to do is confront something that's an impediment, it doesn't matter what it is—there's a lot of pathways uphill. So uphill is a particular direction, but there's many entry points. And as you enter

one of those entry points and you transform, you'll converge on the proper goal across time. You're going like this, error, but it'll correct as you move forward.

3.90 So one of the things my clients used to ask me, students, too, is, "I don't know what to do." Well, then they'd be like that for 15 years. "I never figured out what I should do."

Well, one thing you're doing is getting older. Right, so there's no zero-cost stasis. So if you're not moving ahead, you are degenerating. OK, so there's no staying where you are, so then, you don't know what to do. It's like, well, guess. Let's see if we can come up with something that's slightly better than whatever the hell it is that you're doing. We'll talk about this in more detail tomorrow, about how you can get that ball rolling.

3.91 And you might think, well, "I don't want to take the risk of aiming at the wrong thing." It's like, you're going to aim at the wrong thing, because what the hell do you know? But if you aim at the wrong thing and you practice, your aim will get better. So don't worry about that too much. It's like, pick something. Pick some interesting disciplinary routine. Now, this is a place where moral relativism actually has its role. You might say, well, there's a variety of different forms of acceptable morality.

3.92 And obviously that's true, because we each have a different personality. So there's a fair bit of play in the moral system. That doesn't mean it isn't oriented toward something that's stellar. What it means is, there's lots of games that you can play that will work. But the one game that doesn't work is no game, because there's no progress there. There's no discipline, there's no calling, there's no orientation, there's no transformation. Pick something. If you do nothing, first of all, you can't. Let's just try it. You can't do nothing. You're going to think, you're going to fantasize, maybe bitterly. There's literally no doing nothing.

3.93 All you're doing when you're doing nothing is allowing yourself to fall under the sway of the most narrow and bitter visions that can possibly inhabit you. Yeah, well, that's a really stupid strategy, obviously. So, pick something. What we'll see tomorrow— here's a

practical solution. OK, you don't know what to do. Well, what do people do, broadly speaking? It's like, do you have a relationship? Well, no. OK, well, most people want one. You probably do, too. So even if you don't know you want one, we could try that.

3.94 Do you have any friends? Do you have any family? Are you pursuing anything educational? Do you have any job? Is there any way you're making yourself useful to

other people? Do you have any interests at all outside of work? Et cetera. We'll go through this in detail. And if you don't know what to do, it's like, well, try part of one of those things and see. Maybe you're one of those people who just doesn't need anyone else. You're not, because no one is, but maybe you think that. We could at least put it to the test and see. Probably you want a friend, and maybe you're introverted, so you want one friend, but not zero.

3.95 And so, if you don't know what to do, nothing is the wrong solution. And you can look and see what other people do and try to do that. And that's partly why, by the way, when you're a teenager, it matters to you so much to fit in. It's not like you're fitting in. That's such an insane way—you know, "If your friends jumped over a cliff, would you jump off, too?" It's like, well, probably. Maybe it means there's a bear chasing us. You never know. It's like, of course, teenagers try to fit in because they're trying to socialize themselves into the group. They're trying to escape from their parents and their dependency, and they do that by making a group affiliation.

3.96 Now, you can tell your kids, "Don't sell your soul so that you're a member of the group." That's a whole different discussion because you don't want to pretend that you're something that you're not. You don't want to sacrifice the possibility of your higher-order being to idiot identification with the whim of the crowd. But that's not the same thing as, "It shouldn't matter to you what your friends think." You know what sort of person it doesn't matter to what other people think? That's a psychopath. And most of the time, you should be damn concerned with what other people think. Not always, and that's a tight discrimination.

3.97 But most of the time, if most people think there's something wrong with you, they're probably right. Sometimes they're not. And that's an edge case. All right. Another way of looking at emotions. You move from the present to the future. There are things that you predict that are going the way you want them to. That fills you with positive emotion. And then there's a category of obstacle—we'll talk about this tomorrow—there's a category of obstacle that's unpredictable. Sometimes you'll run into obstacles that you know how to move, and sometimes you'll run into obstacles whose nature you don't understand and you can't predict.

3.98 You run into something you don't understand about your husband, for example. It's a bottomless mystery, and we'll talk about that a little bit tomorrow. So, three categories of stimuli that you respond to emotionally. Things that get you on your way, things that get in your way, and things you don't understand. And the things you don't understand, that's a bottomless pit. That's a hole. We'll talk about that tomorrow.

3.99 OK, I'll close with this one today. I showed you one of these little story frames, right? You're here. That's the present. You're aiming at something. The world orients itself so that there are pathways forward to that. You want the pathway because otherwise your plan is invalidated or you'll be upset. You don't want too many obstacles. You want things to help you along your way. That's the world. You're always in a little frame like that. OK, those frames are nested, and that nesting is your identity. When you're developing a vision, you're developing the entire nested structure.

3.100 OK, so I'll show you how that works. OK, your identity is not something you carry around in your head. OK, so now you're two and you have all these motivational forces working within you. OK, as you mature, you integrate them, and you integrate them in a way that makes you a good player within the family and then within your friends. So you integrate those instincts in an increasingly social environment. And then as you mature more, you get better and better at doing that, across longer and longer spans of time, in more and more situations with more and more people.

3.101 OK, so let's break that down. This will show you how you move from the abstract moral imperative to the particular. So let's say you tell your child to make dinner, and he's three. So he looks at you. "What do you mean?" And you give him a cuff because he's too stupid to make dinner. This is not a good plan. And so what's your problem? The problem is he's three. OK, so why is that a problem? And the problem is he doesn't know what complete, make dinner means. He doesn't know the micro steps.

3.102 When you say to someone, "Make dinner," you're assuming that they know how to make dinner. You're assuming that they've been socialized the same way you have been, so that when you utter that phrase, they understand what it means. OK, so we decompose that. What does it mean to make dinner? So my son's 15 months old, and he's starting to learn to set the table. But you can't say "set the table," partly because he can't even see the table. It's here and he's this high. But you can say, "Do you know

where the knife drawer is?" He'll go, "Yes." Say, "Go to the knife drawer." He goes to the

knife drawer. "Pull the knife drawer open. Feel around till you feel a knife."

3.103 He'll do that. You can give him a pat on the head. "Good work. Got the knife?" "Yes." "Take the knife into the table and put it on the top of the table." OK, so what has he done? He's started to set the table. You see, you've broken it down, right? And you've broken it down to implementable subroutines. So, setting the table is an integrated story. It's part of an identity. It's an integrated story that involves a variety of mastered subroutines. Part of what you're doing when you're learning a new task is you have to break the task down to the level of subroutine that you need to master.

3.104 Right, and so when you're training someone, the first thing you have to find out is, well, what don't they know? Maybe you're training someone for customer service. It's like, maybe they whisper on the phone. You might want to find that out. Do you know how to talk? You might assume yes, and that assumption might be completely wrong. Maybe they have to triple the volume of their voice. You have to play until you find out at what level of the subroutines the person is lacking. That includes you, and you build it from the bottom up.

3.105 So it's cut vegetables, set table, do dishes. OK, that's part of completing a meal. Now, if you're a halfway civilized five-year-old, maybe you can make a basic meal. So then you can say to your five-year-old, "You know how to make some Kraft dinner?" And they've got that. They know where the pots are, they know how to boil water. So you can now tag that whole complex small subpersonality with a single verbal tag, and they can do it.

3.106 OK, so maybe if you're a good father, you know how to make a meal, you know how to play with the baby. And what do you do when you play with the baby? Well, you play peekaboo, you tickle the baby, you clean the baby. Those are subroutines. Now you know how to take care of the baby, and you know how to make a meal. And so maybe that's part of being a good parent. And that's part of what makes you a good partner. And that's part of what makes you a good person. And you can say to your wife, "Be a good person."

3.107 It's like, maybe you tell your kids that, "Be good." And sometimes they sort of know what you mean, but you probably have to decompose that down the hierarchy of identity till you hit the level at which they're insufficient and repair that. Imagine you're playing the

piano, playing a complex melody, and you trip over a note, and you do that repeatedly. So what you do is, you slow down, and then you concentrate on the place where you made a mistake, and then you see what you're doing when you make the mistake, and then you adjust that, and then you practice the adjustment till you've automated it, then you integrate it in the rhythm, then you play the whole phrase, and then you go over it.

3.108 That's exactly what you do when you're trying to solve a problem of adaptation. You hit an obstacle, you decompose it down the hierarchy of specialization till you see where the error is, the minimal error, rectify that, practice the rectification, and then sequence back up. And then you're aiming always up. When you're training your two-year-old to put a butter knife on the table, it's a subset of helping him become a good person. But that good person isn't some disembodied abstraction. It's the integrated hierarchy of a set of leveled specializations all aiming in the same direction.

3.109 I'll close with this. Here's a way of conceptualizing that. Let's say you have a highly skilled athlete on your team who's also elected by his peers to be the captain of the team because of his leadership abilities. OK, so then you can imagine what athlete means in that context. It means, let's say, possibly, he's the most skilled player on the team. But what do you mean skilled? Well, maybe he can score the most goals, but that's not sufficient, right?

3.110 He needs to score the most goals in a way that motivates everyone else on the team to score the most goals themselves and to improve in their capacity to do that over time and not to be jealous of the differences in skill at the team level and to get along in a way that makes the entire enterprise worth replicating over and over. And so if you do that, well, then you're a skilled athlete. And that's the same in the broader moral domain, is you want to be skilled at the specific things that you do. You want to have the perceptions and the actions at hand that enable you to do that.

3.111 But you want to have them integrated into a personality that makes all of the games that you're playing work in a broader game and work repetitively with other people in a self-improving direction. If you do that, your life will be meaningful, because meaning is the instinct that tells you that you're doing that. It's not some metaphysical abstraction that you can eradicate with, like, a nihilistic rationalism. "What's the point of life?" It's an experiential reality. It means that you're existing in harmony with your integration

towards the highest possible purpose. That's a good way of thinking about. Your conscience will aid you in that, and so will the manifestation of your interests.

3.112

OK, tomorrow, we'll talk about how to make that concrete, to bring it all the way down to Earth, because you can do that. You can and you need to. All right. Thank you very much.

4. Fear as a Catalyst

4.1

All right, so I titled this course Vision and Plan: Theory and Practice, and made the case, at least implicitly, yesterday, that the way that you structure your life has multiple levels of resolution, you might say, in the higher order and more abstract levels, like ethical principles and high-order visions. And then that has to be scaled down to where it touches the ground, so to speak, which is where you can make implementable changes.

4.2

And they're usually small, but those small changes, even though they might be troublesome, even those small changes are still necessarily related to the structure of the whole. That's actually what gives them their meaning. If you're doing so-called small things. And one of the things that's useful to know, too, is that if you understand the relationship between the part and the whole, which isn't much different than understanding the relationship between you and the world, then that can also imbue all the things that you do at a micro level with meaning, which is what you want.

4.3

Because you want things in your life to be worth the trouble, let's say. Well, so yesterday, I gave you some background theory, and that's useful. A lower resolution theory, one that's more abstract, has the advantage of covering more situations and the disadvantage of less specificity. And today we're going to try to make things specific, but tie them back to the more abstract higher-order principles that we discussed yesterday. So today we're going to talk about practice, vision and plan, theory and practice. Yesterday we talked about vision and theory, and today we'll talk about plan and practice.

4.4

So, I read this interesting animal study years ago, when I was first investigating the neuropsychology and neurophysiology of motivation and emotion. I read a lot of animal

experimental studies. And from the 1940s till about the 1990s, a lot of psychology concentrated on animal behavior, laboratory studies of laboratory animals. And the people who did those studies, Skinner was the person who first really zeroed in on this; they were very, very careful thinkers. The behaviorists were narrow, partly because they were dealing with micro elements of behavior.

4.5 But man, I tell you, as far as precision of thought goes, those people had it. They had it locked down. And Skinner, for example, was extremely good at detailing out theories of learning, theories of reinforcement, emotion, motivation, reward, punishment, threat, etc. And out of his work, I would say, the whole domain of neuroscience emerged.

4.6 And one of the mediating people in that process was Jeffrey Gray, who wrote a book in 1982 called the Neuropsychology of Anxiety, which is an absolutely superb book looking at the relationship between emotional response and brain function—brain function anatomically and also pharmacologically. That's useful because if you can see something that works behaviorally, anatomically, and pharmacologically, and you get the

same results, let's say, in relationship to your theory, using all three different methods of approach, you can be pretty sure that you're onto something real.

4.7 And I don't think there was a book published in the last half of the 20th century that was a more profound psychological work than The Neuropsychology of Anxiety. Gray, who was quite the genius, was a student of Hans Eysenck, who was the most published psychologist of the last half of the 20th century, who was also a very careful thinker. Gray detailed out a lot of animal behavioral studies. I don't know how many citations he had in his book. Like, 1800? Something insane. 1800, let's say, scientific papers. That's the equivalent of 600 PhD dissertations. So that's how much work he did to write that book. Seems almost incalculable, but yeah, yeah, yeah.

4.8 One of the studies he detailed, which was extremely interesting, had to do with animal motivation. And it's a good example of how you can find out very important things by looking at micro details. You can tell how motivated a rat is to do something by how hard

it will work to get access to the opportunity to do it. It's like how you can tell how much you want something, too. If you want something. What do you mean "want", exactly? You say you want it; does that mean you want it?

- 4.9 These things are very—people throw around these words like, "I feel like I need this." None of that makes any sense. That utterance has virtually no meaning. What do you mean by that? Do you really want something? What are you willing—how do we know if you want it? How about, what are you willing to give up for it? What are you willing to invest in it? What are you willing to sacrifice for it? How much work are you willing to do for it?
- 4.10 Well, one of the things they used to do with rats is, you can tell how hungry a rat is. Maybe you deprive it of food. Skinner deprived his rats of food till they were down to 75% of their normal body weight. So they're actually pretty hungry. How could you tell how hungry they were? Well, one of the things you could do is, if you trained a rat, for example, to run down a little runway to get a food reward, you could tie a spring scale to its tail and see how hard it would pull and for how long. And then you have a behavioral measurement of something like motivation.
- 4.11 And if you feed a rat a lot and you put it in a situation where it can run down a runway and get access to food, but it's satiated, it's not going to pull at all. And you think, well, this behaviorist would have said, "You don't even need the word want in a situation like that. You don't need to infer any internal states." Now, they went a little bit too far with that presupposition, but they could actually measure it. It's like, hungry, "hungry" rat will pull hard against a obstacle to get access to food. It's like a definition of want.
- 4.12 Definition of whether or not you want something might not be how much squawking you're willing to do if you don't get it, but how much work you're willing to put in to increase the probability that it'll happen. And so that's a sacrificial assessment. And we have a sacrificial relationship with the world. That's a good way of thinking about. It's quite strange that human beings do this, because one of the things we presume axiomatically is that if we're willing to give up certain things in the present, that we can gain some reward in the future.
- 4.13 That's what you do when you work. It's like the definition of work. One of the mysteries of the Old Testament, for example, is that there's an insistence in the stories that human beings live in a sacrificial relationship to what's divine. That's why there's so much emphasis on sacrifice in the biblical writings. And it's not easy to exactly make sense of

that because it's couched in an archaic language. But the fundamental assumption is, well, you make a deal with reality. You live in a contractual relationship with the future.

4.14 And the presumption is that, if you put in your time and effort now—and that's what work is, because maybe work is something you wouldn't do intrinsically for the reward of the moment, unless you're very fortunate in your work. You give something up, your time, your energy, other opportunities, because you feel if you make the investment, then the payoff will be worth it. And that's a contractual relationship with other people. But in some really abstract sense, with the future itself, or even with the structure of existence itself, it's like, you strike a bargain and you're supposed to hold up your end of the bargain.

4.15 And we kind of presume that if we do hold up our end of the bargain that things will turn out the way we would like them to turn out. And that's a strange thing, that that can actually work. And it's also something that really is quite peculiar to human beings because most animals have a very short-term orientation to gratification. Short-term and narrowly self-centered. A grizzly bear is kind of out for himself. Now there's a certain amount of planning, but most of that's just running on instinct. Whereas you can conceive of an abstract formulation of the future and do all sorts of strange things in the present to strike the bargain that might make that come about.

4.16 And so that's very strange that people do that. And we do do that. And, well, back to motivation, let's say, with the rats. How do you know how motivated a rat is? How hard will it pull against an obstacle to obtain a goal? And so that's a measure of how hungry a rat might be. A rat will work for a reward. So there's another thing you could do, is maybe the rat is running towards some food at the end of a laboratory setup, and you can measure how fast the rat runs. And then you could assume that the faster the rat runs, the more motivated he is to get to the end.

4.17 OK, so a hungry rat will run pretty fast down the runway to get to the reward. But here's something else that's kind of interesting about rats, is they don't like cats at all, not even a bit. And they dislike cats so much that rats that have never encountered a cat can be thrown into an absolute rat frenzy by the odor of a cat. So there is—rats are as unhappy about cats as we are about snakes, or maybe more. And so a rat's—if you waft in cat odor into a rat cage, the rats will get the hell away from the cat odor.

- 4.18 And rats are very, very good at odor detection, by the way, partly because we've been trying to poison them for, like, 50,000 years, right? In fact, I read that if a rat eats something and gets sick, and the other rats know it, and the rats have smelled the breath of the rat that got sick, they won't eat whatever it was the rat ate. So you know, that's pretty sensitive. And so, anyways, rats don't like cat odor. And so imagine now you have a rat that's hungry and it's going to run down the runway to get to the food at some rate, but then you waft in some cat odor behind it. And so, now the rat's running away from the cat and towards the food. Then it's really moving.
- 4.19 So you could imagine if you were running a race as an athlete that you'd be cruising along at a pretty good rate because you want to win, because that's the reward. But then maybe they release a grizzly bear behind you, and then you find a little bit more motivation. And that's worth knowing because the—see, the lesson you can derive from that is that it's something to be motivated by reward. And that's the most desirable form of motivation. So now when a rat is running down a runway and it's hungry and it's running towards the food, it's going to go eat the food, and that'll satiate it.
- 4.20 And then it won't be hungry and that motivational frame will disappear. And it's happy when it's running down the runway because it can see that it's moving towards the reward. And as I described yesterday, that's the basis for incentive reward. That's the basis for enthusiasm. It's, it's the kind of meaning that characterizes hope and curiosity and forward, forward motion, voluntary forward motion. That's all tied up with positive emotion that's mediated by a system, the dopaminergic system.
- 4.21 Neurochemically, that's the same system, by the way, that cocaine activates. And most drugs that people take for fun, that they abuse, directly activate the system that makes you think you're doing something worthwhile when you're moving towards a goal. So that's very interesting to know as well. And that can motivate you quite a lot. But if you're terrified and something's chasing you and you're moving towards something you value, then you really might be something to contend with. And so you can build that into your vision. And that's a good thing to do.
- 4.22 So this—these little diagrams here are quite interesting. So the one on the left is a vision of heaven, and the one on the right is a vision of Dante's hell. And you see, they're multilayered like that. Remember that diagram I showed you yesterday, where

we moved up from the very specifics of setting the table to the very abstract, being a good person. It's a hierarchy of identity. Well, there's a heavenly hierarchy of identity, and that's the identity that would be you, as you're moving towards all the good things you could be and have, at all the levels that would have to be implemented.

4.23 And then there's a hellish hierarchy, which is where you could end up if you did all the stupid things that you could imagine doing very badly. And so maybe to be optimally, optimally motivated, you need a vision of exactly how bad things could turn out for you if you manage to make all the wrong choices, and a vision of just how good things could be if you had enough sense to walk uphill. And you might think, well, "I don't need to contemplate the negative." But then I would say, "Well, maybe you don't want to forego the utility of having your negative emotions push you along, because they're very powerful motivating forces."

4.24 And one of the things I certainly saw as a clinician was that it's better to have your fear behind you, pushing you forward, than your fear in front of you, stopping you. So, I can give you a concrete example of that. So imagine that you're in a job that you hate, or a marriage you hate, or something you hate, and you're afraid to confront it. And so your fear's in front of you, manifesting itself as an obstacle. And you can understand why you might be afraid to confront it, because imagine that you've been laboring in a job for 10 years. It's a miserable, wretched occupation. You hate virtually everything about it.

4.25 And so now you turn around, you decide to confront it, and now you have to go down the levels of analysis to find out why you were so bloody stupid that you wasted a whole decade of your precious life doing something absolutely, unbearably miserable for no reason at all. When you get to the bottom of that, you find out that, in some fundamental way, you betrayed yourself. That's not much fun, especially because you're not going to get that decade back.

4.26 And often what people do, although it's not that clear—sometimes if you've done something spectacularly stupid and you delve into it and you fix it, you can derive all the wisdom you could have accrued over that decade from that investigation. And then you can turn the negative thing you did into something positive. But that's not an easy thing to do. That's a confession and a redemption and an atonement. But you have to go

through the painful process, which really means that you have to face all the things that you were avoiding during that entire 10-year period.

4.27 Now you can do that, and that's one of the ways you can set your life right. But you can certainly understand why people don't want to do that because it's quite the trip down Dante's Inferno right to the bottom. And so you might say, "Why bother?" And the answer is, well, do you want to spend the next 20 years doing the same thing. So, it's like you're picking your hell. You can pick one that you could walk through voluntarily and repair, or you could just pick one that you'll just stay in for the rest of your miserable life.

4.28 And if you're properly afraid of that latter option, then maybe you can put your fear behind you and that'll be one of the things that'll motivate you to confront what's stopping you. So, when I would talk to my clients, for example, and they were afraid to switch jobs, one of the things we would do is, OK, fine, don't switch jobs. All right, now, let's play a little game. "How angry, resentful, bitter, arrogant, and deceitful are you at the moment, because of your job and the misery that is encompassing you because of your job?" So then, you can walk someone through that, let them talk about that, really explore it.

4.29 Then you can say, "Well, you've been in this miserable job for 10 years. Has that made you better or worse?" And the answer usually is "worse." "Stronger or weaker?" "Weaker." "Has it damaged your relationship with your family and the world?" And the answer to that's usually yes. And you've got older, 10 years, it's like, OK, now it's 15 years in the future and you haven't done a damn thing to fix that. All right, now, what are you like? Well, you're 15 years older, you're 15 years smaller. You're less healthy, you're less prepared psychologically. You're less likely to fix it then than you would now because there's less of you.

4.30 You wait for a bus for half an hour; it's supposed to be there for five minutes. You don't want to leave because you already wasted half an hour waiting. So you wait another two hours. You should cut your losses. But people don't do that. You think you're going to cut your losses when it's 20 years that you've done the same stupid thing instead of 10? No. And so all that's happening as you prolong your agony is that you get smaller

and the agony gets greater. And then you have to think about exactly what sort of person you're going to be like in 10 years if you allow that to happen.

4.31 And then—think about it, I don't mean just some abstract semantic representation that's bloodless. I mean to bloody well think about it. Envision it, imagine it, daydream about it. You don't have that much life, and you've let it go. Now you're older and you're bitter and you're not much fun to be around, and most of the joy's gone out of your life. And maybe you're like, I've seen people. They hit 50, they've had a lot of things pile up around them. They haven't cleaned up the mess, and now they're 50 and they don't have that much time left, not much youthful time, and they didn't have the bloody energy to clean up the mess in the last 20 years. What's the probability that they're going to start now?

4.32 And sometimes they can turn things around and, as I said, you can break things down into small pieces and start moving ahead. And maybe there's no point in your life where the situation is absolutely hopeless. But, man. I had a great conversation with an artist friend of mine once, and he said, "You know, you see people who—the mess around them is so large that there's not enough energy left in them to fix it." Well, then you're done, right? Because barring a miracle, and you maybe don't want to discount that possibility, you're just not going to manage it.

4.33 And I've had people like that now and then in my clinical practice, where no matter how much digging we did, there was so much to be dug up that it would have taken three lifetimes to fix. And then, well, what do you do? Yeah, you throw up your hands and probably you leave because there's nothing you can do.

4.34 All right, so we, with my colleagues, Daniel Higgins and Robert Pihl— Pihl was my graduate supervisor at McGill, Higgins, a student of mine at Harvard—and I've worked with these two men for 30 years now, with Bob for even longer than that, had a great relationship with him as a supervisor. Daniel was a wonderful student of mine and has been a very good business collaborator. We tried to make some of this practical. And 30 years ago, we decided we were going to put this company together that would produce psychological interventions.

4.35 We had a bunch of rules for that. They had to be low-cost; free, by the way, is not a good price. People ask me sometimes online why I haven't made these intervention

available for free. And the first answer to that is, what do you mean free? Someone's paying for it, and the logical person to pay for something that the person is using is the person that's using it, not the person that's providing it. And so, one of our rules right at the beginning of our enterprise was that we weren't going to produce micro businesses that weren't self-sustaining.

4.36 Another reason for that is if your endeavor can't stand on its own two feet, what the hell makes you think it's worth pursuing? One of the advantages to being embedded in a market environment is you get signals. If I'm trying to produce a psychological intervention, and no one wants it, then I've probably designed it badly or marketed it badly, or I'm trying to solve a problem that's not actually a problem, or my solution isn't a good one. And so if you put a reasonable price on something, the reasonable price would be one that enables the project to sustain itself and possibly grow.

4.37 Which is why you need profit, which is often regarded as a dirty word. It's like, well, you work for profit. If you're not working for profit, all you ever do is work because the work is just enough so that you can continue the work. Well, why would you work then? Just to not die? And fair enough, but that's a hell of a harsh kind of motivation. Do this or I'll shoot you. That's not a great way of motivating yourself optimally. So you want to set up an enterprise that generates a profit so that you have something to play with.

4.38 It's not so you can go gratify all your idiot hedonistic whims. And maybe you can get away with that for a while and spend all your ill-gotten capitalist gain on hookers and cocaine. But it's not a very good long-term strategy. If you have any sense, you take what you've earned in profit, you reinvest it either in the company so it can keep growing and you can provide more services, maybe at a lower cost, or maybe you can go do something else somewhat creative and useful with the surplus. That's what you should be doing.

4.39 And people who are radically successful at continued entrepreneurial ventures, that's really what they do. If you're a mafioso boss, and all you're interested in is power and luxury, well, first of all, that's a movie. It's not something that's going to work in your life. And even if you do try to implement that, it will probably only work for about 10 years before you're either dead of your own stupidity or someone will do you the favor of putting you out of your misery. This is not a good plan.

4.40 And so then you think, well, how much should you charge for a product? And the answer is, this is the answer—what the market will bear. Because imagine that I put together a program that, if you did, wouldn't take very long and would change your life and positively and maybe permanently. Well, what's that worth? Well, in the Soviet Union, they had a central pricing committee. They had to make something like 10,000 pricing decisions a day. Well, if you ever start a company, the first thing you're—one of the first things you're going to find out is, it's really hard to figure out what your damn product is worth.

4.41 I mean, maybe I make a program that'll help you make a vision. I charge you \$10,000 for it. Now, why? Well, maybe if you paid \$10,000, you'd take it seriously, and maybe you'd be happy to pay \$10,000 because you want to indicate to yourself that you've made a sacrifice that indicates that you think that putting that much time into yourself is worthwhile. And maybe instead it's 50 cents. It's like, well, if it's 50 cents, well, everyone could do it, but then it's 50 cents. And if there's something online for 50 cents, what's the probability that you're going to think it's worth anything?

4.42 And you might think it should be free. It's like, well, we already discussed the problems with free, but how much should you pay? Well, here's another problem is, most people want to trade. They don't want charity, and if so, if you offer people the opportunity to engage in an enterprise that you've established, they would like to repay the favor so that they keep the slate clean. Because most people are sensible enough to know that you shouldn't be accruing unreturned favors as you move through life. And so you also want to put the price at something that's fair.

4.43 So the person can think, well, "The provider of the service did their part in providing the service, but I did my part in paying for the service." And part of the way that societies stay productive, generous, and abundant is that that deal, that mutual deal, is made honestly and voluntarily. So you can go into a store and buy a piece of clothing and you don't have to feel like you did anyone a favor or vice versa. It's just an even trade. And so it sums to zero or maybe to mutual benefit, which is actually the case. And you can just do that repeatedly. And that's the utility of setting up a system where the trade is voluntary.

4.44 And then people will participate in it on a voluntary basis too. It's not based on force or charity or pity or any of those things that sometimes sound good, but you have hidden prices. So, anyways, the other rule that we put into place was that, while we wanted psychological interventions that were of demonstrable utility, so we had to demonstrate to ourselves and generally by publishing that the intervention worked, it had to be profitable. But as reasonable a cost as we could manage, because we wanted to offer it to as many people as possible.

4.45 It had to be scalable, so if the enterprise grew—if your enterprise isn't designed properly and starts to scale, it can collapse under its own weight. So you have to think about what you would do if you became successful, how you would scale upwards. So we wanted it to have minimal bureaucratic understructure. And we've run this company for 30 years, literally with, we have three people and one part-time person who handles customer service. And we're able to, what would you say? We've offered our products to 150,000 people, something like that, with no infrastructure whatsoever.

4.46 So we've been able to keep the price down there, too. Now we have built this program called Self-Authoring that helps people write an autobiography. It helps them evaluate their faults and their virtues in the present and then it helps them develop a vision for the future. And it corresponds in some ways to the map I showed you yesterday of past, present, and future. And the idea is you want to iron out all the kinks in your life. So maybe you have to iron out your past a bit because you're carrying some baggage along with you. And maybe you need to figure out what your virtues are and your talents in the present and what your faults are, so you can capitalize on your virtues and talents and rectify your faults.

4.47 Then maybe you need to lay out a vision for the future. And there's a big literature on such things, by the way, from two sources. One, the clinical psychological domain, showing that if you get people to write about past traumatic events voluntarily, that that increases their physical and mental health. And another that shows if you get them to write about their future, that that does the same thing. And then a literature from the management side of psychology, psychology of business, that if you have employees and you want to motivate them—

4.48 Imagine that if I wanted to motivate you, I could ask you to lay out a plan about how you were going to be a good employee for the next year or five years into the future. Seems like a reasonable thing to do. But man, imagine you could match that against another experimental group where, instead of writing about how you were going to be a productive and generous employee, let's say, you wrote about what you were going to do with your life and how your job might fit into that.

4.49 So what you find is that if you get people to do the latter instead of the former, that the effects are much more positive. And you could imagine that the reason for that is, is that if I hire you, one of the things I'm going to want to know is, why is working for me or with me, which is a better way of thinking about it, what is that going to do for you? You're going to want to tell me what it's going to do for me, because that's, at least in principle, part of the reason I might hire you. If you're in a job interview, you might want to tell the person why you're going to be useful to them.

4.50 But this is a more subtle thing to contemplate, is one of the things you want to tell them is why it would be useful for you to be working here. And the reason for that is, if you're making a partnership with someone, which is really what you're doing even if you hire them, if you have any sense, is you want to know why. I would like to set up a situation where, if I just ignore you, if I have to, you'll go out and work like a mad dog without me having a micromanage or supervise you. And then I can be certain you're going to do that, if I know that our interests are aligned in relationship to your own goals.

4.51 So I want to know that if you come to work for me, that you have a reason for that. Which also implies that you have a reason. And so you get your employees, for example, to lay out a vision for their life, and then if they find out too, that it turns out that the job they have isn't in keeping with the vision for their life that they want to pursue, then really it's like, "Sayonora, man. Nice working with you. You should go find a place that suits what you're aiming at because it'd be better for you and be better for me. There's just no reason for us to be partnering," which is what you do if you're an employee and you have any sense.

4.52 There's no reason for us to be partnering unless your needs and wants, the genuine ones, are met by our contractual arrangement. See, and this is a good thing to know if you're a manager, because you don't want to be imposing a motivational framework on

someone. You'll have to use power to control them then. And part of the problem with that, maybe you want power because you're completely out of your bloody mind, but what power really means is, I have to stand over you with a stick, unless I'm a bit on the sadistic side and I'm looking for an opportunity to whack you for idiot reasons of my own.

4.53 I'd much rather know that you're doing these things for your own purposes. I'd like to know what those purposes are, and I'd hope that they would run in alignment with mine. That's what happens when you play a game with someone, and it's a voluntary game. And you see this with children when they, once they're three or so, and they can start engaging in pretend games. What they do when they set up a pretend play opportunity, say, they want to play houses, they invite the other child to play. "Do you want to play house? Do you want to play tag? Do you want to play hide-and-go-seek?"

4.54 And part of the rule is the other person has to want to play. And then you see, you can enter into the same shared frame of reference. Your emotions line up, and so do your motivations. And then you can walk in lockstep towards the hypothetical goal. So that's a very good deal. And it's a good deal to do that with yourself, too, so that you're not standing over yourself with a stick, beating yourself so that you move forward.

4.55 Maybe that's better than being completely useless and laying in your bed being nihilistic and depressed. But it's not an optimal solution. You want to entice yourself forward to the degree that that's possible, and you want to get your fears in order. OK, so when we built this future authoring program, one of the things we did was try to operationalize this, to bring these abstractions down to earth. OK? So here's what you do at the beginning of this exercise. And you don't need to purchase the program to do this, you can just do it yourself. But the program makes it easier because it's all laid out. But I'll walk through it.

4.56 Now what we found, we used this program in three separate research studies. At McGill University, which is a selective state school, that's a good way of thinking about it. I'd say it's probably a 90th-percentile-tier university by American standards. It would be less elite than the Ivy leagues in the U.S., but it would be the next tier. So that's what McGill is. And we ran it at the business school in Rotterdam and at a kind of community college/trade school in Ontario. So, we hit a variety of different academic domains.

4.57 And what we did is, we had students come in and they would either do this vision program for 90 minutes or they would write about—they would write an equivalent amount about what they'd done in the last two weeks. We're just controlling for the fact of a psychological intervention and the fact of writing. And we found that, at McGill, students who did the program, their grades went up 35% and their dropout rate plummeted. These were students who are already in school. I think, on average, they were second- or third-year students.

4.58 At Mohawk College, we had students do it before they enrolled in there, when they were going to be familiarized with the university, before attending in the summer. They did it for 90 minutes with no preparation. They got no feedback for their writing. We dropped their dropout rate by 50% with a 90-minute intervention. And the biggest effects, and this was true in the study at Rotterdam too, the biggest effects actually occurred with the students who had the worst academic background and who were the least likely to perform well at university by, if you used their race and their ethnicity and their sex to predict their probability of continuing.

4.59 So it actually did the most, it had the most effect for the least promising students, which was fascinating because, most of the time, it's one of the terrible things about psychological interventions. Imagine you have a group of kids who are performing from bad to good, and you put in an intervention. Often, what happens is the students who are doing well do even better. It has hardly any effect at all on the poor performers. It's part of that Matthew principle I talked about earlier, that if you already have, you'll get more, and if you don't have, it'll be taken away from you.

4.60 It's very hard to come up with an intervention that actually lifts up the bottom end, regardless of how positive you are about your intervention. Another thing you learn as a social scientist, and every politician should know this is, just because you think you have the proper outcome in mind doesn't mean you do have the proper outcome in mind. And it certainly doesn't mean that your stupid intervention is going to do only the good things you think it will do and nothing else.

4.61 And it's often the case with broad-scale psychological or social interventions that the unintended consequences of the intervention are so negative that they just demolish anything positive and are often counterproductive. So that's a terrifying thing to

understand, the law of unintended consequences. But it's an ethical rule if you're a social—if you're a social scientist, that if you're going to intervene in people's lives, that you build in an assessment of your intervention to ensure that what you're doing actually works, instead of making people worse.

4.62 A good example of that is the self-esteem movement that the idiots, educational psychologists implemented almost nationwide 20 years ago. All they managed to do was to make kids more neurotic and experience higher levels of negative emotion. And they confused narcissism with self-esteem and taught a generation to also be narcissistic. So, making children more narcissistic and miserable doesn't count as a success unless part of you is aiming at that, which, and that was a suspicion I couldn't squelch when I saw that form of stupidity being purveyed out into the educational universe.

4.63 Whole word reading was another cataclysmic example of that. So dim-witted psychologists noted that excellent readers maybe read a whole phrase in a glance and certainly a word, they're not sounding out the damn word. And so they derived from that the proposition that, if you wanted to teach children to read, you should teach them to identify whole words, instead of noticing that we actually have a phonetic alphabet, which is like a discovery so crucial it's like discovering the wheel.

4.64 And that by teaching children to identify words, whole words, we're trying to make them learn English like Chinese people learn Chinese, which is so insane that only someone idiotic and educated could possibly think it up. And the consequence of that—and they implemented in California first—was that reading ability in California plummeted. I think it went from first in the US to 51st over the course of about five years. I don't still think they've shaken that stupidity out of the education system.

4.65 So anyways, you test your damn interventions to see if they work. And maybe you do a micro project first to make sure you're not doing anything cataclysmic before you launch it into the entire population. So in any case, students' grades at McGill went up 35%, their dropout rate went down. And we found that the dropout rate at Mohawk College went down by 50%. And then we found similar results at the business school in Rotterdam. And the groups that benefited most there, the stratification for success was,

like, Caucasian women were doing the best, then non-Caucasian women, then non-Caucasian, then Caucasian men, then non-Caucasian men.

4.66 That was the stratification of academic achievement at the business school. Now there were more men than women. So the women were a more elite group. And that's part of the reason they were doing better. Although women tend to be doing better academically than men across the board now, all the way from junior high through the entire education system. The biggest effect was on the non-Caucasian men. And in fact, in our Rotterdam group, the intervention had such a big effect that the non-Caucasian men outperformed the Caucasian women as the program moved forward across a couple of years.

4.67 So that was cool. And one of the things we concluded from that, I don't know if it's true, is that, if men are motivated by their own purposes, they will succeed. But if they're only in a system because the system has a structure, they're going to be all over the place. And I think that's probably because men are more disagreeable than women. And so, unless they're motivated, unless they're self-motivated, they're just not going to participate.

4.68 And so, anyways, the consequence of that was that absolutely zero universities picked up the programs, even the ones where we did the bloody studies, even when we worked with the universities where we did the studies for, like, a year afterwards, trying to adjust our technology to their systems, even after they promised us they would implement them, which indicated to us that they could care less whether half their bloody students dropped out, which is a complete catastrophe.

4.69 There's a school—Larry Arnn runs it—Hillsdale. It's a conservative college in the northeast U.S. They have a 1% dropout rate. So you can get there if you run things properly. It's like 50%; it's absolutely inexcusable. And it was quite a mystery too. Took me a long time to think through. We have people sit down and write for 90 minutes about what they would want in their life and who they would want to be.

4.70 Now this is a pretty fundamental thing to do. You'd think that if you educated children for 15 years, that, at some point, you might take an afternoon to have them sit down and write seriously about their vision for themselves and themselves in relationship to the

world. You might think that would be so important that it's self-evident and that, maybe for a semester, you might do nothing other than that.

4.71 Yeah, well, I learned, because I looked into the history of the development of the education system, that the public education system in the West was predicated on the Prussian military model developed in the mid-1800s. And the purpose of the Prussian military schools was to produce obedient and will-less soldiers. And then that was imported into the US by industrialists who were fascists. And this was before the Second World War, when being a fascist wasn't quite the dismal enterprise that it then became, to train the children of rural people who were flooding into the cities to become obedient workers.

4.72 Not to become people who could manage their own lives, right, but people who would show up and do things in order by the bell. And you could say, well, there was some utility in that because rural people were flooding into the cities, and industrialization was taking place. And the most likely life outcome for many of those children was that they were going to be working in a factory, and they needed to be socialized in order to do that. But taking away their own autonomy and subjugating their will to the corporate, what would you say, the fascist corporate endeavor, hardly seems to be an optimized solution to that problem, but it's still the one that we implement, literally 130 years later. God, dismal, dismal. Anyways.

4.73 OK, so how do you do this? Well, let's see, do I have that quote here? Yeah, this is another quote, a gospel quote from Matthew. We talked about the Matthew principle. This is a very strange injunction. "Ask and it will be given to you. Seek and you'll find. Knock and it shall be opened unto you." All right, so we're going to think about that for a minute. So one of the things you might ask yourself is, what is it exactly that you're doing when you're thinking? Let's say you're thinking about something serious that has to do with you.

4.74 OK, so imagine what you have to do to actually think seriously about something. OK, so the first thing you have to do is, you have to admit that you have a problem or you don't know something. So the search has to begin with an admission of error or insufficiency. Something isn't right, and I don't know. So that's a gesture of humility. You could think about that as an opening up. It's like you have a question in mind. OK.

- 4.75 And then, well, then you seem to be able to think up an answer. Now, not always. And maybe you have to discuss it with other people. Maybe you have to do some reading and some investigation. But weirdly enough, how the hell does this work? If you ask yourself a question, there's some probability you'll get an answer, and there's even some probability that you'll get the right answer. And you could say, well, you thought that up. But that sort of begs the question—it's like, well, how do you do that exactly? What do you mean, you thought that up? Because you don't know how you did that.
- 4.76 It's more like you ask yourself a question, and the answer makes itself known. And you might attribute that to yourself. But then you have to ask, well, if you could do it yourself, why do you have the problem to begin with? Why do you have to ask the question? If you had the knowledge at hand, why was it a mystery? And if it was a mystery, then, well, why was it a mystery? And if it was a mystery, then where the hell did the answer come from?
- 4.77 One of the things Jung said, and I think this is right, is that although people don't really notice this, it's like, thoughts that appear in the landscape of your imagination are like walking into a room and noticing that there's furniture there. You do the noticing, but you don't know how it got there. It's a given in some ways. And I think, I believe, by the way, that I believe that thought is literally secularized prayer. Because the prayer concept was, the prayer and atonement concept was, you had to admit there was something wrong with you, and you had to open yourself up to a revelation. Then you had to assess the quality of the revelation.
- 4.78 And I think that's exactly what you do when you think, except if you're secular, you attribute the consequences of the thought to yourself, whatever that means. But like I said, that gets you into those philosophical conundrums that I just laid out. If you could think it up, well, how did you do that? Because you certainly don't know. And if it was within your power to do that thinking, that spontaneous creative act, which you don't understand, why did you have to do it? Why do you have the problem to begin with? And where'd the new information come from?
- 4.79 It's not like we know the answer to any of these questions, but we should be smart enough to know we don't know the answer, and it's quite—I think it's a revelation fundamentally, and you experience it that way because now and then, you ask yourself

a difficult question. Maybe you don't really want to, and you actually want the answer, which is also terrifying because most of the time, if you ask yourself a difficult question, you're not going to get the answer you want.

4.80 You might get the answer you need. It'll be something that points to something that's insufficient about you that you need to change, generally speaking, or to a blind spot you have in a relationship or something like that. Generally, you kind of have a sense of how true what you think up is by how much you wish it wasn't the case, and that's a very interesting thing to note, too. Anyways, you approach the mystery on your knees. I need some help. And if you're fortunate, it arrives, and that's frequently the case.

4.81 Sometimes it'll appear in the form of a fantasy or dream, which is why dreams can be analyzed in psychotherapy with some utility, if you're fortunate enough to find someone who has the perspicacity necessary to analyze a dream. It's a very difficult thing to do. The dream is a proto-thought. A dream is a place where thoughts emerge, and the dream is a mystery because it's the thought before it's absolutely clear; it's the first stages of the process by which things you don't understand at all start to become yours.

4.82 And so the dream is mysterious not because it's trying to wrap up something you've repressed in a mystery to hide itself from you, but because the dream is the best first-pass approximation solution to the problem that you've presented. Part of the reason that you're dreaming at night is because you're trying to reorganize the way you look at the world, underneath the explicit and the semantics, so that you can adapt yourself more particularly to the structure of the world.

4.83 That works, whether you remember the dreams or not, by the way. But if you do remember them and you can interpret them, sometimes you can jump the adaptation process forward and it's not that mysterious in some ways. So imagine this and say, OK, so imagine we did this as an exercise. Say, OK, I want you to think about one way your life could be better in a year that would be relevant to you, that you think would be attainable. OK, now, so to do that, you have to set that question up in your mind. It's like, OK, what, what's one thing I'm unhappy about? Do I have some vision of how that might be improved and what might reasonably be expected in a year?

4.84 OK, now you close your eyes and then you let yourself, well, think about it. OK, so what does that mean? Think about it in words. Or more likely, you could generate an image

that's sort of like the daydreaming that a child engages in—and that daydreaming, that's a waking dream. It'll be in images, like a moving picture. Well, moving picture, a movie is actually a collective dream. That's another way of thinking about it. And so the birthplace of your hypothesis about what your better future could be will make itself manifest in the form of a vision. Literally.

4.85 And people have visions all the time. It isn't how we describe them. When you're reading a book, a novel, the characters come to life in your imagination. That's a vision. When you daydream, that's a vision. It's a form of thought. But it's also a form of revelation, partly because—why revelation? Well, it has an autonomy, and you know this. If you fantasize, if you fantasize sexually, there'll be a part of that that's voluntary. You set up the image, let's say, but it'll play itself out as if it has its own autonomy, its own characterization.

4.86 People who write novels report this all the time. They don't know what the hell is going to happen to the characters. The story unfolds in their imagination. They capture it in words. There's an in-built dynamism that's autonomous in the fantasy. And one of the reasons that people have a religious impulse, you might say, is because they've noted over millennia that that process of fantastic approach to the solution of problems has an autonomy.

4.87 So what would you say? It's characterized by a spirit that's not exactly you, in the same way that your conscience isn't exactly you, or in the same way that things that grip your interest aren't exactly you. Jung, when he talked about the collective unconscious, his hypothesis was that the deeper reaches of the collective unconscious constituted the spirit that makes itself manifest in everyone, that generates the fantasies that constitute the initial solutions to the problems of life. So it's tied deep down into the instinctual substrate, and there is an autonomy to that.

4.88 And Jung's proposition was that the entity that people regard as God is the concretization of that autonomy of spiritual development. Brilliant, a brilliant hypothesis. I also think that one that's irrefutable. OK, so back to this statement. Ask and it shall be given to you. OK, so what does this mean? It means that you actually have to ask. You might say, well, this has never worked for me. It's like, well, first of all, that's not true

because you think, and now and then that works. And you might ask yourself, well, how well could you think if you were really thinking?

4.89 And really thinking might be, "I'm asking a dead serious question here, and I'm willing to accept any answer whatsoever, as long as I find it credible and motivating, no matter what I have to give up." And that's a sacrificial gesture. And maybe you're very unhappy in your marriage and you're trying to figure out why and you think, "Oh my God, I'm at the end of my bloody rope. I'll do anything to fix this."

4.90 And then you have a fantasy, and God only knows what that is. And if you don't do that, maybe it'll be a murderous fantasy because that's when the problem-solving mechanism has been suppressed enough and lied about enough to start to become seriously pathological. You might want to consult yourself with a little bit more regularity before it comes to that. But the fantasy will make itself manifest and there'll be things that you have to change. And those are parts of you that you— parts of you that you have to let die. And that's part of the pain of thought, and it's part of the pain of genuine conversation with people.

4.91 Because maybe you're sitting down with your wife trying to sort through what the hell went wrong, and you find out that there's parts of you, buddy, they really have to go. And those might be like limbs, not just like fragments of your being, whole parts of you that have to burn away. God, it's no wonder people don't want to do that. But, so, how do you put yourself in a position where you're willing to ask? I would say, well, one of the things you can do is you could use some terror on your side. So here's something to contemplate. You can try this.

4.92 It's kind of interesting. You might have to practice it a bit before you get good at it. So, imagine you sat down and you allowed yourself to think about all the stupid things you do that you know are stupid. There's going to be things you do you don't know. And maybe it's because you're blind or you're ignorant or whatever, but there's some things you're doing for sure that you know are stupid.

4.93 And there are also some of those things that you could stop doing, but for whatever reason, don't. And then you might think, OK, imagine I let those things have free rein. I just stop resisting them. I let them take me wherever the hell they're actually aiming. What would that look like five years down the road? Now, everyone's temperament

predisposes them to a different domain of temptation. So for example, if you look at narcissistic people, so narcissistic people want unearned attention and they want unearned status, OK?

4.94 And then you might say, well, what are the personality predictors of narcissism? And if you're extroverted and disagreeable, you're more likely to be narcissistic. And then you might think about that as a form of genetic determinism, because whether you're extroverted is like 50% genetic, and whether you're disagreeable is 50% genetic. And that seems to indicate that whether or not you're narcissistic has a genetic element and a powerful one. And then it's sort of deterministic and—but then, so how do you wrestle with a problem like that?

4.95 And one of the answers to that is, I don't care what your temperament is. It's going to confer on you a set of advantages, but it's also going to confer on you a set of probable disadvantages. And that'll be the temptations that beckon to you. I studied people who were prone to alcoholism, and they were often people who had multi-generational family histories of alcoholism. And if you gave these people alcohol, their heart rate would go up like 30% after four drinks. And it was because they were responding to alcohol as if it was a cocaine-like, actually an opiate-like psychomotor stimulant.

4.96 And lots of people don't respond to alcohol like that at all. But if you do, you're really going to enjoy alcohol. And you can see that there's a biological component to that. You might think, well, that's radically unfair. And I suppose it is, but it's more complicated than that because your temperament might tilt you towards antisocial behavior, criminality, or narcissism. But it also might tilt you towards, like, sexual licentiousness or neuroticism or depression or anxiety.

4.97 There's going to be a genetic proclivity to some domain of sin for you. But that doesn't mean precisely that it's deterministic. It just means that some things are going to be more tempting for you than others, and you're going to have to wrestle with those things. And other people have to wrestle too, but maybe with different temptations. OK, so that's a good way of thinking about that.

4.98 And you might even be strongly tempted in a particular direction because of your temperament. You're hyper-extroverted and you're hyper-disagreeable, so narcissism is really going to be a temptation. What's the advantage? Well, if you're really extroverted,

you have all the advantages of being really extroverted. You're charismatic and dynamic. You like being around other people. You have a lot of energy. You have a lot of

positive emotion. And if you're disagreeable, it's bloody difficult for people to take advantage of you. But if you're charismatic and it's difficult to take advantage of you, it's quite easy to take advantage of other people.

4.99 It's like, well, you can't get the advantages without the disadvantages. And then maybe you can be wise enough, if you're bloody likely and careful, lucky and careful, to regulate the temptation and manage to capitalize, let's say, on the advantages. OK, so, back to contemplation. Most people know what sort of hell they would end up in if they allowed themselves to go in that direction. Some people can't control their temper. Some people can't control their drug intake. Some people can't control their despair or their appetite. Who the hell knows where you'd end up if you allowed yourself to fall apart. But you probably have some idea.

4.100 So then, one of the things you can do is, play it out. Imagine what you've done that was stupid in the past, that hurt you. There's probably a pattern of some sort there because people tend to have their pattern of errors. And then you can think, OK, you stop resisting that. You let it take you over completely. What sort of hell are you in, in five years? And maybe you're, I don't know, maybe you're on crank in downtown Portland, bent over. That's you. Is that really what you want?

4.101 And you've got to think it through. Not like some abstraction, but like some deeply embodied fantasy. And you got to think, well, how much do I not want that, and how probable is that, and do I even want to taste it that. Or maybe I just want not to go there at all. And the more real you make it—when you're getting people to expose themselves to things they're afraid of and avoiding, and you get them to do that in their imagination, the more real they make the imagination, which you can measure by measuring their psychophysiological responses.

4.102 Because if you have a frightening fantasy and it's real, you'll sweat more. And that can be measured. The more realistic people make the fantasy, the faster they progress in exposure therapy. And so you can do this with your daydream. It's like, what would you be like if you were as bad as you could be? In the particularized way that you would be the worst you could be? You might think, well, I'd never do that. Well, you should

disabuse yourself that thought very, very rapidly. Because that's actually one of the things I learned about totalitarianism.

4.103 It's the people who think they would be least likely to follow the dictates of a totalitarian regime that are in fact the most likely to be exactly those people. It's like, no, it's probably you, buddy. If you can't see it, it just means you're blind. And so this is partly, actually, a grappling with your capability for malevolence, for aiming down. And you can be sure there's things in you that are aiming down. And you might say, well, no, why would I aim down? It's like, ah, you're bitter.

4.104 How would that be? You've been betrayed, you're resentful, you want revenge on other people or maybe yourself, or maybe you want revenge on God for making such a godforsaken reality to begin with. I mean, people have these motivations. If you don't see them, you're not paying attention. And you should pay attention because those motivations, first of all, they get in your way. And second, they might divert you. But even perhaps more importantly, if you get them behind you, pushing you forward, they make you very difficult to stop.

4.105 If you let your fear stop you, well, then you're stopped. But if your fear is propelling you, you're a lot more difficult an agent to interfere with. And so you think— well, one of the reasons, I don't know if this is a good example but it might be. I got myself in trouble about seven years ago for saying some things that people thought I shouldn't say, and the reason I said them was because I was much more afraid of the consequences of losing control of my tongue than I was afraid of whatever the hell the idiot administrators at the university were going to manage to array against me.

4.106 You've got to know what to be afraid of. And one of the things you should be afraid of is your own capacity for self-destructive stupidity. And you can play that out. You think, well, there's a hell I don't think I'm going to visit. But you have to make it real and you have to make it personal, and that's a frightening thing.

5. Faith in Tragedy

5.1 The Christian Passion story nests at the bottom of our culture. And there's a reason for that. It's necessarily the case. And Jung called that story an archetypal tragedy. And this

is what he meant by that. It's like the story in the Book of Job. So the Book of Job is a story about a good man. God even admits he's good. And God makes a bet with Satan.

5.2 And Satan comes along and has a chat with God and says, "You think Job is good, but I don't think so. I think he's just fortunate. If you stripped him of everything about his life that would be good, he would become bitter and turn against himself and turn against you." And God says, "Yeah, I don't think so." And Satan says, "Well, why don't you let me have at him and find out?" And God says, "Yes," which is rather a bitter thing for God to do. But there will be definitely times in your life where you feel exactly like that's what's happened to you.

5.3 And so what happens to Job is that almost everything that could possibly be terrible that could happen to a person happens to him. And the story is about how he contends with that. It's a tragedy and an archetypal tragedy. So you might think, what's a tragedy? Well, life is a tragedy. There's tragic aspects to life. And what's a tragedy? Tragedy is when a terrible thing happens to someone. But that can be justice. If you go to a movie and a terrible thing happens to an arch-criminal, you're actually happy about it. You don't think it's a tragedy.

5.4 So it's not merely that terrible things happen. It's that terrible things happen in an unjust way. That's a tragedy. And then you might think, well, what's the ultimate tragedy? And the ultimate tragedy is when the worst possible thing happens to the least possibly deserving person, right? And the reason that that story is at the basis of our culture is because you're going to have to contend with that at some point in your life, because there will be things that will happen to you, despite your innocence, at least in that regard, that make you suffer dreadfully.

5.5 And if it doesn't happen to you, it'll happen to your children, which is a situation that makes it even more poignant and terrible. And so you have to contend with the problem of unjust suffering. And the archetypal story sits at the bottom of our culture because everyone has to contend with that. The Christian Passion is not only the wrestling with tragedy, an unjust tragedy, it's also the harrowing of hell. Part of the mythological dream that surrounds the canonical Judeo-Christian story is that after Christ is crucified, he descends into hell.

- 5.6 Think, well, what does that mean psychologically, let's say? And what it means is, not only will you have to—every soul has to confront the reality of tragedy and unjust suffering, but that you have to also confront the reality of malevolence. And maybe that's even worse than death. When you look at soldiers who develop post-traumatic stress disorder, most of the time they don't develop that because something terrible has happened to them. They usually develop it because they did something terrible.
- 5.7 And you find, as a clinician, people can bear an awful lot of suffering even if it's unjust, but if they're betrayed by someone malevolent, especially if it's themselves, they have a hell of a time recovering from that. And so it's very frequently the case that someone who's traumatized isn't traumatized by tragedy. So, for example, if you're four years old and you were sexually molested by your uncle, well, that's not exactly suffering and tragedy, although there may be an element of that, obviously.
- 5.8 It's betrayal, but it's betrayal of the most perverse sort because it's betrayal by someone who should be taking care of you within the confines of a family, and it's reducing you to an agent of their satisfaction, despite your vulnerability. And then what you have to contend with is not precisely the physical damage that's been done as a consequence of that, although that might be part of it. You have to contend with the fact that now you have to figure out just exactly what the hell motivated that person. And how in the world are you going to do that when you're four?
- 5.9 Because you can hardly imagine anything darker than that. You can, but that's starting to get pretty far out there on the edge. And one of the things that is done to a four-year-old child who's sexually molested by someone who should be taking care of them is that the problem of the evil in the human heart is laid at their feet when they're four. Now, how in the world are you going to deal with that? What that does is, it just fragments and shatters people.
- 5.10 Maybe by the time they're 30, maybe they're sophisticated enough to spend a whole year thinking that through and coming up with some formulation about, what would you say, the theological and psychological nature of malevolence itself. And they can put it into context and move on, but it's not an easy matter. Well, one of the things I did with people in my practice who had post-traumatic stress disorder, sometimes people who

were betrayed and tortured, sometimes people who'd betrayed themselves, is I'd have them read accounts of great evils.

5.11 So, for example, there's a book called *Ordinary Men*, a brutal book. And it details—it's really quite a singular book— details out the adventures of this group of policemen who were middle-aged in Nazi Germany. And middle-aged is important because they grew up before the Nazi propaganda. If you grew up under the Nazi propaganda and you became a Nazi, it's like, well, not that that's forgivable, but it's more understandable, because that's all you knew. But if you're, like, 40 when Hitler comes to power, you don't have that as an excuse.

5.12 And so all these policemen in this battalion were middle-aged guys and they're all just ordinary policemen, going about their ordinary policing work in Germany. And then they were shipped as a battalion to Poland when the Germans marched through, and they were basically shanghaied into military service. OK, so now there's a war going on, and the Germans have been told that the reason for the war is the international conspiracy of the evil Jews. And the policemen are told that there's a lot of Jewish people in Poland and that it's necessary for them to keep the peace and keep the homeland safe, to start to act against the Jews.

5.13 And this is a very interesting book because the commander of this battalion was, by all appearances, quite a compassionate and reasonable person. And he told all his policemen at the beginning of the action that if they wanted to leave Poland and go back to Germany and not participate in what was to come, that they could and that there would be no repercussions. And some of them did, and there were no repercussions.

5.14 And by the way, although everyone thinks that, if you didn't abide by the dictatorial dictates of the totalitarian state of Nazi Germany, that you were going to be severely punished. There's not very much evidence for that. People seemed to go along with it voluntarily for the most part, and that was exemplified in this battalion. Well, the first thing these men were called upon to do— now, you might imagine too, you're in that situation now.

5.15 You're out there with all these men you've worked with for a long period of time, and your commander is saying, "Look, we're in a war, and there's going to be some difficult things you have to do. And maybe you don't want to leave all the terrible, difficult things

to your comrade here. Maybe you want to shoulder your fair share of the catastrophe." So the people who left, and some of them did, had to do that, despite the fact that in some real sense, they felt they were betraying their fellow officers by leaving them with the dirty work.

5.16 Now, at the beginning, they didn't exactly know what the dirty work was going to be. But I'm telling you this so you can see how the stage might be set for someone's participation. Could easily be that it was the more loyal policemen who stayed. And you generally think that loyalty is an admirable trait. And that's one of the terrible things about participating in great acts of evil, is you can be pulled into them by your virtues. So that's terrifying. Anyways, they started— I won't get this exactly right, but I get the gist of it.

5.17 They started out, I think they started out by rounding up Jewish men who were of military age and shipping them off to God only knows where, because they didn't really know where they were ending up at that point. But they ended up, step by step, taking naked pregnant women out into the fields and shooting them in the back of the head. And this wasn't a pleasant initiation experience for these men. Most of them developed alcoholism. They were traumatized like mad for doing this.

5.18 But one bloody step at a time, they went along with it until they turned into the absolute worst murderers. And you can be sure that, at some point, some of them started to enjoy it. And then you think, well, what does that have to do with you? And that's a good question. What it has to do with you is that, if you were there, that's probably what you would have done. You think, no, because everyone, you talk to them about this. You talk

to people about this, about Nazi Germany, and they always think they're Oskar Schindler. They're the people who would have hid the Jews in the attic.

5.19 It's like, yeah, I don't think so. I don't think so. That was pretty damn rare behavior. If you look at the avidity with which everyone went along with the totalitarian restrictions around Covid, how many people positively enjoyed that? That put paid to any simple notion that we've learned something from what happened 80 years ago. And I would say too, and this is something I learned from Jung, is that, if you are really concerned about the fact that such things happen, and you should be, because they might happen

again, and at any moment, you should take whatever steps are necessary to ensure that you wouldn't be a participant.

5.20 And the first thing you have to do is to understand that you probably would be. And since that's the case, there might be some alterations that have to be made to your character that are pretty damn deep. And so, one of the things you do to that is, well, in which handbasket would you ride to go to which particular hell? And what are you doing to increase that probability? And that's a very good thing to meditate on.

5.21 That's also part of the incorporation of the shadow from the Jungian perspective. You can find out some interesting things about yourself, too, because if you're more horrible than you think, which is highly probable, you also might be a more difficult creature to contend with than you might think. Lots of times, people don't really know how to stand up for themselves.

5.22 And this is also part of getting Satan behind you, so to speak, is that if you can get that part of your personality that might make itself manifest in vengefulness and resentment, if you can integrate that and use it as something like what the charismatic power of anger at your fingertips, that makes you very difficult to stop because you'll be facing people who put out a hand to stop you, and often that'll stop people cold. But if you have that demented and bent spirit organized properly in front of you, that's not going to slow you down a bit.

5.23 And that's part of the utility of actually being dangerous. And you're not going to be dangerous till you know you can be. And if you know you can be, well, then you can integrate that. And then you're formidable instead of dangerous, and that's a kind of dangerousness too, but also understanding that can make you treat yourself with a bit more respect. And that respect isn't exactly, let's say, self-esteem. It's more like the respect you might have for a stick of dynamite. Be careful because you don't know what you're capable of.

5.24 So, walk carefully, and don't be thinking that your minor league foolishnesses are, what would you say? Trivial. They're not trivial. What did Dostoevsky say? Solzhenitsyn said, "One man who stops lying can bring down a totalitarian state." So then, if you happened to inhabit a totalitarian state—maybe that's the job you hate—you might ask yourself, just how much lying are you doing to contribute to that? And if everything around you is

turning into a totalitarian state, you might ask yourself the same question. Because maybe if you were a little straighter, things around you wouldn't be quite so crooked.

5.25 And really, I do believe that that is the case and that is the responsibility that rests on every person's shoulders. We wouldn't believe that we are sovereign citizens with intrinsic worth if we weren't charged with that responsibility. And I don't really understand how everyone can be charged with that responsibility, but I do understand that in a totalitarian state, everyone lies about everything all the time. And so then you have to ask yourself, if you refuse to participate, just exactly how much would that shake things up?

5.26 And Solzhenitsyn's conclusion was, well, they'll probably kill you. And maybe that's because you started telling the truth a little late. But I don't know, maybe it's better to risk death than to live in hell. It's something to think about, that's for sure. So this has to do with seriousness, is that one of the things that can make you serious is to really contemplate just how bent and twisted you could become if you allowed yourself to revel in that, let's say.

5.27 I'll give you another example of that. In the story of Cain and Abel, Cain and Abel is a story of sacrifice. It's the story that's placed at the beginning of human history. You could think about it as a story that lays out two broad patterns of adaptation. There's that pattern of Abel, and Abel makes the proper sacrifices. What does that mean? Well, it means something like, he makes the sacrifices that are pleasing to God. OK, so what does that mean? Well, what does it mean to make the proper sacrifices? You know this.

5.28 You know perfectly well when you're giving your all to an enterprise and when you're not. And you know perfectly well that the probability that you'll succeed is proportionate to the amount of commitment you have to the enterprise. Maybe you're like 60% in. You're mucking about and you're trying to get away with things, and you're a little late to work and you don't do as much of a job as you could and you slough off and, well, you're not going to be that successful and you know that.

5.29 And you probably call yourself out on that, and maybe you've hidden that so much in lies that you've forgotten that you should. And you're all cynical about capitalism so that you can be useless with a good conscience. But you know, and you know this, and you know too that, when you look back at your life and you're pleased with what you've

done—genuinely, you'll be pleased because you really put yourself into something. And the consequence of that was that something positive emerged as a consequence. And maybe that's some sort of internal transformation or some sort of material gain or some sort of social gain, like a genuine one.

5.30 And those are the things that put you firmly on your feet. And Abel is a representation of the pattern of proper sacrifice. And Cain, he makes second-rate sacrifices, and that story doesn't really say why. And I think the reason for that is, you have your own reasons for making second-rate sacrifices, and so do you, and the reasons aren't going to be the same. So you don't want to specify that too tightly; you want to leave it loose. It's like, I don't know why you're failing voluntarily. That's in your domain to determine. But the probability that it's the case is very high.

5.31 And why might you do that? The answer has something to do with pride. I mean, when a child attempts to pull the wool over the eyes of his father, he does that because he assumes that his father's too blind and stupid to notice. And that's a form of arrogance. And there's an even deeper arrogance that's associated with it, which is that you're acting out the belief that you can bend and twist the fabric of reality to benefit you unfairly and that there will be no consequences to that.

5.32 That's not a wise decision. Who the hell do you think you are? You really think you can twist what's real and not have it snap back and take you out? That's not a wise conclusion to draw from your experience. Now it's complicated because sometimes you can do that for a short period of time, and it works. And sometimes you can do it for a short-term period of time and it works. And when it snaps back, you can be so blind that you don't draw the connection.

5.33 One of the things you do in therapy is quite painful—and you do this with deep conversations too—if someone's life has taken a vicious turn, you unwind it back to the origin point of that turn, and you generally find that someone made a decision that they knew was an inappropriate decision and that put them on the wrong path. They had their reasons for it. And then they forget, because you don't remember why the hell you did something five years ago. It might take a lot of digging to recreate that state of mind and to remember the decision. But the probability that you knew it was a bad idea when you embarked on it is extremely high.

5.34 That's a painful part of self-realization, because you also have to then come to terms with the fact that, if you took an inappropriate turn five years ago, you've now spent five years erecting the wrong Tower of Babel. That's a good way of thinking about it. All right, so, you sit for 15 minutes and you develop a little vision of just exactly how dismal your bloody life could be if you kept doing all the stupid things you're doing and you did them better. And that's useful. You want to do it to the point where you think, "Yeah, I don't think I'm going to go there."

5.35 And so, then when you're tempted, you see, then in the future, when you're tempted to take a step in that direction, you can conjure up that fantasy and you can think, "Yeah, nah, maybe not, maybe not." And maybe fear isn't enough. And it probably isn't. And it's not the best weapon to use, even though, say, against your proclivity for your worst excesses. And that's why you also need a counter-vision. You need, you need a vision of heaven.

5.36 How would you develop that? Well, it's the same approach about asking and seeking and knocking. It's like, OK, here's the deal. And this is something, you can just do this. It's a useful practice. You can do it for the day or the week or the month, or for five years. Think, "OK, I'm going to give myself the benefit of the doubt, even though maybe I don't deserve it," and that's a hard thing. It's like the presumption of innocence in law. You're going to make the assumption that it would be OK, hypothetically, if things worked out for you.

5.37 Now that's hard, because people bear an existential burden of guilt, and there's always part of us that thinks that we deserve to be punished. And there's often some reality to that, but flawed as you are, you might still be worthy. This is the conclusion Job comes to, by the way, when he's tormented. There's two things—he doesn't lose the thread. Two threads.

5.38 One, he maintains faith in his own value despite the fact that he's suffering dreadfully. And his friends come along and say, "You're probably suffering because you're bad, because you're unworthy, because you're sinful, because you've done stupid things." And Job says, "Well, I probably have done stupid things like people do, but that doesn't mean that my suffering invalidates my own merit." And that's a very tricky thing to get

right. Because if you're down on the ground and things are rough in your life at the moment, it's going to be a temptation to take yourself out.

5.39 Well, and I mean, sometimes literally, people will commit suicide to assume that you're such a dismal creature that it would be better if you didn't exist and maybe that you never had. And so you can understand how you might get to that point. And Job refuses to walk down that road, even though everything he ends up with, like this terrible disfiguring skin disease, and he loses everything he spent his whole life gaining. And his wife is so desperate that she tells him to "shake his fist at God and die," which is pretty rough advice.

5.40 And then his friends come along and tell him how horrible he is and why he deserves everything that's happened to him. So it's pretty damn rough. But one of the things that he insists upon is that, despite the tragedy of his life, he has intrinsic merit. And the story is more powerful, too, because we have God's testimony at the beginning of the story that Job is, in fact, a good man. He's not just making this up. He's not justifying himself falsely.

5.41 And part of that story is an investigation into the fact that you will be punished for the things that you've done wrong. You can be certain of that. But you'll also be punished, period. So you might say, despite your innocence, sometimes even because of your innocence, and you're going to have to contend with that, too. And if you lose faith in yourself because of that, well, then you're going to suffer, and you're going to suffer because you've lost faith in yourself. That's not helpful. And it's rough because it's going to be hard for you to have faith in yourself at your lowest moments.

5.42 And the other thing that happens is Job refuses to lose faith in existence itself, in being and becoming, in God. He says, "Despite the fact that all of this misery has been dumped upon me in a manner that seems unjust, I'm not going to draw the nihilistic and cynical conclusion that life is meaningless and evil." And you can think about that practically, too, as well as theologically or metaphysically. Imagine you're struck with cancer and then you get bitter and cynical and hopeless and depressed. And now you're aggressive and you alienate everyone and you're shaking your fist at the sky.

5.43 You might think, well, you have your reasons, and you do. But then, what's the consequence? And the consequence is, maybe you've got 10 months left, buddy. How

are you going to spend them? Are you going to open another hell up underneath the hell you're already in? Are you going to do what's so insanely difficult and look to what you have to be grateful for, even in those circumstances? Now, that's a hell of a thing to ask of people, but what's the alternative?

5.44 So that's all to say, maybe you can give yourself the benefit of the doubt. That's the presumption of innocence. And think, look, maybe I wouldn't be violating some cosmic dictum if I set myself up in life so that things turned out well for me, like they might turn out for someone I was caring for. And that's a useful thing to conceptualize. We tend to think of people as selfish. And some people are selfish and narcissistic and self-centered. But a lot of people have the reverse problem.

5.45 At least half the people have the reverse problem, which is, they value other people more than they value themselves. They'll give other people a break and give them the benefit of the doubt when they won't do that to themselves at all. And so one of the things you can do to rectify your relationship with yourself, if you're like that, is to think about someone you actually care for—a sister, brother, child, parent, or friend, someone you actually care for, and then see if you can see yourself through that lens.

5.46 And think, well, if I was counseling—I had lots of clients like this, especially agreeable women. They'd say, "Well, I can really advocate on behalf of someone else." And agreeable people can do that because mothers who are agreeable can really advocate for their children, and they'll do that pretty disagreeably, but they do that because they're

advocating for someone else. It's like, well, you don't know who the hell you are. And if someone else has value, then you have value. And so you need to learn how to advocate for yourself.

5.47 Not in this narcissistic manner, but in the manner that ascribes to you the same worth that you would ascribe to someone else that you care for. And it's the same attitude that you might want to have to someone that you just meet. You might—this is actually what makes society work, by the way, this attitude, is that, well, I'll assume that we could walk uphill together. I'm going to make that assumption, and instead of meeting you with distrust, and maybe I would have reason for that because I've been betrayed and people are full of snakes, and I could face you with hostility and distrust, and you probably deserve it to some degree.

5.48 But what's the appropriate attitude? The appropriate attitude is, and this is courage, not naivety, is like, no, I'm going to assume that you're going to enter this relationship in goodwill. And what's so interesting about that is, if you're extremely sophisticated at doing that, you radically increase the probability that that's how the person will respond. And this has been simulated, by the way, in repeated interactions. And one of the things that have been learned by these simulations is, I should confront you as a potential ally, and then if you cheat, I should whack you proportionately, and then I should treat you like a potential ally again.

5.49 If you run competitions between different ways that agents can interact with each other, there's no strategy that beats that one. And that's a strategy, not of naivety, because naivety says, "Yeah, you're a great person, I can trust you." And then cynicism says, "No, like everyone else, you're full of snakes." And there's some wisdom in that. But courage says, "Yeah, I know you're full of snakes, and me too, but if we had some sense, we'd organize ourselves so that we're going to walk uphill together." And then that increases the probability radically that that's what'll happen.

5.50 That's faith, right? It's faith that that's a possibility. You can't derive it from the facts because the facts could be, well, you've been screwed by most of the people in your life. The fact might be that that's the most probable outcome. It's not the right a priori assumption. Imagine a puppy that growls when you lean down to pet it. Well, it's not going to get petted very often. Now and then, it might get a kick. And then it's going to think, "Well, all I get is ignored and kicked. It's no wonder I growl." It's like, yeah, but you're growling, so what do you expect?

5.51 And then the puppy that runs up with tail wagging is going to run across the odd psychopath who's going to kick it just because it's happy. But most of the time, what's going to happen is that the recipient will think, "Wow, isn't that a delightful little puppy?" and give it a stroke. That's kind of a childish analogy, but you get the point. And so part of what you wonder is, how do you present yourself? So the opportunity for instantaneous collaboration makes itself manifest in the imagination of your partner, even the person you don't know, as rapidly as possible.

5.52 That's very important, too, because first impressions matter. They set the frame. One of the things you can practice, this is a religious practice, is adopting that attitude of

courageous trust. And that's something like loving your neighbor or even loving your enemy. It's a very difficult thing to master. And you might think it's naive. It's naive if you—it's naive if you think there's no danger. It's not a virtue, then. It's not naive at all if you know what the danger is. Then it's courage, and it's the courage that keeps the world turning, that's for sure.

5.53 And you can apply that dictum to yourself, too. Flawed as you are, full of snakes as you are, still, maybe it's OK that you treat yourself like you have some worth. OK, so imagine you managed to put yourself in that head. God, I was working often with clients who'd been bullied terribly by, like, sophisticated psychopaths at work. And the sophisticated psychopaths, they're just a dreadful plague in a workplace because they'll take something.

5.54 Maybe they want to steal what you have—your book of clients—and they'll find something you did that was, a little iffy, maybe when you were not in your best state of mind, or when you're in a crisis; and they'll blow that up into evidence of your insanity and unworthiness for the position. They'll gossip about that everywhere and try to take you out, while they convince you that you're insane, so that their theft of what you have is justified. Jesus.

5.55 And you'll run into someone like that who's been practicing it for 30 years, and they're way better at doing it than you are at defending yourself. And so I often had people like that in my practice, and one of the things I had to do with them was teach them how to make a case for their own sanity and innocence. Maybe it's not even true, because you're kind of insane and you're not that innocent. But you could at least have the argument at hand. If you had to stand up for yourself when pushed, how would you do it? How would you justify yourself?

5.56 That's worth thinking through, too. What is it about you that's worthy, if you're giving yourself the benefit of the doubt? The reason I'm trying to bang this home is because, in order to develop the proper vision for your life, you have to give yourself the benefit of the doubt. And given all the trouble that people are and bring to bear on situations, especially if you've had real rough experiences in the past and betrayed yourself and so forth, it's a very hard thing to do.

5.57 But if you do it, then you can think, OK, well, five years down the road, if I could have what I wanted and needed, if I was treating myself properly, what would that look like? OK, so what is that question? It's something like this. There's a lot of suffering in the world and in your life, and there's a lot of malevolence in the world and in your life, and hypothetically, there might be something of sufficient value to stave that off and to justify it.

5.58 And what I mean by justify it is when you're looking back in your life, maybe you accomplished something that was very difficult, but you managed it, and you look back and you think the struggle was worth it. OK, so I would say that's sort of like the core of meaning. The core of meaning is something like, meaning is what justifies the struggle. OK, so now you have to ask yourself. You're going to struggle in your life a lot. You're going to die. And maybe in not such a lovely fashion. Maybe you have some control over that, maybe not.

5.59 What would justify it? That's a hell of a question because it's a hell of a cross to bear that. And so maybe you need something pretty remarkable to justify that. You might think, well, what justify—what could possibly justify that? Your children are vulnerable. You bring them into the world. You love them; you're happy that they exist. The love seems to be the justification for their existence. It's something like that. That's why you grieve for people when they leave. You grieve because you presume, all things considered, that despite the catastrophe of their life, their existence had an intrinsic worth.

5.60 That's really what it means to love, and so you can aim that at yourself. You think, OK, well, how would my life have to play itself out so that I would be able to bear up underneath its weight without becoming resentful and bitter and wandering down the wrong pathway? And that's a serious question to ask yourself because you might need something real. And then you have to figure out what real means. What—and you can do that by consulting yourself to some degree, because you can ask yourself, like, in the times that you were struggling in your life, what did you have at hand that guided you through?

5.61 I was just talking to a gentleman this week who was going to shoot up a high school when he was a kid. He's about 40 now, and he had his reasons, that's for sure, man.

That kid had one brutal life, and he explained in detail how he got to the conclusion that he drew, and what pulled him out of the abyss. He pretty much severed all his ties with everyone, and he had made himself into the least attractive person he could possibly conceive, trying to justify what he had now planned to do.

5.62 And he came to the conclusion that he was going to do this. He was living by himself in a field when he was, like, 15, filthy, hurt. He went to a mental health clinic in a fit of desperation, and they told him that there was nothing they could do for him. And he had reasons not to go to a mental health clinic because he'd been in the hands of social workers before, and that wasn't particularly pleasant. And so it really took him a lot to go ask for help. And then he was turned away and, apart, on top of everything else that had happened to him, that was just too much.

5.63 And that's when he started to formulate this plan. But he had a friend, he said this over and over—I'm going to put this on YouTube, by the way, this discussion—he said over and over that this friend, he had an actual friend, like this guy cared for him. They had deep intellectual and philosophical discussions. And even though he also had a very brutalized childhood, he was very artistic and interested in literature and the arts, and he immersed himself in the world of literary fantasy. And that's what he had to bolster himself against the psychopathic cataclysm of his life.

5.64 Because his mother was like a violent cocaine-abusing serial addict who was married twice, both to the first guy was a violent ex-Vietnam vet who'd been brutalized in Vietnam and who had a hair-trigger temper and was always pounding on them. And the second husband who promised to rescue her from the first husband was a narcissistic repeated conman criminal who was just as violent. So that was this kid's home life. That's just a fraction of it.

5.65 And he had his creative ability at hand to use as a buffer. A temperamental advantage, you might say. He was smart. And he was able to find beauty in the literary arts. And that's one thing that you have at hand if you happen to be high in openness, and then he had this friend who stuck by him, and the friend essentially was what saved him. Because when he was at his lowest point, his friend called another friend and they organized a spontaneous birthday party for him. And he went over there and didn't expect it. And he had this birthday party among people he hardly even knew.

5.66 And he said that shifted him back into the human camp. Anyways, it's a hell of an interview, so you can take a look at that. But the reason I'm bringing it up is because you can look back in your life and the times you were suffering and you can think, OK, something buoyed me up then. I found solace or strength in something. What? And you can see there's a pattern to this. Sometimes it's what people are interested in, sometimes it's their duty. Often it's their responsibility to other people. Often it's the relationships that they have with other people, friendships or familial relationships, that buoy them up.

5.67 But you have to figure that out for yourself. You can find what's meaningful to you, not least by what buoys you up when things are rough. And so you can imagine that and you can think, well, how much of that do you need? I was very ill for a long period of time and in a lot of pain. And part of what got me through that, a huge part of it, was that I had solid relationships with my family and my friends.

5.68 If you're in very dire straits and you also have chasms in your interpersonal relationships, that's going to be pretty damn brutal because there may come a time when things are so hard on you that if things that could have been there to buttress you aren't, then you're done. So anyways, but you can figure this out for yourself. Some things are going to beckon to you, like the burning bush in the pits of despair. And you think, well, those are the things you need. And then you can think, well, how do I have more of that in my life?

5.69 Maybe that's too abstract still, like, what could your life be in five years if it could be what it should be, if you got what you wanted and you needed? That's still a pretty vague question, and I had clients and students who really couldn't answer that. They didn't know where to look even. They were so detached from themselves, let's say. And so one of the things I talked about yesterday is that if you're having a hard time with a broad-scale conceptualization, you're having a hard time confronting everything at once, you can narrow your problem till you get a problem that's narrow enough, so that you can start to make progress.

5.70 So let's differentiate this vision a bit, so we'll leave the hell side of things alone, on the presumption that you've already imagined how things could go terribly for you and you've decided that maybe you don't want to go there. You might also think through, too,

what would be attractive about going there? One of the things people do in their lives, they toy with drugs and alcohol and, let's say, sexual impropriety, affairs and that sort of thing, because there's some real adventure to be had in flirting with disaster and breaking the rules.

5.71 People are like that. We like to break the rules and skirt around the edges and have a bit of an adventure. And some people more than others. And so here's another possibility, which is that if you're not doing something exciting enough in your own life, demanding enough, challenging enough, to satisfy that part of you that would like to cause trouble, then you're probably not taking enough risk in your vision. Your vision shouldn't be one of just security. I don't know how much danger you want. Maybe a lot. Maybe mostly you're built for trouble. Highly probable.

5.72 So in the story of Abraham, Abraham, he's the father of nations. The Abrahamic faiths are Judaism, Christianity, and Islam. And so, Abraham, at the beginning of the story, he has everything anyone could want if what they wanted was satisfaction and satiation. He's like an overgrown infant. He has rich parents. All he has to do is lay in his tent, and people will feed him, and there's slave girls around, and it's like incel paradise, you might think. Anyways, and he does that till he's like 70.

5.73 And then a voice comes to him and it announces itself as the voice of the ancestral spirits. The voice of the god of his forefathers. And it says, "Leave your zone of comfort and go out into the world." And that's an interesting thing because in some ways he has everything that an infant could desire. Comfort. But then the question is begged. Is that what you want? Do you want comfort? And the answer to that is, well, how much trouble do you cause? Because if the answer isn't zero, then probably you don't just want comfort, you want some trouble.

5.74 And then you might think, well, where's the proper form of trouble? And the answer to that might be, why don't you try to do something difficult with yourself? That'll cause all sorts of trouble. Try telling difficult truths. That'll produce an adventure in short order. And then, one of the things you might ask yourself is, is your proclivity to cause stupid trouble proportionate to the fact that you're not seeking hard enough in the positive direction? Because maybe if the goal you set for yourself was sufficiently demanding and rewarding, you wouldn't be enticed by false adventures.

- 5.75 I think that wild partying and general licentiousness, that sort of troublemaking, I think that's false adventure. It's a hell of a lot better than just laying in your couch, on your couch, being depressed and alone, but being out in the world drinking too much and snorting cocaine and causing trouble, it seems like an adventurous activity, but it's a substitute for something that's real.
- 5.76 And we know this because one of the things that reliably cures alcoholism is religious transformation. And that's known by secular investigators. It's a very well-known psychiatric fact. And what seems to be the case is that if you're addicted to something like alcohol, you can get rid of the addiction by just not drinking for two weeks. You might have to do that in hospital because the withdrawal can kill you. But after two weeks, you're no longer physiologically dependent. Now, you'll still crave if you go back to your old environment, and you'll probably relapse, but you're no longer dependent. So that can be fixed pretty quickly.
- 5.77 The reliable cure for alcohol addiction is that people find something better to do. Alcohol is a spirit. It's a Dionysian spirit. It's 40% spirit, if it's whiskey. Well, and it is that because it transforms your personality. There's a reason for that, and it's a false spirit. It's the Dionysian spirit. And if you want to escape from possession by the Dionysian spirit, you need a better spirit. That's essentially what it boils down to. If you're attracted by alcohol, it can be a pretty good false adventure, just like most of the drugs that attract people are pretty good false adventures, but they're a substitute for the real thing.
- 5.78 And maybe you need quite a vicious substitute, you know, because you're a lot of trouble. And so maybe you should dare something great, and that'll keep you on your toes. And then this is essentially what happens to Abraham, because he follows this voice and it takes him out in the world, and all hell breaks loose for him. He encounters totalitarianism, and like, the Egyptian aristocrats conspire to steal his wife, and he encounters famine and war, and the entire catastrophe of existence sort of writ large.
- 5.79 But the conclusion of the story is that that's better. And that's interesting because you got to ask yourself. The world is a very complicated and dangerous place, but it's also full of strange opportunity. That's the dragon with the treasure. There's the bigger the dragon, the bigger the treasure, but also the bigger the treasure, the bigger the dragon.

And you might think, well, maybe we just want treasures without the dragon. And maybe not, because maybe you want to confront the dragon, so you grow.

5.80 And maybe that's the spirit of adventure. And certainly when you think about the sort of movies you might go see while you're fantasizing with everyone else in the audience, they're often— what's the perfect movie? How about a romantic adventure? That's the perfect movie. If it's a date night, you go to a romance. If it's, if your wife is willing, you go see an action flick. If you can—I know those are stereotypes, but they'll do the trick. But maybe you can get that exactly right, and you have an action, a romantic adventure. Well, maybe that's what your life could be.

5.81 And maybe that would satisfy you. And if it doesn't, then maybe you have to increase the intensity of the romantic adventure until you think, geez, that might be worth, that might be worth it. Worth what? Well, how about worth the ultimate sacrifice? Because that's what you're going to be called upon to make anyways. And that's also a freeing thing in a weird way because people won't take a risk. Well, you're going to lose everything you have anyways, and you're going to lose even more if you won't take a risk.

5.82 So, once you know that you're going to lose everything you have anyways, well, then why not take a risk? And then you might say, a risk on what? And I would say, well, how about a risk on what's worthwhile? And why wouldn't you risk that? Because taking a risk on what's worthwhile, that's not a risk. Not taking a risk on what's worthwhile, that's a risk. OK, so back to practicalities.

5.83 So I called this slide dimensions of identity. In our culture we have a war about identity going on right now. And the insistence is, that's causing the war, is that I get to define my identity however I want, whenever I want, and I get to do that in a way that everyone else has to abide by, or else, no matter what. And so there's a metaphysical claim underneath that that's twofold. One is that I get to define myself, and the other is that the "I" that's defining myself is equivalent to my desires, to my localized desires, which is why most of the identities that people are claiming are like sexual identities.

5.84 So I see. It's your sexual desire, that's you, and in its free expression, that's where you find the most integral part of yourself, and everyone else is supposed to play along with that. So that's your claim? You're reducible to your instantaneous sexual needs, and

everyone else has to abide by that. That's not a game that other people are going to play. And it's not a game that, if you play, is going to work out for you. It's a very, very immature game.

5.85 It's the game that 2-year-olds who can't play games play, because a 2-year-old says, "I want what I want right now, or else." And you dispense with that by the time you're three because you have to play with other people. And what that means is, you negotiate your damn identity all the time. You're married. "It's about me." Well, good luck

with your wife with that attitude. If she has any sense, she's going to trip you down the stairs at every possible opportunity. You're negotiating your identity if you're married all the time, and thank God, because you're not everything you could be.

5.86 And maybe you're updating yourself a bit by having this tussle with your beneficial adversary, just like you do when you play against someone who's well matched for you. You give up your self-proclaimed identity for a negotiated identity. And the negotiated identity is a social identity. You're not who you say you are. Maybe you're a husband. Maybe you're a father, maybe you're a brother, maybe you're an uncle. Those are all parts of you and maybe the most integral parts, but they're negotiated social identities.

5.87 They're not in your head; they're acted out in the world and that scales. There's you, and you and your wife, and you and your wife and your family, and you and your wife and your family and your neighborhood, and your town, and your state, and your country. And then so the dictum goes, it's one nation under God. You're related in your identity to every one of those levels.

5.88 And that means that your mental health—mental, which it isn't—mental health is actually the harmony that you establish between all those different levels of identity. And you might also hypothesize, and this is a useful hypothesis, that the more burden you take on in relationship to all those possible social identities, the more robust your identity and the more meaning there is in your life. And that's another example of the idea of the relationship between meaning and voluntary sacrifice. When you get married, you sacrifice.

5.89 Well, what's the sacrifice? Well, it's not about you anymore, not that it ever was. And even if it was, you weren't going to be successful at that, because you're going to annoy other people to death if it's always about you. But when you get married, well, it's also

not about your wife, it's about the marriage. And so the marriage becomes paramount, and the two individuals are subordinate to that paramount unity, and both of you should serve that unity, whatever it is. And you do that by communicating, and then that's part of your identity.

5.90 If you establish a harmonious relationship with your wife, then your household is relatively sane, and you can go home and not be driven out of your mind. And so, I don't care how organized you are intrapsychically; you should get that somewhat under control by the time you're about three. But without extending that capacity for union to other people, you're not sane. You can't play your own solipsistic game. That's the literal definition of immature narcissism.

5.91 "If you're going to play with me, you're only going to play the game that I insist upon." A child who says that has zero friends. It's the first thing children do when they check each other out, is, "Can you take turns?" "Do I get to pick a game now and then, like half the time? Or even better, do you engage with me in a way so that we both get to pick the game we're playing?" It's elementary socialization.

5.92 There's a fairly large percentage of people who don't pick that up by the time they're four, and they're done for. They're the career criminals. They're the outcasts who are outcast at four, and permanently. They never learn to play with others. What you see with people like that, the career criminal types, is, if you keep them in prison till they're about 30, by that time they generally mature enough so they're not an active danger. But the maturation takes that extra 10 years. So, anyways.

6. A Higher Vision

6.1 You're going to play with others. And hopefully, if you do it right, it's going to be a game. And if you do it extremely right, it's going to be a voluntary game. And so, let's see, if you don't know what you need and want for yourself, let's see what the range of games is that people generally play. Because you might say, well, if you don't know where to find meaning in your life, why don't you look at tradition, so to speak? Or the social community, what other people do that seems to work?

- 6.2 I figured this out because, when I was doing a clinical interview with my clients, I would try, especially if they were depressed—there's two reasons you might be depressed. They're very different, these reasons. One reason is that you're depressed. You have an immunological problem. There's something wrong with you physiologically. Your positive emotion system is shut off, and your negative emotion system is heightened. There could be all sorts of causes for that, and it could take forever to figure that out. Maybe antidepressants would help you if you're one of the responders.
- 6.3 I would be able to tell if you're depressed because I could say, "Well, do you have an intimate relationship?" "Yes." "Do you have a family?" "Yes." "Do you get along with your wife and your kids?" "Yeah." "Are they meaningful to you?" "Yes." "Do you have friends?" "Yes." "Do you have a job? Are you pursuing something on the educational landscape to keep yourself going? Do you make good use of your time outside of work? Do you have any terrible habits that might spiral you into the ground?"
- 6.4 You can do a multi-dimensional assessment of someone's life and see if they have a life. If they don't have a life, well, they're going to be miserable, but they're not depressed. They just don't have a life, which is a much more serious problem. And so you think, well, to have a life, what do you need? Well, there's seven things that you need or eight things that you need. And maybe you don't need all of them. But the probability that you need none of them is zero.
- 6.5 And I would also say, if you're miserable, barring a physical cause for that, and you don't have any of these things, and you're so cynical, you think, "Well, none of that's for me," one of the things we could start with is your presupposition that, what? You're that different from every other human being that ever lived? You're so wise that you can be cynical about all the games that other people are playing? You're really going to tell me that despite the fact that you don't have an intimate relationship, you're one of those people who doesn't need one or want one?
- 6.6 Maybe. Maybe you're the kind of guy who needs to be alone out in the bush with your cat. Who the hell knows? But probably not. You'll end up writing screeds to newspapers about how the whole military-industrial complex needs to be brought to its knees. It's not a good pathway. Probably you want someone around. If it isn't a mate, it's at least a

friend. So you can go through it. And then you can do this when you're developing your vision.

6.7 OK, so here's the next deal. It's five years down the road. You have an intimate relationship. It's what you would want. What does it look like? That can actually be a relatively entertaining fantasy. OK, I get to have the relationship of my dreams within some reasonable parameters. You're probably not going to get seven Hollywood actresses in your trailer. So, we can dispense with delusional stupidity, but it wouldn't work anyways, because could you imagine having seven Hollywood actresses in the same trailer? God, that'd just be hell.

6.8 I saw a show a long time ago. It was Hugh Hefner, and he was going around Europe with these blonde bimbos. It was a TV show, and they had some of their conversation, and I thought, "Oh, my god. Hugh Hefner is in Hugh Hefner hell. He's 75 years old, and he's hanging around with four dim-witted bottled blondes who can't share a word between them having the same inane conversation in different high-end hotels across Europe." Oh my god. Be careful what you hope for.

6.9 Yeah, we'll dispense with the delusional stupidity and think, OK, well, within some reasonable parameters, if you could have the relationship you wanted and could offer, which is an even more important question, what would that look like? Who would you have to be to make the offer to that person that you would want? Then you have to think, well, imagine you conjure up some man you'd respect. Now, then you have to think, well, if he's a man that you'd respect, he's going to go after the right sort of woman, because otherwise he wouldn't be a man—whatever woman that is. Otherwise, he wouldn't be a man that you would respect and want.

6.10 Then you might think, well, then you need to be the woman that would be attractive to a person like that. That's probably a better place to put your fantasies, is if you want a perfect relationship, fair enough. What do you have to offer? I got this question on the road all the time. How do I find the person that's right for me? Well, A, why do you think you will find that? What, under a rock somewhere? It's like, "Oh, that's where you've been hiding all my life."

6.11 And right for you? Really, there's some person out there whose whole goal was to be right for you? And then you might think, well, would you even want someone that was

right for the sort of thing that you are at the moment? Possibly not. And even if it was the right person, and they were really the right person, how do you know they wouldn't take one look at you and run in the other direction? The whole question is just absurd. And I couldn't answer it. And I got asked it three times in a row in different cities. I thought, "I can't answer this damn question."

6.12 I thought, "Oh, it's because it's a stupid question." The right question is, "How can I be the person that would attract the person that I would want to be with?" There's a question you could start working on. You got to conjure up this person that you'd want to be with, and then you have to think, well, what would they want? Well, then, now you've got a goal. I would say, too, look, it isn't certain that if you do that, Prince Charming will show up on your doorstep, but it's virtually certain that if you don't, he won't. It's still your best bloody bet.

6.13 I have interactions with these so-called incels online from time to time, and they're all cynical about women, because women have taste, and that's very annoying to them. And so they think, "Well, I've been trying to put myself together and it isn't working." Possibly, maybe you're unlucky or maybe there's something about you that's so off-putting—I'm not saying this meanly—that it's really hard for you to overcome it. You're cursed by that. But it's a much higher probability that if all the women are rejecting you, there's either something rotten about women per se, which is highly improbable, or there's something wrong with you; you'd better go with that.

6.14 Because if it's the women, you're doomed from the get-go. And if it's you, you could probably do something about it. And you should just assume it's you to begin with anyways, because it probably is. But that doesn't mean that if you did put yourself together, that it would necessarily magically appear. But yeah, it probably would. When I speak with men, that's especially true as they get older. I don't mean, say, from 20 to 30, because a man who's potentially functional at 19 still might not be attractive to women. But a man who's 27, who's got himself together in a real way, the probability that he'll be able to find a mate, if he at least let people know that he has his act together, it's pretty damn high.

6.15 So, what do you want from an intimate relationship? And I would make that detailed because you can imagine the romantic situation. You can imagine whether you want

kids, and if you want kids, how many? And if you want kids, when? And what are the kids going to be like? What relationship are you going to have with them? How do you want your partner to be a father or mother? That's playing house in your imagination. It's like daydreamings. What the hell is it that would satisfy a creature like you?

6.16 There's a certain darkness to that, too, if you're smart about it, because if you're a combative person, maybe you want a woman who's a bit of a bitch, so you can have a fight now and then. Because you need—you want to have some provocation and some tension in the relationship. You don't want someone who's just a doormat, and that's going to depend a lot on your temperament because some people like—they're more scrappy than other people. If you're a scrappy, disagreeable person, you probably want someone who could stand up to you and give you a good slap now and then just so you stay respectful.

6.17 The same thing applies on the sexual front. Men, naive men tend to divide women into two camps. There's sort of the untouchable virgin mother and the whore. They get married, and now they have the untouchable virgin mother. The problem with that is, there's no sexual satisfaction in the relationship. So then they stray. The reason that's happened is they've turned their new partner into frigid perfect, right from the get-go. And then they're not satisfied, but they don't want to, what would you say, bring impurity into their relationship. And so then they end up searching outside.

6.18 Well, so one of the things you do with your fantasies is, be honest. What the hell do you want? And that would mean, what's going to satisfy you? And who knows what you need to be satisfied? You might even be ashamed to admit it, and you probably should be. But it's possible that if you're careful and smart and a bit seductive and wise, you not only could get what you wanted to and need, but maybe your partner would be more than happy to play along, because she might have some darkness of her own that could be brought into the relationship in an interesting way.

6.19 That might make you not so interested in Pornhub. That's worth thinking through, too. That's part of that integration of the shadow as well. There's a certain amount of courage that goes along with that, too, because you have to reveal who you are. That might be a shock to you and a shock to your partner, but it might be an exciting shock, both to you and your partner. That's worth thinking about. The probability that it'll stay on

the healthy side, let's say, of daring, is in keeping with the degree to which you can make those desires honestly manifest, instead of repressing them down into the nasty Freudian unconscious, where they take their weird twists and turns.

6.20 OK, intimate relationship, family. You might think, well, I don't want kids. You should think that through. I mean, first of all, what do you think you're going to do from the time you're 50 till the time you're 90? Especially if you happen to be alone. People who don't want kids are usually thinking they're going to be 25 for the next 75 years. "Well, I don't want it to have my freedom impinged upon." Well, freedom for what exactly? To backpack through Europe and find all the little cute bodegas? Fair enough. Maybe you need to do that for six months. Well, but you're not going to be doing that when you're 75 and alone.

6.21 And so part of the reason people have children is because we live quite a long life. And maybe you don't want to be a parent, but maybe you want to be a grandparent. And that's worth thinking about. And you also might want to think, too, is, are you so sure? Here's what a child offers you. This is very cool. Well, first of all, the innocence of childhood, which is a wonderful thing. But your child will be the only person in your whole life who wants nothing more, from the time they're born, than to have the best possible relationship they could have with you. Man, you're a fool if you don't take that seriously. What a deal that is.

6.22 And if you're careful, you could have that. And that's what that person wants, and you'll never meet anyone else in your life who offers you that. So maybe you could have four people like that. And you come home, they're so goddamn thrilled to see you that they can hardly stand it. That'll keep the, what, suicidal thoughts of melancholy at bay. That might be necessary for you. And that's a privilege. And if you can't see it, you're going sacrifice that to some hedonistic freedom, you're really not thinking very hard. You're not treating yourself well. So that's family.

6.23 Friends. It's like, well, what sort of friends do you want? And I have some rules of thumb for that. You can tell good news to your friends, and they're happy for you. And the same thing with family members. You tell a family member good news and they substitute something great that happened to them or put you down in some way. It's time to go find someone else to talk to, I would say. The same thing on the friendship

front. Your friends should be able to join you in your triumphs, because they might be few and far between, and maybe you can return the favor to them.

6.24 If that doesn't characterize your friendships, well, then you want to ask yourself. Are you so sure those are friends? And then a friend is also someone you can tell bad news to. They also won't trump it with some misery of their own. And they'll try to sustain you through the bad times instead of secretly being happy that the more successful you is finally being brought to your knees. And so it's the same thing with your family members. And can you share your joys and your sorrows? You want friends around who

are aiming up with you and who you can go on adventures with, in that regard.

6.25 And you need to learn—it's very hard for agreeable people—that you do not have to martyr yourself to redeem people who aren't interested in being redeemed. And maybe the best thing you can do for someone like that is say, "Look, you are going to have to dwell in your misery for quite a long time before you wake up. And I think I'll just go do my thing until you're a little more clear-headed." And you might think, that's pretty damn cruel. I don't know. I don't know if it's that cruel to confront someone with what's actually there. It might be a lot more cruel to pretend that everything's OK forever and enable their foolishness. I don't think you're morally required to do that.

6.26 And that doesn't mean you shouldn't help someone who needs help who will accept it. That's not the same thing. But it's very worthwhile to surround yourself with people who are aiming up like you. Well, you can consult your own. Maybe you need a project. Maybe you need a friend who's wobbly to bolster up. And fair enough, because it is helpful to help people, but you should be doing it consciously, and you got to ask yourself, too, what is it? Don't cast pearls before swine. You cannot help people who don't want to be helped.

6.27 That's the first cardinal rule of clinical endeavor. It was established by Carl Rogers. The person has to come to therapy deciding they would rather be better. I had court-mandated clients now and then, once, I think. I only did it once. The person was forced to come by court. It was just a complete bloody charade. He was a psychopathic child molester, which didn't help. He was there to act out the lie because he didn't think there was anything wrong with him. He thought he was a hell of a guy, and that's pretty much all he ever told me in the therapy sessions.

- 6.28 There is no getting him to decide he needed help, partly because I think if he would have ever had to confront who he was, the shock would have killed him. So seriously, there are places you can go and be blind, that if you ever looked at, you just— he was a grandfather who molested two of his under-five grandchildren. OK, now you wake up one day and you see who you are. You think you're going to live through that? I don't think so. Not much of you, that's for sure.
- 6.29 So it's the same with your friends. If they're aiming down hard, I don't know. And you say something three times and there's no listening, and you just hear the same story over and over and over and over, you think, "Yeah, maybe it's time to look elsewhere." What else? What do you need to do at work? You got to pull your weight at work. Well, what justifies the sacrifices you're going to make it work? Maybe you just have an ordinary job, because most people have somewhat ordinary jobs, let's say. I don't know.
- 6.30 You work at a parts department, an auto parts store, let's say. It's not a James Bond career, but you have your coworkers and you could establish relationships with them. I worked in a lot of restaurants. I had a lot of low-end jobs from the time I was 14 till I was about 25 or so. I probably had 30 different jobs as I moved around, something like that. There are no simple jobs. I worked as a busboy and a dishwasher. Those are pretty low-end entry jobs at a restaurant. But you have to get along with the waitresses. I was only a kid, so I had to learn how to act like an adult, to work like an adult. That was real interesting.
- 6.31 I got along with the cooks. They taught me how to cook. That was helpful. I learned how to clean up a kitchen and take care of one. And so when I left home, I knew how to do that. It wasn't a simple job. There are no dishwashing robots. It's a complicated job. And if you just have a job, well, you have the people around you, and they're complex and interesting, and you could do a stellar job at your job. And then all of a sudden, it wouldn't be mundane. And if you're doing a stellar job at your job and it's still mundane and you're not getting anywhere, then it's time to find a new job.
- 6.32 And maybe you work at some small business, like a small restaurant, and you are the best waiter or waitress that there ever was. You make everybody who comes in there unbelievably welcome, and you go the extra mile, and that bloody place just thrives. Then maybe you're on your way to success because you've learned how to deal with

people and you've learned how to communicate. I don't think there are trivial jobs. I don't believe that.

6.33 Now, there are dead-end jobs, and that happens when you're somewhere where the person who's ruling over you is a tyrant, and you're not getting rewarded for doing a good job. And then, well, you go look somewhere else, and that can happen. But there's rarely you find yourself in a situation where the person you're dealing with is only a tyrant and where there's no possibility around the fringes to do much more in your job than you think might be there.

6.34 I worked with this guy named Scotty Kyle when I was about 14, and Scotty was this ex-alcoholic, and he had all his teeth knocked out in fights. He was like 35. He looked about 50. He was a rough guy, but he'd straightened himself out. And he was absolutely hilarious, and he was really fun to work with. And the waitresses really liked him because he was always playing tricks and telling jokes. And I really liked going to work. He was a challenging guy. Great wit, good storyteller. He made the place jump, and it got to be very popular in this little town. It was a place everybody hung out after the bar closed, which was a little on the dark side, often.

6.35 But he made a real difference, and he treated me like an adult, which was really great when I was 14. I really appreciated that. I don't think there are trivial jobs. You hire a plumber. It's easy for educated people to be dismissive of tradesmen, which I think is really stupid. If you're a good plumber, that's a hard job. You can be a bad plumber, and you do not want a bad plumber in your house. All hell will break loose if you have a bad plumber.

6.36 If you're a plumber, well, maybe you're successful enough so you hire a couple of people and you can help them straighten out their lives, and you treat your customers well, and then they tell everybody in the neighborhood, because everyone's always looking for good tradesmen. If you're that person who can keep your books and you can do your job and you treat your customers properly and you're honest and you do the job on time and you charge a reasonable amount, or even a premium, but you do an excellent job, you're going to be so goddamn successful in no time flat that you won't know what to do.

- 6.37 People get all cynical, and they say, "No way." Try it for a year and see what happens. I've literally had thousands of people now come up to me and say, "Well, I tried that for a year and everything around me changed." They're usually pretty damn thrilled to tell that story. So this isn't some naive wish. This is how the world works if you're operating properly in it. And it's hard to find people in an entry-level job who will do a stellar job.
- 6.38 If you are that person, you won't be in an entry-level job for long, because the sensible people around you, they'll think, "Oh, man, I don't know what it is with that kid, but there's something to him. Maybe we should provide him with some more responsibility because he's already been looking around to see where he could pick up some extra responsibility." And that's an accelerating curve very rapidly, especially in a country like the United States, because I've traveled a lot all over the world. And one thing that's really cool about your country is that, I don't know how you managed it, but this is the country in the world where success is admired more than any other country.
- 6.39 You see that a bit in other Western countries, but not nearly as much here. And that's especially pervasive among the working class. People here are—that American dream thing. That's real. You're smart enough to value people who are successful in their local enterprises and to want that and to not be resentful and bitter about it. There's some of that, but much less here than anywhere else by a lot. That's why it's so damn rich here. Canada, now, we make 60% on average as much as the US, as Americans, and that's about the same in Europe, too. Yeah, so good work, Americans.
- 6.40 All right, so outside of your family and your job, what do you do with your time? Do you have any artistic interests? Maybe not. Maybe you're not an open person, so the artistic and intellectual side of things doesn't attract you. But maybe you need to care for someone because you're agreeable, or maybe you need, I don't know, you need to do something political because you're conscientious and dutiful and patriotic. Maybe you should join a political party or some local community club and see what you can do on that side of things.
- 6.41 Do you have a plan for what you do with your time outside of work? That's not leisure time, right? That's you. That's your life insofar as it isn't your work. You might want to have, not a plan exactly, because that sounds like something you're imposing on yourself, but a vision. I don't know what you could learn to do in the next four years. I

mean, maybe you could sing or maybe you could play the piano or maybe you'd learn how to shoot a handgun or wrestle or you'd be better at basketball. There's a lot of things you can do.

6.42 That's especially true now that you can learn virtually anything online in no time flat. Why don't you make a plan and think about three or four things you could learn over the next five years? Then maybe you'd be more interesting at a party, and you'd be more likely to attract the mate you want to attract or keep the one you have. That's worth thinking about. You can do that by thinking about what beckons to you. If you could master something that you might dream about.

6.43 I watch these videos on YouTube, these woodturners, these guys that make or they refinish old furniture or something like that. It's really fun to watch people on YouTube who are very skilled at making something beautiful or restoring something. You'll find—maybe you want to learn how to program. There's a useful skill. You can learn that in 10 weeks at a boot camp, and then you'd know how to program. Maybe you need to take a communications course or a public speaking course or who knows? Maybe you're really skilled in your trade, but you can't communicate with people. Well, why don't you fix that? Because if you are skilled and you could communicate, man, you'd be unstoppable.

6.44 And so, then how are you going to take care of yourself? Psychologically and physically, that's worth a bit of a plan, too. And maybe you need to go to the gym, and you only go once a week. And then maybe that's a good start. And you need to know why, because otherwise you won't go. That's why you have your little vision of hell, and you're starting to flesh out the rest of the vision because you think, well, maybe I should be in decent physical shape so I can undertake things I want to do, so I maintain a certain level of attractiveness. And maybe because you have a developed vision, you'll actually stick to your damn plan, because you think it's worthwhile and that the payoff will suffice. That's worth thinking about.

6.45 Temptation. Well, people often have, we talked about this already, people often have a flaw, too. Maybe you like cocaine, maybe you smoke pot every day, maybe you take a drink far too often. If you're drunk once a week, you're hungover for three days. Takes three days to recover from alcohol withdrawal. If you drink twice a week, you're

hangover all the time. That interferes with your cognitive ability and it increases your negative emotion. Because alcohol withdrawal, it destabilizes the system that runs on the neurotransmitter GABA, and that's the neurotransmitter that mediates anxiety.

6.46 So if you're drinking even a glass of wine twice a week, you're much more neurotic than you would otherwise be. Now, when you have the alcohol, that'll calm you down, but you'll pay for that for three days afterwards. It also disrupts your sleep. Maybe you like wine and you think, OK, that's a risk I'm willing to take. Fair enough. But my point is that in the realm of temptation, you might want to have a strategy.

6.47 I stopped drinking when I was about 27, and I quit for 23 years. Then I started again, then I quit about a year later again because I was just as stupid when I was 50 as I was when I was 27, as it turned out. It was a very annoying thing to realize. The reason I stopped was because the only time I was doing things that I regretted was when I was drinking. Then it was also interfering with other things that I was doing that were difficult to do, that I couldn't do if I wasn't in tip-top shape.

6.48 You need a strategy at some point. Do you want to waste your time in this hedonistic pursuit when it's clearly interfering with things that you need to do that are actually important? I think if the things are important and you want to do them, you'll be motivated to stop because, well, what's the payoff? If you're clearly hurting yourself and you're stopping yourself from doing the things you actually really want to do, then you're perfectly motivated to start putting some constraints on your temptations.

6.49 If you can't control your temptations, what you're aiming at is probably not good enough, because you want that as an excuse. That doesn't mean they won't burst through now and then. Then you think, well, a slip. I'll get back on track tomorrow. Then on the social front, we talked about marriage, and we talked about family, friendship, and community. One of the things that's worth understanding, I would say, on the community front is how much service should you be to the broader community? Say, political clubs, religious organizations, political parties, religious organizations, service clubs.

6.50 I think the answer is something like this: there's a certain degree of civic responsibility that everyone has to bear, or someone else will do it. The people who will do it, if you abdicate the responsibility, are generally people who want power. What that means is, if you abdicate your civic responsibility, the power-mad tyrants will take up what you leave

on the table and they'll use it against you. That's a vision of subsidiary social organization. Every bit of necessary social responsibility you leave on the table will be taken up by a king-like figure who will be a tyrant.

6.51 It also means to the degree that you abdicate your broader social responsibility, also be a slave. You have to take on the—this is also a great opportunity. Some people don't understand, too, especially young people. If you go to a religious organization or a community organization or a political party, and you're willing to put in the time and you're reliable, you will have opportunities open up to you so fast, it'll just make your head spin.

6.52 I met a couple young women in Europe, one in Belgium, I believe, the other in Holland, who got involved in political parties when they were very young and started to do the work. They have political careers already, and they're 24. You think, well, that can't happen to you. It's like, that would happen to you a lot faster than you'd think, because political parties, for example, they're starving for people all the time. And a lot of the people that are there, they're not doing a good job.

6.53 If you go there and you're even vaguely sensible and reliable, you show up, you knock on the door, you prove your worth with the entry-level jobs to begin with, man, you'll end up terrified because you'll think, "How the hell did someone who knows as little as me get the opportunity to do the things I'm doing?" The answer is, "That's how the world works." Part of the reason that things are not as good as they might be is because there aren't enough people.

6.54 I knew this, when the Democrats took power, they couldn't find enough competent people to fill all the positions. They knew that. So they filled a lot of federal positions with seriously incompetent people, in case you haven't noticed. But you can't really be cynical about that because it's like, well, where were all the useful people? It's complicated because sometimes the people who could be useful are just cynical, and sometimes they don't know that they're wanted. But one of the things that's even more perverse is often the useful people are already off doing useful things.

6.55 One of the things that also means, that even if you are a useful person and you've fleshed out your life quite well, you still might have to bear some of the burden or accept some of the opportunity that goes along with civic responsibility. Because if all the useful

people are just involved in doing their own local useful things, well, who's going to sit on the school board, for example, or run for city council? You can learn an awful lot by doing that, by getting involved in those organizations.

6.56 That's also a place where you can find additional meaning and companionship and skill development. It's a good thing to learn how to speak publicly. It's a good thing to sharpen your political arguments. It's a good thing to understand a little bit about how a city might run and what's involved in maintaining the infrastructure and so forth. OK, so that's a much broader sense of identity. Now, while you're developing a vision, said, well, you can have a vision of how things might go catastrophically, and you can have a vision of how things might work out for you, if they could work out for you as well as possible, then you could differentiate that.

6.57 And the differentiations, well, there's other ways of differentiating your life, but these, what is it? 10 things, 9 things, they're not a bad first-pass approximation. You could break it up in a different way, but it's not a bad start. And then you could imagine that you were making incremental improvement at the rate you deemed optimally engaging on every one of those axis. OK, so then let's make this even more concrete. Let's talk about schedules.

6.58 If you're starting your educational career, let's say you've joined Peterson Academy, for example, or maybe you're off to university, or maybe you have a new job, it's not a bad idea making a schedule. Now, people don't like schedules, generally. People, especially creative people, especially creative, unconscientious people, because they tend to, I don't know, they think that freedom comes as a consequence of the avoidance of responsibility, and they think that plans do nothing but interfere with your creative flowering.

6.59 None of that's even the least bit true. It's based on a misapprehension of what a schedule should be. Because a schedule should be an invitation. We talked about this a little bit yesterday. So you could imagine that you could try this just as an exercise, is that, when you wake up in the morning, you have the day laid out in front of you. Say, "Sufficient unto the day are the troubles thereof." So what does that mean? It means something like, the day is not a bad unit of, what would you say, singular apprehension, something like that. You need a vision for the day.

6.60 And so you might ask yourself, what is it that confronts you when you wake up in the morning? You open your eyes and think, "Well, what I see is the bedroom." Not exactly. You don't really have to look at the bedroom. Your mind is going to be wondering about. You're not that interested in the bedroom because you know what's in there. So you sort of see it, but that isn't what presents itself to you. And maybe you wake up worried, or maybe you wake up excited, or maybe you wake up bored. But what you really wake up to is the opportunities that the day presents.

6.61 That's what confronts you, is the day is an unformed realm of bounded possibility. It's one day long and it's parameterized by the walls that you've erected around yourself. And so it offers you an opportunity, and it calls to you with your conscience. If you wake up worried, it might be that something's bothering you that you should take care of. One of the things Friedrich Nietzsche did, by the way, is when he first woke up, he'd try to figure out what unpleasant thing was morally required of him to do that day to keep the ledger straight, and then he'd do that first.

6.62 That's actually a pretty good mental hygiene practice. Probably there's something you should do tomorrow. There's probably something that you'd rather not do; that you have to do or it will get worse, that you could do, that you would do. We can start with that. This is partly why I recommend it to people. This is a very trivial thing. Well, you can make your bed first thing in the morning. It's actually an interesting ritual because really what you're doing, you're really doing this, by the way, let's see here, that.

6.63 That's the eternal story of the human spirit. You confront something that's disorderly, chaotic, and threatening. That's what a dragon is. It's the eternal predator that lurks in the darkness, and you free something of value as a consequence. You're always doing that. That's the activity of consciousness. The thing you're confronting might be just your bed, your little chaotic bed that you just slept in, and you put a little order into it. It's a symbolic ritual. It's the first thing you do on waking. Your consciousness is the sun that's fought through the darkness at night and reemerged triumphant in the morning, and triumphant because you're not dead, are you?

6.64 You just took a journey through the realm of unconsciousness itself, and now you've arrived back on the landscape. The first thing you can do in the light of day is to put a little order in the place of the chaos. That might be enough just to get you going,

especially if you don't know what else to do. It's why these ritualized habits can be so useful. I have a new place about three hours north of Toronto, and it was in very good order when we bought it, and they left virtually everything there for us, but it's still not exactly mine. I didn't know what was in the garage, for example. It was full of tools and so forth.

6.65 What I did when I first started to live there, and I've tried to do pretty much every day, is when I get up, I go into the garage, or some other room, and I spend 10 minutes putting something in order. That gives me a chance to clear my head a little bit. The cumulative consequences of that across time, if you do that, if you spend 10 minutes every day putting something in order, in a year, everything in your house will be in absolutely perfect order. Then that's really good because then you can wake up in the morning, maybe you're not cluttered up in your imagination by a bunch of undone tasks, and then you can take on something that's more difficult.

6.66 The day presents you with opportunities of that sort. There are things you can put into order. In Genesis—this is very much worth knowing— so Genesis makes the claim that the world is brought into being out of chaos and potential by the action of the Word. That's the doctrine. And the Word is something like the— that's St. George mounted on horseback. If you're investigating something chaotic and you're telling the truth, you're using the Word to extract order out of a chaotic domain. If you're doing that honestly, then that's a manifestation of something that's divine, by definition. That's the part of you that's made in the image of God.

6.67 That's the thing that constantly renews the world. That's the proposition. There's another proposition in that story. The proposition is that, if you confront chaos, aiming up, and truthfully, the order you produce will be the order that's good. You either believe that and act it out or you don't. Those are your options. There's no third option. You're going to either act that out or you are going to act out the contrary. So you act it out, predicated on the idea that if you attend to something and set it right properly, that that will work. Maybe also that that's what you should do, whatever that means.

6.68 You're going to stake your life on that proposition, one way or another. You're either going to do that well or you're not going to do it at all or you're going to do it badly. Those are your options. The injunction, the deepest religious injunction in our society is

that you should do that without reservation all the time, and that that's how things are set in order, not just you, but everything. There's another element to that, too, which is that if things aren't set in order, that's your fault. And that's a weird thing to think.

6.69 That's that Dostoevskian claim that you're not only responsible for everything that you do and that happens to you, but that you're responsible for everything that everyone else does and everything that happens to them, too. And that's a pretty weird thing to think. And it's kind of insane, but it was Dostoevsky, and he was a genius, like a world-transforming genius. And you don't know how much better the world would be if you were everything you could be.

6.70 And you don't know how much worse the world will be if you're not everything you could be. You have no idea how much that rests on you. And I'm afraid it's a lot more than you think, especially if it's true. There's this scene in the story of Abraham where God is going to destroy Sodom and Gomorrah, these cities that have deviated from the straight and narrow path. And Abraham doesn't think this is a very good idea because he tells God, "Look, maybe there's some innocent people in those cities." And God thinks, "Yeah, I don't think so. Have you looked?"

6.71 And Abraham says, "Well, if I can go there and find 40 people who are good people, aiming up, following the right pathway, telling the truth, will you leave the city alone?" And God says, "I don't think you're going to find 40, but OK, if you do, I'll leave the city be." And then Abraham, who's a rather stubborn person, says, "Well, 30?" God says, "Yeah, OK. You're pushing it, but 30." And I think he bargains him down to something like 10.

6.72 And you think, what does that mean? I think this is true. If your society has corrupted, but it's still uncorrupt enough so there are 10 people who are willing to say what's true, there's hope. And you could be one of those 10 people. There'll be situations where it's actually incumbent upon you to be one of those 10 people. Maybe you have to speak up at work, or maybe you see an injustice being committed somewhere, and everyone's watching it. You know it's wrong, and it's like, "Hey, it's your turn to say something." And if you don't and no one does, then the whole bloody, tragic farce plays itself out.

6.73 And there'll be lots of situations in your life where you know you have something to say. And you think, "Well, I don't have to." It's like, fair enough, but you knew you had

something to say, and that means the consequences, they're on you. And if you're ever wondering how societies degenerate into Nazi Germany or the Soviet Union, the answer is pretty simple. It's that when ordinary people are called upon by their conscience to say something, they don't. And then, with each step backwards, the probability that the next step will be backwards increases, and more and more people get tangled up, until everyone is lying about absolutely everything to everyone all of the time.

6.74 I just read this book by Theodore Dalrymple, called *The Wilder Fringes of Marxism*, something like that. He went to Pyongyang, North Korea, the capital, 15 years ago, and he went to this department store. It's such a dreadful story. North Korea is one starving, rat-infested hellhole of a tyrannical state. They have a department store in Pyongyang, even though there's no consumer infrastructure whatsoever. Everyone is required to be self-sufficient in North Korea, but all trade and commerce is illegal.

6.75 That's fun. You have to do everything you can do yourself, so you don't die, but everything you would do to survive is illegal. That sounds like great fun. Anyways, despite that, they have a department store because even though the communists have transcended the petty wants of the capitalist world, they have to demonstrate that they can provide the plentiful supplies that the capitalists manage. So they have this department store with escalators in it, a couple of stories high, hundreds of people milling around full of these items, but none of them are real.

6.76 And so Theodore Dalrymple went in there. He saw these plastic bowls sitting on shelves, all of the same type. It's like a simulacrum of a department store. Then it's full of these North Koreans. And so Dalrymple, who's a bit of a troublemaker and a brilliant essayist, decided to just follow one of these people around, because they didn't actually seem to be buying anything. And so he followed one of them around, and this person would just go up the escalator, around the store, down the escalator, and then up the escalator again and around.

6.77 That was their job. They were to go there and act like a customer eight hours a day or else, and they were going to look happy doing it despite the fact that there was nothing to buy. And so Dalrymple decided he would poke a bit, which is a very dangerous thing to do in North Korea, and he wanted to buy a pen. So he went up to a shelf where there

were, hypothetically, pens. And so a crowd gathered around to watch him buy a pen because no one buys a pen in this department store, because it's not a department store, it's just a huge lie.

6.78 Then he got his pen, and it's in this box with the worst-quality cardboard you could possibly imagine, printed in a way that looks like a Western product, except the ink is saturated into the terrible cardboard and the box barely holds together. He took out the pen, which couldn't write, and the little clip broke off as soon as he maneuvered it, and the eraser didn't work because it wasn't a pen. It was just a lie that looked like a pen. That was the whole department store.

6.79 And that was the whole country full of false products, every one of which was a lie, being not purchased by people who weren't consumers but had to act like it or else. And so that's how far the lie can go. So that absolutely every single thing is a lie, and that's hell. And so, how do you stay out of there? Don't lie. And you think, "Well, I can get away with it." It's like, yeah, I don't think so. Are you going to have faith in the lie or are you going to have faith in the truth? And if you're going to have faith in the truth, then you can consult yourself about the truth.

6.80 What are the preconditions for your joyous existence? Seriously, and that's a hard question because life is brutal. It's rife with malevolence. And for you to be satisfied, pleased, enthused? That means to be filled with the spirit of God, by the way; that's what enthusiastic means. What's your price? What do you need for that? I would say you need something like a glorious adventure. You don't need satiation, satisfaction. That's not going to work for you, anyway. You'll just break that to bits the first opportunity you have in a bit of spiteful privileged resentment.

6.81 You need a challenge. You need a challenge that's big enough to satisfy you. And that's going to be some major challenge because you're not that easy to satisfy. And maybe that's actually a reflection, in some deep way, of who you actually are, all that stubborn inability to be satisfied. Maybe it's because you're actually longing for something great. And maybe with a truthful conversation with yourself, you could develop the vision that would enable you to discover what that is. And then you could pursue that. And then God only knows what would happen.

6.82 What God offers Abraham is the opportunity to be the father of nations, to establish a pattern of adaptation so successful that it cascades down the generations. That could be you. And maybe you're a stay-at-home housewife, and all you do is take care of your kids, but you really take care of them. God only knows what they might become. And they're the beginning of an unbroken line of people who propagate into the future. You have no idea what that dedicated concentration on that local environment might bring about when you see it, let's say, across generations.

6.83 You do something well, what do you do? You tilt the world towards heaven when you do something well. And then you got to ask yourself, too, what would the world be like if everyone did that? We're very bitter often because the world is such a harsh place. But it's harsh, at least in part because we don't do what we could. And you might say, well, you could break yourself in half trying to put things together, and they wouldn't still be together. And that's brutal. But God, they'd be better than they would have been otherwise.

6.84 You could certainly make a mess of things if you really set out to do nothing other than that. And so, you do your part, and you're going to encourage other people to do their part. And if we all did that— part of the reason that we have societies of abundance at all is because, and I think, again, your country is a stellar example of this, is that lots of people are doing their part.

6.85 And most of the time, when you call a plumber to your house, they fix the plumbing and they don't steal what you've got when they're there and they're not dangerous and you pay their bill and they're happy about it, and they don't bring their psychopathic relatives over at 4:00 in the morning to steal everything that they found in your house, which is run-of-the-mill in many, many countries, and for much of human history. It's a bloody miracle that you can trust strangers to help you. It's amazing that we ever managed to produce something like that, and we have, and perhaps we could even do better at it.

6.86 I would say the place to start doing better at that is with you and with your vision. Really, I learned this from Jung, mostly, because I read a lot. Carl Jung spent more time trying to figure out what went wrong in Nazi Germany than anyone else I ever read, deeply. He was obsessed by it. He worked for the CIA, too, by the way, and reported on Hitler for months and months during the Second World War, analyzing Hitler's state of mind

and, what would you say, informing the American Secret Service, the CIA, on how they might conceptualize their information campaigns and so forth and understand what was happening in Germany.

6.87 Jung's belief was that—he was a psychologist—that the totalitarian state was basically a psychological debacle, is that it's the adoption of the lie by everyone, and that the way that you break out of that, the same way that Alexander Solzhenitsyn proclaimed, or Viktor Frankl, for that matter, Václav Havel in Czechoslovakia, you resist the tyrant by resisting that in the confines of your own life. And that's enough because you face the reality of tyranny in your own life. You will face that in its micro form, maybe as a consequence of your actions, or maybe because you're subject to that. It doesn't matter.

6.88 You're going to face the problem of slavery. You're going to face the problem of how you get to the promised land and what that is. It is the case that you shape the manner the world makes itself manifest by the choices that you make. It's also the case that that echoes more broadly than you think. You know that because you can cause an awful lot of trouble, and everyone knows that. Then it begs the question, if that's the case, how much good could you do? You know you've done some.

6.89 Maybe you're only in it about 5%, because you're not wholly convinced that you should throw yourself into the fray. But then you could ask, well, if you really threw yourself into the fray, like wholeheartedly, just exactly what could you accomplish? And then one of the things that's so interesting about even positing that as a question is it immediately becomes extremely interesting. Well, what could I do if I really set my mind to it? How much of the world would open up to me?

6.90 And what's—there's another line in the gospel that you can move mountains with faith. It's a concretized metaphor, but we do move mountains, by the way. But I think you can move things that are a lot more immobile than mountains with faith. It has to be the faith that you act out. It's not faith isn't the belief in stupid, childish things. That's not faith. Faith is the willingness to put yourself on the line. It's what you do if you get married. Anybody who gets married does it in faith. It's like, what the hell do you know about your partner?

6.91 Maybe you fall in love with them and you're deluded enough to think that you know who they are, but they don't even know who they are. You sure don't. And so you step

forward thinking, "I'll take the risk." And you can make that work. It's a dance. It's a problem you have to solve along the way. You do that when you take a new job. You have to take a new job in faith. I mean, you don't do it stupidly. You try to set it up so that

your faith appears justified. But basically, what you're still proclaiming is that the possibility is that this unknown realm hold can be dealt with appropriately by me.

6.92 But you don't have any evidence for that. I mean, you can look at your past behavior. But if it's a new job and it's pushing you farther than you've been before, you don't have the data at hand that would suggest that you can be successful. You certainly don't have that when you start a new business. I mean, if you used actuarial data, which is what you do if you looked at the facts, you'd never start a new business, because the probability that you'll fail in the first year is more than 50%. So you'd just think, "No, I'm not doing that." Well, if everyone thought that, there wouldn't be any businesses.

6.93 So you have to put forward the notion that you're the creature on the horseback, and that if you find the right size dragon, which apparently this character has done, then not only can you be victorious and gain the requisite treasure, but you'll be prepared to fight a bigger dragon the next time one comes along. And there's no difference between that and having faith in your ability to learn and adapt. It's the same thing.

6.94 When therapists stumbled over the fact that voluntary exposure was curative in psychotherapy, all they did was rediscover the fact that people can learn. Because what you do when you learn—I bought my daughter when she was about three, a little play structure. It was like a swing set with a ladder up both sides and across the top. And it was about 10 feet high. It was big for her. And she was quite a careful child. And she went out there. We were watching her from the window and she was trying to figure out how to climb up the ladder.

6.95 She'd put her foot halfway up to the first rung and then three-quarters of the way up. Then she'd rest her foot on the first rung and then she'd put her weight on it, and then she'd do the same with the second foot, and then she was on the first rung. And then she did that, I think, the first day up to about the fifth rung, and that was good enough. But she was doing that in micro form. It was like, "Can I stand on one foot? Can I stand on one foot and hold this? Can I do that while I'm thinking about climbing to the top?"

She's climbing up Jacob's ladder, one little step at a time, and playing because that's what she was doing.

6.96 She was playing at the edge of her own ability and expanding that ability. We were watching, thinking, and that's not a good time when she's up to the fourth rung, to run out and say, "Oh, my God, dear, be careful, you might fall." And then hope with all your heart that she does fall so you can be the martyr that goes and rescues her. That's a really bad idea. You sit back and you think, "A little danger, but you're handling it well." And that's what you hope for your kids. And if you have any sense, that's what you hope for yourself.

6.97 And maybe it's not just a little danger, man. Maybe it's all the danger you can take. Then maybe you'd have a little respect for yourself when you looked at yourself in the mirror. You'd think, well, you justify your miserable existence by your bravery. And I think that's dead true. And so you want to find the right size thing to take on, right? And not minimize that, man. It's how you set the world straight. And one of the things Jung believed solidly was that the problems of the modern world will not be solved on the political side. It's not a political problem. It's become fundamentally a spiritual or psychological or spiritual problem.

6.98 The way those are solved is that people individually solve them. In your country, your country will stay free to the degree that you all act out the utility of freedom. If even a handful of you do that properly, that might be enough to keep the whole bloody game going. There will be times when you'll be one of those people, and there might be times where you could be one of those people almost all the time, and you could be bloody sure that that'll be more exciting than you could possibly imagine.

6.99 And maybe what you need for the adventure of your life is more exciting than you can possibly imagine. It could be, right? Because maybe that would be sufficient payment for your mortal vulnerability. It's so damn interesting, you can barely tolerate it. Well, there's a game you could play. It'd never exhaust itself. And one that expands continually. And it's a hell of a lot better than taking the wild trail down to the depths of the betrayal pit in hell, and dragging everyone else along with you.

6.100 All right. So we'll recapitulate with vision and plan, theory and practice. Well, what's the vision? How would you set the world straight optimally around yourself? You can

decompose that into its constituent elements. What sort of relationships do you want? How are you going to conduct yourself? You have to ask yourself, not force yourself, not tell yourself like you're a tyrannical father. Figure out who the hell you are. There's something you want, some things you won't even want to admit, some things you think you shouldn't want. They're worth sorting through.

6.101 Maybe your morality in relationship to yourself is too narrow. Maybe you're putting restrictors on yourself. You think, "I shouldn't be aggressive." It's like, I don't know. Maybe you should be 10 times as aggressive as you are, if it was channeled in the right direction. God only knows how you might transform what could be a vice into a virtue. These are things you have to discover about yourself, the conditions for your own satisfaction. And that's a meditative exercise.

6.102 You think, well, how could I make things go terribly wrong? And do I want that? And if not, how could I avoid it? And then, how could I make things go terribly right? What would terribly right look like, if I could have it? But actually, instead of as a juvenile dream. I had a client, he said he wanted to be retired when he was 50. He didn't do a very good job at work, by the way, because he was always dreaming about being retired. I said, "Well, what are you going to do when you retire?" And he said, "I see myself down in the Caribbean on the white sand with a mai tai in my hand."

6.103 And I thought, "Was that some travel poster you looked at when you were 13? Let's think that through." You're a 50-year-old white guy from Canada. You go down to the Caribbean, day one, you're out on the beach with a mai tai in the sun. You sit there all day, and what are you going to drink? Ten of those? So you're the stupid drunk tourist who's now so sunburned, he has to stay in his hotel room being hungover for the next week. And that's what you're going to do when you retire. That's your life.

6.104 Well, you don't want to have a vision like that. Have some sense. Flesh it out a bit and take yourself seriously, really seriously. You could be a force for terrible destruction because you are. And so you take yourself seriously because of that. You think, OK, what are my conditions for being a good person? What is it that I'm aiming at that would justify my existence so I could abandon my nihilism and my cynicism and my bitterness and my resentment, my hostility and my pride?

- 6.105 And you can find that out because, unless you're absolutely unreasonable, and you probably are to some degree, there'll be things that do satisfy you. There'll be times in your life where you think, "Yeah, God, if I could have more of that, that'd be just fine." And you can see in your life that, too. It says in one of the gospel tracts, "The Kingdom of God is spread upon the earth, but men do not see it." And you can see it, because you'll see times in your life where you're in the right place doing the right thing at the right time, and it just opens up.
- 6.106 And then it closes. It happens when you fall in love with someone. You could open that up so that was there all the time. And that'd be a hell of a thing to aim at. Maybe you could get expert at that. That'd be a good thing to get expert at. Then you wouldn't hide your light under a bushel. And you'd be walking uphill like you should be walking uphill. And you'd be, what would you say, an inspiration to the people around you. And maybe you'd want that more than anything else if you had any sense, and it's highly likely.
- 6.107 So it's worth thinking about and seeing what you can manage. You got 50 years to play with and see how much good you could do and maybe more than you could imagine. And maybe you'd think, God, that was worth it. Yeah. That'd be good. All right, good. Thank you.